

MODI'S 4-DAY TRIP TO CENTRAL ASIA



Prime Minister Narendra Modi shares a car ride with Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev in Tashkent, Saturday. ANI

Modi flags 'shared vision' in Tashkent: Trade and culture to energy, defence

Bilateral meeting with President Mirziyoyev today

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 29

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi's four-day trip to Central Asia began Saturday with a dinner meeting with Uzbekistan's President Shavkat Mirziyoyev in Tashkent as the two sides pledged to deepen cooperation in a sweeping range of areas — from trade and tourism to health, energy and defence — as part of a "shared vision".

Modi, who left Delhi Saturday morning, is on a two-day state visit to Uzbekistan after which he will be in Bishkek for the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) leaders' summit August 31-September 1. He was received at the air-

port by President Mirziyoyev. After landing, Modi said on X, "Landed in Tashkent to a warm welcome by President Shavkat Mirziyoyev. Grateful to him for the special gesture. This is my fourth visit to Uzbekistan, reflecting the depth and growing momentum of our bilateral relations."

Modi later visited the Yangi Uzbekistan Monument in Tashkent along with Mirziyoyev, and laid a wreath at the monument.

In his departure statement, Modi had said: "In recent years, India-Uzbekistan Strategic Partnership has seen significant advancement. I look forward to my discussions with President Mirziyoyev on further deepening our cooperation in trade and investment, digital connectivity, defence, energy, and on advancing our shared visions of Viksit Bharat and Yangi Uzbekistan."

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

● **AFTER THE RECENT** unrest, a civil rights group in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir has called for fresh protests over alleged security restrictions affecting education, healthcare and civilian movement.

TRACK THIS AND MORE ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

POLITICS PAGE 6



GOVT LIKELY TO NAME WINNER OF SARDAR PATEL AWARD THIS YEAR

In spotlight over governance, HDFC Bank CEO Jagdishan to step down

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 29

SASHIDHAR JAGDISHAN will step down as Managing Director and CEO of HDFC Bank, the country's largest private sector lender in October, bringing to an end a six-year tenure that included the institution's transformational merger with mortgage giant HDFC Ltd. The decision comes at a critical juncture for HDFC Bank, which



Sashidhar Jagdishan's term ends on October 26, 2026

is now preparing for a leadership transition even as questions around corporate govern-

INDIA SENDS TUNNEL RESCUE TEAM, FORENSIC EXPERTS, ADDITIONAL RELIEF MATERIAL

275 Indians still missing in Nepal, toll climbs to 675

MEA: 108 Indians rescued so far, 598 who were stranded on China side cross into Nepal, another 900 safe there

Shubhajit Roy & Divya A
New Delhi, August 29

AS SEARCH and rescue operations continued in Nepal for the fourth day on Saturday, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said 275 Indian nationals and another 128 people of Indian origin — mostly Kailash Mansarovar Yatra pilgrims — remained missing. On Friday, the MEA had said at least 320 Indians and over 100 people of Indian origin were missing.

The total death toll climbed to 675, with more bodies being recovered even as nearly 2,400 people were reported to be still missing after the devastating flash floods that wiped out parts of several districts in Nepal on Wednesday morning.

According to a statement by the Nepal Police, 675 bodies have been recovered so far, from across the eight districts that were affected. Over 4,400 people have been evacuated so far as rescue teams led by the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) raced against time amid on-and-off rainfall in the flood-affected regions.

MEA spokesperson Randhir

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Sonali Belosay (left), who was among the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra pilgrims stranded in Tibet, kisses her daughter Seeya after returning to Mumbai on Saturday. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

Houses buried in mud, fields, orchards destroyed: 'We have nothing left now'



DEVANSH MITTAL TASHI TOBGYAL
EXPRESS IN NEPAL

Nuwakot, August 29

UNTIL WEDNESDAY morning, '1 Number Pul' was a quiet, idyllic hamlet located in the valley area of Nepal's Nuwakot district, on the banks of the Bhotekoshi river. Today, the



At '1 Number Pul' area in Nuwakot district, Saturday. TASHI TOBGYAL

area, like many others in the region, lies submerged in mud and debris.

Only seven houses are left standing, and three of these are

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INSIDE PAGE 9



SAREE BECOMES LIFELINE FOR 21 TN PILGRIMS IN FLOOD ESCAPE

EYE Where every square has two answers

Nothing brings the mind to its knees as a good crossword. Meet those behind the toughest clues

BOOKS

In *Regime Change*, American journalists Maggie Haberman and Jonathan Swan look at what has shaped Trump's second term



DALITS DISCRIMINATED AGAINST: LoP

Kharge 'purification' row: Rahul calls for FIR, Dhami pushes back, says no BJP link

CM: Congress devoid of issues, no one in Uttarakhand knows Khargeji's caste; group was clearing litter, says MoS Tamta



LoP Rahul Gandhi in New Delhi, Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Asad Rehman, Lalmani Verma and Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, Lucknow, August 29

LEADER OF Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to order an FIR over a "shuddhikaran hawan" (purification) ceremony held at Ramliila Maidan in Haldwani in Uttarakhand, staged days after a rally there by Congress president and Dalit leader Mallikarjun Kharge. Calling the act a "crime," Gandhi said, at a press conference Saturday, that it illustrated the "untouchability" Dalits face across India and exposed the "BJP-RSS mindset."

His remarks drew a sharp response from Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Dhami,

who said the Congress was a "mudda viheen" (issue-less) party and that those who conducted the hawan were not BJP workers. According to Dhami, the ceremony was a religious organisation's protest against littering and against slogans raised by "people of a particular religion" at a ground used for staging Ramliila.

"Uttarakhand me koi nahi jaanta ki Kharge ji ki jaati kya hai" (Nobody in Uttarakhand knows what Kharge ji's caste is)," Dhami said, speaking to reporters in Haldwani. He added Kharge was a respected senior leader who had worked along side Atal Bihari Vajpayee and L K Advani. "How can Uttarakhand people insult anybody? Uttarakhand people have

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

UGC, QUOTA, CENSUS

Poll win on sprawling social base, BJP walks tightrope on caste

Vikas Pathak
New Delhi, August 29

LEADER OF the Opposition Rahul Gandhi's call for an FIR against the "purification" of the Ramliila ground in Haldwani after a rally by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge comes when the BJP and its government are having to engage protesters against reservation — walking the political tightrope on emerging caste divides.

The party is intent on addressing the concerns of its original "upper caste" voters, now that social media has amplified their voice too. At the same time, it is also deeply aware that its string of electoral successes have been built on support not just from this core base but from

multiple OBC and even Dalit and tribal groups where reservation is sacrosanct.

Even as Union minister JP Nadda and UP Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak cordially engaged anti-reservation agitators Harsh Dubey, Ran Bahadur Singh Chauhan and Mritunjay Pathak, ministers and senior leaders of the BJP and NDA from

reserved categories made it clear that reservation was inviolate.

Any demand for its removal is divisive, said Union Minister of State for Social Justice and Empowerment Ramdas Athawale. Speaking to *The Indian Express*, the RPI (Athawale) leader, an NDA ally of the BJP, said that he was open to each caste getting its share of

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● IN WANDHAMA, GANDERBAL, THE RUNDOWN STRUCTURES REMAIN FROZEN IN TIME SINCE THE MASSACRE IN 1998

In village where 23 Kashmir Pandits were killed, 4 homes a reminder of dark night

Bashaarat Masood
Wandhama (Ganderbal), August 29

ON A warm summer day two weeks ago, Abdul Gani met a man who looked familiar. The meeting was just off the Srinagar-Ladakh national highway, at the start of the 400-metre-long road that climbs gently into the village of Wandhama. As soon as he saw him, Gani asked the man where he was from — a customary first question in these parts when Kashmiri Pandits and Muslims meet.

The answer stunned him — Gani was meeting his old

neighbour Brij 'Batta' (Batta is a Kashmiri word for Pandit) from Wandhama in Kashmir's Ganderbal district.

"We hugged," says Gani. "Time had changed us — we had both grown old and grey. But somewhere in his face, I sensed something familiar."

For Gani, this reunion with a face from his own childhood was a throwback to a different time — a time before the dreadful events of January 25, 1998, etched themselves into the collective memory of Wandhama. On August 25, Jammu & Kashmir Police's State Investigation Agency opened an investigation into

that incident, when militants in Army fatigues entered the village and killed 23 Kashmiri Pandits in one of the deadliest attacks of that time.

The case is the latest in a series of probes that the SIA has opened into the killings of Kashmiri Pandits during the militancy. And although Brij had left the village for Jammu eight years before the Wandhama massacre, when many like him were having to leave the Valley as part of the larger Kashmiri Pandit exodus, the reunion with him brought back memories for Gani.

Nestled among tall Chinara and walnut trees, Wandhama is a village in central Kashmir's



One of the four rundown brick-and-stone houses belonging to Kashmiri Pandits, in Wandhama, Ganderbal. SHUAIB MASOODI

Ganderbal.

On the night of January 26, 1998, a group of militants

descended on the village, assembled the Kashmiri Pandits in one place and opened indis-

criminate fire. It led to the killing of 23 Kashmiri Pandits, including four children and nine women.

Today, much has changed. A new highway corridor that connects Srinagar and Ladakh has come up a few hundred metres from the village, and old brick-and-stone houses are giving way to larger concrete ones.

And yet, in the heart of the village, four rundown brick-and-stone houses belonging to the Pandits remain standing, frozen in time. Time and weather have torn away most of the structures, and dense green vegetation grows out of the windows and archways.

"We had seven Pandit

houses here, but now you can only see four. Locals bought three of the houses, and new houses came up in their place," says Mohammad Haneef Baba, a 65-year-old resident. "Nobody from the village has touched the other four, but how long will they stand the weather and time?"

As militancy peaked in 1990, several Kashmiri Pandits began leaving the Valley for Jammu. But the residents of the four households stayed put.

Then came the night of January 25, 1998.

Baba recalls that night and its horror. It was Ramadan, and most of the village's male residents were at the local mosque,

he says. "We heard a few shots but thought it was somewhere far away. It was January 26 (Republic Day), and we thought it was a celebratory fire," he says.

Then came the wails of some women.

"When we went outside (the mosque where people were praying), we heard the women pleading with us to leave for some safe place. They said there had been firing in the village," Baba says. "Some of the young men from the gathering mustered courage and ran towards the Pandit houses. They saw bodies scattered outside."

The massacre wiped out all four families that remained.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

HDFC

Despite persuasion, Jagdishan reiterated his decision to not seek reappointment,” the bank said. “The Board decided to fast-track the process for selection and appointment of his successor well within time,” it said.

The development marks the end of a leadership chapter that began in October 2020, when the Reserve Bank of India approved Jagdishan’s appointment to succeed Aditya Puri as MD and CEO. Jagdishan has been with HDFC Bank since 1996. He joined as a manager in the finance function, became the Chief Financial Officer in 2008 and played a key role in the bank’s financial and strategic functions.

What put the spotlight on the bank in March this year was the abrupt resignation of part-time chairman Atanu Chakraborty, who said certain happenings and “practices” within the bank were not in line with his “personal values and ethics”. The bank subsequently appointed external law firms to examine the concerns raised in his resignation letter. The law firms gave a clean chit to the bank. The RBI too had given a clean chit to the bank saying it did not find any governance concerns.

On May 27, *The Indian Express* reported that HDFC Bank’s Audit Committee had ordered an internal vigilance investigation into payments totalling Rs 45 crore made to the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation’s subsidiaries during FY2024 and FY2025. The payments were allegedly routed through the bank’s marketing department and presented as contributions to a road-safety campaign rather than as differ-

ential interest on deposits. The bank had denied the allegations relating to the reported payments.

But in July, the bank’s board concluded an internal disciplinary process relating to the MSRDC arrangement and issued warning letters and imposed a monetary penalty of Rs 1 lakh each on Jagdishan, Chief Financial Officer Srinivasan Vaidyanathan and Group Head of Retail Assets Arvind Vohra. The board characterised the conduct as “business overreach” rather than mala fide action, personal enrichment or improper motive, and decided that the matter should be communicated to the RBI.

Earlier in March this year, the bank had taken action against three executives, including Sampath Kumar, group head of branch banking, for their alleged involvement in mis-selling of Credit Suisse Additional Tier-1 bonds. The bank’s executives were accused of inflating income details of NRI clients to qualify them for AT-1 bond purchases, a product typically reserved for high-net-worth investors. The bank had in September 2025 informed the stock exchanges about an action taken by the Dubai Financial Services Authority barring its Dubai International Financial Centre branch from onboarding new clients.

Jagdishan’s departure puts the spotlight on HDFC Bank’s succession process. The bank had already appointed former CEC Rajiv Kumar as chairman in June. The choice of the next CEO will be closely watched by investors and regulators, particularly because HDFC Bank is still in the process of integrating the enormous HDFC Ltd franchise and recalibrating its balance sheet following the merger.

touched and that they are dirty.”

Echoing Dhami, Union Minister of State for Road Transport and Highways Ajay Tamta, himself a Dalit leader and Almora MP, rejected Gandhi’s allegations.

He told *The Indian Express* that religious sloganeering from “people of the minority community” had occurred during Kharge’s rally, and that the ground, which regularly hosts yajnas and pujas, does not belong to the BJP. The clean-up, he said, was ordered not by the government but by a religious organisation responding to littering at the event, a routine practice at Ram Lila grounds. “In Uttarakhanda, in Ram Lila, all characters are played by people of all religions,” Tamta added. “Rahulji, don’t try to malign Uttarakhanda like this.”

Gandhi reiterated that the Congress wants an FIR filed under the SC/ST Act against those responsible for the Haldwani ceremony. “The PM says he is for all castes, and his state president is saying the ‘purification’ was right,” he said.

Uttarakhand BJP president and Rajya Sabha MP Mahendra Bhatt had recently triggered a controversy after he defended the “purification” ceremony at Haldwani.

Asked about Kharge’s reported disappointment that some Congress leaders hadn’t openly condemned the incident, Gandhi clarified: “He didn’t say the vast majority of Congress people didn’t support him. I supported him. Several others did too.” He added that the issue extends beyond Kharge to every Dalit: “If the Congress president can face this openly, then imagine what happens in school with a four-year-old child.” On the silence from the PM and BSP chief Mayawati, Gandhi said he had “no interest” in it, adding: “Our interest is in illegality.”

Rahul

accepted everyone. Uttarakhand people always give priority to nationalism,” he said.

Gandhi’s attack comes as caste and reservations have become a flashpoint. The Congress had long demanded a caste census, which the Modi government eventually agreed to conduct; meanwhile, the UGC’s equity regulations — though stayed by the Supreme Court earlier this year — have stirred resentment among sections of the upper castes. Gandhi also recently took aim at the Manusmriti at an event in Pune, where he urged girl students to “smash patriarchy,” drawing counter-attacks from BJP leaders.

Seeking justice for Kharge, Gandhi framed the episode as part of a larger battle: “two ideologies fighting in the country, the Constitution of India and that of the BJP-RSS.” He argued that Dalits have endured violence for centuries despite constitutional protections, citing everyday humiliations. “In schools, Dalit children are made to clean toilets and sweep... Dalits are not allowed to drink water from wells. At tea stalls, there are two types of cups... During *baraats*, which should be a happy occasion, thousands of Dalits have to wear helmets when they climb the horse. This is the reality of UP, India and north India. You can see it in cities and villages,” the LoP said.

Drawing a parallel, Gandhi noted that a temple visited by Rajasthan LoP Tika Ram Jolly was similarly “purified,” as was a temple visited by NDA ally and former Bihar CM Jitan Ram Manjhi. “Who does this? It is BJP-RSS people,” he said. “We are calling it ‘purification,’ but this is untouchability... they are saying Dalits should not be

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

275 Indians missing in Nepal

Jaiswal said that 108 Indian nationals had been rescued so far. These included four who were rescued from a hydropower project in Rasuwa, Nepal’s border district which was among those worst hit. He said 598 Indian nationals, who were stranded on the Chinese side of the Sino-Nepal border, had also crossed into Nepal. Another 900 Indians are safe and are yet to depart China, the MEA said, adding that the Indian Embassy in Beijing was in touch with them, either directly or through the local government.

India on Saturday sent more relief material as well as specialised teams. In a post on X, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar said: “The 4th flight from India with 11 tonne assistance is now airborne. The C-130 aircraft is carrying a tunnel technical contingent along with equipment for search & rescue operations, a team of forensics experts for DNA analysis along with forensic equipment, relief supplies, including blankets, sleeping bags, tarpaulin, plastic sheets & hygiene kits.”

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

‘Nothing left now’

buried in mud right up to their second floor. The rice and maize fields are gone, as are the banana and apple orchards. Mangled banana plants lie on a rooftop, while the bare trunk and branches of a mango tree stand covered in mud.

The hamlet gets its name from a bridge that runs across the river — part of the Trishuli hydroelectric project in the area. The project, commissioned about six decades ago, was among the first jointly developed by India and Nepal.

The floodgates of the dams along the river, the bridge from which the hamlet derived its name, and the three-lane highway that led to the border district of Rasuwa are barely visible, all

“Additionally, 16 trucks carrying equipment for a 230-foot single lane modular steel bridge have reached Nepal. Equipment for installation of seven more Bailey bridges will be supplied soon. Technical teams for their installation are expected to reach shortly,” said Jaishankar, who spoke to Nepal’s Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal on Friday.

“So far, a total of 68.5 tonnes of relief material comprising essential medicines, portable generator sets, food packets, water purification tablets and technical equipment have been airlifted to Kathmandu. Our support to the relief & rescue efforts continues,” he said.

Earlier in the day, the MEA said a five-member specialised technical team from the Indian Army carried out on-site reconnaissance of hydropower tunnels in the flood-hit areas, which would help in facilitating early search and rescue operations. The team reached Kathmandu late on Friday, and started work on Saturday. Based on their recommendation, a specialised

tunnel rescue team from India with equipment was expected to land in Nepal later on Saturday night, it said.

The recce team, sent at the request of the Nepal government, reached the Trishuli area after conducting an aerial reconnaissance of the Chilime and Langtang areas and began assessing the situation for rescue operations, according to Nepalese authorities.

The team met Indian Ambassador to Nepal Naveen Srivastava, who said that they “conducted a recce of tunnels in Chilime and Langtang power plants area with Nepali Army”.

A joint team comprising the Nepal Army, Armed Police Force and Nepal Police personnel has been working since Friday night to clear debris and reach people believed to be trapped inside a tunnel at the Trishuli-3A hydropower project in Rasuwa. Rescue efforts have been complicated by mud and debris blocking the tunnel entrance and adverse weather conditions.

According to the Nepal Army, security forces have so far

them survived, his eldest daughter-in-law did not make it to safety. In just a few minutes, he says, the flood waters swallowed the fields where his family had grown rice and maize for generations, their banana and mango orchards, poultry and a tractor.

On Saturday, when Pyakuryal and his wife made their way down the hills to their house, all that they could salvage was a few clothes, all covered in mud.

“I have seen the river overflow many times. Just last year, half our paddy crop got submerged. But never have I seen such a flood, nor have I heard my parents or grandparents recalling such a thing,” he says.

“We have nothing left now, just the clothes we were wearing and these clothes we took today.”

An eerie silence has settled over the area, which earlier had

rescued 191 workers from tunnels at various hydropower projects. However, a large number of workers still remain unaccounted for. More than 100 people are believed to be trapped inside a tunnel at the under-construction Upper Trishuli-1 hydropower project in Rasuwa.

Nepal has sought foreign expertise for DNA testing, forensic work and other specialised tasks as local authorities struggle to identify bodies. It has also sought the help of India and China for construction of 42 Bailey bridges to resume transport services in the flood-hit areas. The portable bridges are designed for fast assembly without heavy machinery or special tools. India had sent one Bailey bridge earlier.

“The Government of India has remained engaged with relevant authorities in Government of Nepal to provide assistance as needed. Government of India has offered the National Disaster Response Force to support Nepal’s search and rescue efforts and also mobilised immediate humanitarian assistance with Indian Air Force aircraft carrying emergency relief material to Nepal,” the MEA said.

AGENCY INPUTS FROM NEPAL

about 19 houses with a population of about 150 people, a temple, a cooperative bank branch, a grocery store, and a funeral home. Most of its residents have now left for higher ground.

Pyakuryal’s cousin, Sita, is among the few in the area on Saturday. As she looks at the spot where her house once stood, she can’t help but cry. “I just had to come down and take a look,” says Sita, who lost a daughter-in-law and granddaughter in the flood.

Pyakuryal, however, is already planning ahead. “There is no other way I can live my life. If I keep thinking about that day, I won’t be able to survive,” he says, as he plays with Khairi, the local dog who has also survived.

On the third floor of his house, the breakfast that he left behind on Wednesday — rice, dal and some vegetables — still lies there.

rajanj district, then flows through Kushinagar and Deoria before entering Bihar.

Officials handling the bodies in UP have recorded details of jewellery and other belongings found on the bodies, as well as distinctive physical features such as tattoos and other identifying marks. Photographs have also been circulated in nearby areas.

Additional District Magistrate of Maharajanj, Prashant Kumar, said the bodies of three women and a young man had been found in the district. “If no one comes forward during the 72-hour period, further action will be taken in accordance with government guidelines,” Kumar said.

Until then, the administration will await information from Nepal or India that could help identify the victims. Officials said they also sent a report on the recoveries to the state government, which is expected

to forward it to the central government for further information and necessary action.

Ravi Pratap Rai, a disaster management expert posted in Kushinagar, said they recovered the bodies of three men and three women. Four bodies were found in Khadda tehsil and two in Tamkuhi Raj tehsil.

Since August 27, several teams, including Pandey’s, have patrolled the river around the clock, working in shifts to maintain continuous surveillance. They use searchlights at night and have sought help from local villagers, asking them to alert authorities if they spot anything unusual in the water.

Teams from the National Disaster Response Force, State Disaster Response Force and the flood battalion of the Provincial Armed Constabulary are also working alongside the district administration and police in Maharajanj and Kushinagar.

Bhagwat

become a game of self-interest.”

“In 2018, during my lecture series, Muslim brothers asked me that I talk about Hindu Rashtra and if that meant Muslims would be driven out. I said no, that is not Hindutva. If any Hindu thinks there should be no Muslims in India, he will not remain Hindu,” Bhagwat said. “If you want to call yourself a Hindu you have to believe that all paths are leading to the same God. And every human has dignity. There is no difference between human beings.”

Bhagwat said the Hindu tradition held that all faiths ultimately lead to the pursuit of divinity and that India had historically provided shelter to people of different denominations who could not find safety elsewhere. However, he said, “a baggage” from the past had contributed to disturbances between communities.

He said the RSS believed it had a responsibility to communicate the idea that diversity did not negate an underlying unity. “Diversity is a decoration of our innate unity. It has to be protected. As I protect my own specific nature, I have to protect others also. Diversity is the rule of nature. Unity is the truth behind nature,” he said.

Bhagwat said the objective was also to influence policies and politics, including efforts to stop wars, but argued that this could not be achieved by beginning

engagements.

The Yoga Federation of Uzbekistan was established in 2018 and nurtured by the Indian Council of Cultural Relations (ICCR) which had deputed a yoga teacher to it for four years. With India’s support, Uzbekistan became the first country in Central Asia to conduct yoga certification examinations under the Yoga Certification Board (YCB) of the Ministry of AYUSH. So far, under YFU, 528 Uzbeks have obtained yoga certifications.

Beyond yoga, there is cooperation in arts and culture. There are two ICCR chairs in Uzbekistan. The Hindi Chair has been in operation since 2024 in TSUOS (Tashkent State University of Oriental Studies) and Hindi has been taught there since 1947. TSUOS has done work in promoting Hindi language and literature.

Officials said that close to 14,000 Uzbek nationals visited India for medical tourism, making Uzbekistan the third largest source country for medical tourism to India.

In education, over 2,700 Uzbek nationals have been trained so far under various programmes. A total of 426 candidates have availed various ICCR scholarships. There are four Indian universities in Uzbekistan.

At the political level, India and Uzbekistan interact under the India-Central Asia framework in India-Central Asia Summit and India-Central Asia Dialogue at the foreign ministers’ level.

Tashkent

He said he would visit the Shastri Memorial and the Mahatma Gandhi Centre at the Tashkent State University of Oriental Studies (TSUOS), an affirmation of the close “cultural and people-to-people ties that bind our two countries.”

This is the PM’s fourth visit to Uzbekistan and second bilateral visit — he visited Uzbekistan in July 2015 (bilateral), June 2016 and in September 2022. The leaders last met briefly in September 2025 on the sidelines of the SCO Summit in Tianjin, China.

According to MEA’s Secretary (West) Sibi George, the PM’s discussions with Mirziyoyev will touch upon “trade and investment, critical minerals, healthcare, business-to-business engagement, education, space, technology, culture and people-to-people exchanges.”

India is among the top 10 trading partners of Uzbekistan with bilateral trade in 2025-26 close to US\$ 1 billion. Indian investment in Uzbekistan is close to another \$1 billion invested in renewables, construction, pharmaceutical, mining, IT, education, healthcare, engineering, textile and agriculture.

On Sunday, Modi is expected to start the day with a yoga programme at the Yoga Federation of Uzbekistan. After that, he will meet Uzbek President Shavkat Mirziyoyev at the Kuksovskiy Presidential Palace for bilateral

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+22RVd_RG9mJmZgJ

BJP tightrope on caste

reservation as per its population when the data of the ongoing Census enumerating caste is out.

“They should convey what they want, and not demand that others lose what they deserve in a caste-ridden society,” Athawale said of the protesters. He added that there should be talk of ending the caste system rather than ending reservation — which was something that the constitution has provided for.

Athawale isn’t alone. There is clarity among leaders from the reserved categories within the BJP that reservation should continue — something that the government and the RSS have also said repeatedly over the years.

Asked about the anti-reservation movement, Uttar Pradesh OBC Welfare Minister Narendra Kashyap, who was also the BJP’s state OBC Morcha president, told *The Indian Express*: “The movement is not in sync with the constitutional boundaries (sanvaidhanik paridhih).” Kashyap, who has also been UP OBC morcha president said that OBCs got reservation after a delay of 40 years, and two commissions of enquiry were set up for it to become a reality.

“Ye koi achanak mil jaane waala prasaad nahin tha (These were not sweets that were suddenly offered to them),” he said, adding that reservation was not a poverty alleviation measure. “As for the fear that the rich may benefit from it, there is creamy layer exclusion among OBCs. As a minister, I hold a constitutional post and my children cannot get reservation,” Kashyap said, adding that the agitators were either unaware of this or were looking for ways to disturb the Narendra Modi government when they were talking of quotas on economic grounds.

“It is their constitutional right to express what they wish to, but they should realise that the well-off OBCs do not get reservation anyway,” he underlined. Kashyap added that Jawaharlal Nehru as PM should have given reservation as early as 1952, but it came after much delay.

Talking to *The Indian Express*, former BJP OBC Morcha president K Laxman said, “Till disparity prevails, both social and financial, reservation will have to stay.”

BJP’s long arc on caste

The discourse on caste within the BJP comes when the party, once derisively called a “Bania-Brahmin party”, has over the last few decades imprinted itself on a much larger, sprawling social base. The experiment began when KN Govindacharya started an outreach into non-Yadav groups in north India once the BJP became a player in politics. Some castes like the Lodhs and the Kurmis began veering towards the BJP.

However, the floodgates were opened with the rise of Narendra Modi, himself an OBC, when the party made a massive symbolic outreach to OBCs, SCs and STs. After the BJP lost Bihar in 2015 when RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat suggested a review of reservation, the entire Sangh

Parivar began to repeatedly underline the sanctity of quotas. The opposition latched on to caste just before the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, saying that BJP wanted a tally of “400-paar” (400-plus seats) to end reservation and change the constitution. Party leaders interpreted the loss of 63 seats in the election — with significant dents in Maharashtra and UP — as a consequence of the campaign making an impact during the polls.

After this the Modi government 3.0 announced that caste would be enumerated in the coming census — this was demanded by the Congress before the Lok Sabha polls — and brought the UGC equity regulations.

At the 100th year function of the RSS in Nagpur, former President Ram Nath Kovind said that Atal Bihari Vajpayee had as Prime Minister underlined that his government would work on the basis of Dr Ambedkar’s constitution, and thus the BJP could be called “Ambedkarwadi”. He added that Vajpayee had averred that the Bhimsmiti (constitution) rather than the Manu Smriti was the “guide” for the government.

However, with the UGC equity regulation leading to a backlash and a Supreme Court stay, the government became cautious, lest the BJP should alienate the “upper castes” — its most committed voters north of the Vindhya since about 1990. The Bankipur assembly election loss in a constituency with a significant “upper caste” population has made the party more cautious.

Poll-bound UP, which has 80 Lok Sabha seats and a 20% “upper caste” population, has also been a hub of the Mandal movement, with many non-Yadav OBC castes with the BJP or the NDA over the last decade.

The “upper castes” have till now seen the BJP as their party, preferring it over the Congress for a decade-and-a-half, but there are signs of wariness. Reservation Hatao Andolan leader Harsh Dubey told *The Indian Express* that Brajesh Pathak had assured them that he would make them meet one among PM Modi, Amit Shah and JP Nadda within two working days, adding that they had two meetings on consecutive days with Nadda, one lasting three hours and the other two hours.

Dubey added that Nadda assured them that some significant measures would be announced on September 7 and that they would have a joint presser for the same.

Two other BJP leaders from the reserved category — Union Minister of State for Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying and Panchayati Raj SP Singh Baghel and former national spokesperson Bijay Sonkar Shastri — were less forthcoming when contacted.

“Policy makers will make their views clear on this issue,” Baghel said. Shastri on his part said, “We have freedom of speech. People are expressing their views. Whatever will happen will happen constitutionally alone.”

Kashmir

Five of those killed that night were guests of the Pandit families.

The massacre had only one survivor — a teenager. “He was a smart boy,” says Baba. “He was wearing a black pheran and hid himself in charcoal. When it all fell silent, he ran towards a house on the other side of the village. An hour later, he returned home, took some documents and left.”

The villagers went to the closest Army camp in Kurhama and told them about the killings. “The next morning, we went to the police station in Ganderbal and told them what happened in the village the previous night,” one resident says.

The killings of that night set off another series of migrations — this time of some Muslim families, who headed to Srinagar and even to north Kashmir.

Twenty-eight years later, the killings still inspire fear. “Why are you reopening the old wounds?” says a villager in his fifties, refusing to talk about that night.

But the killings have failed to sever the bond between the Muslims and Pandits of the village. Pandits who left years ago still return.

“They come to the village to meet their old Muslim friends, but they don’t stay the night. They have land here and sell their walnut produce every year,” says Baba. “They are connected to this village through their land and their friends.”

**PLUTUS IAS**
UPSC / PCS

ANTHROPOLOGY & SOCIOLOGY OPTIONAL

**DR. HUMA HASSAN**

- PH.D (SOCIOLOGY) JNU,
- EX FACULTY JAMIA UNIVERSITY
- GOLD MEDALIST FROM JAMIA UNIVERSITY
- 15 YEARS OF TEACHING EXPERIENCE

BATCH STARTING FROM 30th August

GS FOUNDATION COURSE FOR UPSC CSE, STATE PCS (BPSC), (UPPSC), (RAS), (NPSC) etc.

NEW BATCH STARTS 4th September

UPSC TOPPERS

Info@plutusias.com +91844-844-0231
2ND FLOOR, APSARA ARCADE, NEAR GATE NO. 6, KANOL BAGH METRO STATION, NEW DELHI, DELHI 110005

Noida airport could see ‘slower ramp-up’ amid geopolitical challenges: Operator

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 29

NOIDA INTERNATIONAL Airport (NIA) is expected to see a “slower ramp-up” of operations – passenger traffic, flights and routes are likely to increase more gradually than initially expected – primarily due to a challenging geopolitical environment, according to Zurich Airport Limited.

NIA is operated by a special purpose vehicle of Zurich Airport International AG, the international business entity of Zurich Airport Limited.

“Slower ramp-up expected due to challenging geopolitical environment, with near-term performance remaining subject to elevated uncertainty. Route network will continue to expand, with international services expected to follow,” Zurich Airport said in its post-earnings presentation in Switzerland.

The operator, however, remains confident about the “airport’s long-term growth prospects” and the “attractive fundamentals of the Indian aviation market”. According to the presentation, the route network will continue to expand, with international services expected to follow at the Noida Airport. It identified India and Brazil as key focus markets, citing their growth potential and its existing presence.

Losses continue

The NIA, located in Jewar near Noida, began operations on June 15. IndiGo and Akasa Air currently operate from the airport, together serving 17 domestic routes.

NIA handled 204 flights in June, which rose to 1,044 in July. Passenger numbers also increased from about 25,000 in June to 77,000 in July.

In the first half of 2026, the airport earned CHF (Swiss Francs) 2.5 million in revenue against operating expenses of CHF 4.9 million, resulting in a loss of CHF 2.4 million before in-



Noida airport began operations in June. FILE

terest, taxes, depreciation and amortisation. Air India Express had planned to operate from NIA but later backed out amid financial pressures worsened by the West Asia conflict. The continued closure of Pakistani airspace has also affected Indian airlines’ west-bound operations and expansion plans.

The challenges

Zurich Airport’s guidance for 2026 indicates that NIA’s operations will weigh on the expenditure of the parent company including operating expenses, depreciation and amortisation and finance expenses.

While Noida Airport’s operationalisation is expected to result in higher revenue for Zurich Airport, the net impact on the group’s consolidated earnings for the year is likely to be negative, which is common for early stage large infrastructure projects. The operationalisation of NIA comes at a time when the aviation sector is grappling with headwinds amid the West Asia crisis, forcing airlines to prune schedules and put network expansion plans on hold.

NIA is the second major airport serving Delhi-NCR, after Delhi Airport. Its location, however, remains a challenge. It is around 80 km from central Delhi and nearly 60 km from Central Noida. Although the airport has expressway connectivity, proposed rapid rail and high-speed rail links are still years away.

Lessons from Tokyo, New York, 3-pronged plan in focus as Capital races to clear legacy waste

Mishal Mussaddique
New Delhi, August 29

TECHNOLOGY-DRIVEN Tokyo model, externalised New York waste management and Barcelona’s hybrid model were in focus on Saturday as the Municipal Corporation Delhi (MCD) discussed the waste management system in the Capital with World Bank experts at a key meeting.

Amid a race to meet deadlines to clear legacy waste piled up over decades at landfills in the Capital, the discussions pivoted around suggestions for informal sector worker integration, utility tariffs rollout and emissions control, said officials.

The meeting was chaired by MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar. Officials said that the discussion culminated in a proposed approach for Delhi with the stated objective to “improve

MCD’s operational efficiency, establish financial sustainability and reduce atmospheric emissions”. This was followed by presentations by the World Bank team on waste management models being followed in major global cities.

Global best practices

In an official statement, MCD said, “The presentation highlighted that Tokyo has developed an extensive waste processing system with 23 Waste-to-Energy units where a major portion of municipal waste is scientifically processed.”

It added, “The experts also presented the externalised waste management model of New York City, where private agencies are engaged for transportation and processing of waste, including its movement to facilities outside the city. Under Barcelona’s Zero Waste



Machines segregate garbage at the Bhalswa landfill site in Delhi on Saturday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Plan 2021–2027, the city is moving towards decentralised waste management facilities to reduce pressure on transportation systems.”

At the meeting, Khirwar, as per the statement, spoke about “the importance of adopting suitable global best practices according to Delhi’s local requirements and conditions”.

3-pronged approach

The proposed approach for Delhi centres on three components — decentralised processing and transport; development of a sustainable waste treatment mix; and institutional strengthening.

Many of the propositions, however, already exist on paper, including, legacy biomining to

develop a “sustainable waste treatment mix”. This is part of the MCD’s current plan to clear the Okhla and Bhalswa landfills with a proposed deadline of December this year, and the Ghazipur landfill by December next year.

The march towards this deadline has been slowed down by heavy rainfall over the last month.

According to the civic body’s dashboard, over the last three days, an average of 787 (tonnes per day) TPD of waste was lifted at Bhalswa, 575 TPD at Okhla and 3,382 TPD at Ghazipur. However, during the same period, an average of 4,243 TPD, 2,115 TPD, and 2,541 TPD had been dumped at these landfills, respectively.

Meanwhile, other recommendations at the meeting included “ward-level processing” — recyclables and organics

are processed at the source to prevent open dumping or burning, which is already encouraged under the existing Solid Waste Management Rules 2026. The Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) guidelines released in June instruct that municipal solid waste first undergoes ‘manual and mechanical segregation’ at the Material Recovery Facilities (MRF) before being sent to landfills.

The implementation, however, has gaps. An MCD official said that they sometimes receive mixed waste at the landfill sites which has to then be segregated.

A version of another recommendation on utility tariffs—to levy user charges for solid waste management along with property tax — was rolled out last year by the MCD but later put on hold because of public opposition.

Man kills son, hides body in container

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 29

A 64-YEAR-OLD man and his friend have been arrested in Delhi for allegedly killing his 38-year-old son, police said on Saturday. The victim was allegedly lured to an abandoned container in Southeast Delhi’s Kalindi Kunj area by his father on the pretext of being taken to a doctor before being attacked with stones and strangled with a rope, officers added.

Police arrested the accused, Talukdar Ansari, and his friend, Md Wasim alias Akram, on Friday, days after the body of Ansari’s son, identified as Gul Hasan, was recovered from the container on August 23.

Following an extensive probe, according to the police, both the accused were traced to a garment factory in Govind-puri.

DCP (Southeast) Vineet

Kumar said the investigation so far has indicated that the killing was linked to the victim’s mental health condition.

“During the investigation, it emerged that Gul Hasan was suffering from schizophrenia and other mental health-related problems. The complete motive behind the crime is being further investigated, but the circumstances leading to the murder are being corroborated through forensic, technical and other evidence,” Kumar said.

Officers said they received information about an unidentified male body lying inside a container, locally known as ‘Bablu ka container’, around 7.13 pm on August 23. A team from Kalindi Kunj police station reached the spot and found an injury on the deceased’s head. A stone with apparent blood stains was also recovered from the crime scene.

Man electrocuted by street light pole, claims family, case lodged; no lapses, says PWD

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 29

AROUND 8 PM on August 26, Sandeep, 28, who worked as a caregiver, was returning home when he allegedly came in contact with a street light pole in East Delhi’s Anand Vihar, got electrocuted, fell into a pit and died. His family, unaware about the accident, launched a hunt and contacted police when he did not return home that night. About 12 hours later, his body was recovered from the pit. Officers on Saturday said a negligence case has been filed in the matter. The pole lies in the jurisdiction of the Public Works Department (PWD) of the Delhi government. So far, the PWD said, no safety lapses have been found.

Sandeep was the sole bread earner in his family. Officers said the post-mortem examination attributed his death to



Deceased Sandeep

electrocution.

Recalling the night of the accident, his uncle, Sunderlal, 68, said the family became concerned when he did not arrive at his usual time. “I called him around 9.50 pm because he would normally be home by then. Someone disconnected the call,” he said, adding that the family was unable to locate his mobile phone later.

The family searched for him for several hours before police found his body around 7 am on Thursday.

Sandeep’s relatives have raised questions over the circumstances of his death and alleged foul play. They have also held the authorities responsible, alleging that negligence in the upkeep of public infrastructure may have led to the incident.

Police, however, have denied any immediate indication supporting the allegation of foul play and said the role and possible responsibility of the agencies concerned would be examined as part of the investigation.

Sandeep lost his parents as an infant and was brought up by his aunt and uncle in Shahdara’s Bihari Colony. His uncle and aunt had stopped working after their health deteriorated. His cousin Manish said Sandeep would hand over his monthly earnings to Sunderlal, whom he regarded as his father. “The family is devas-

tated. We want the truth about how he died and action against whoever is found responsible,” Manish said.

In a statement, the PWD on Saturday condoled Sandeep’s death. The department said the Delhi government has directed that every aspect of the incident be examined and that accountability would be fixed if any negligence, lapse or breach was found. It said it has undertaken a detailed technical examination of the location. According to the department, the findings available so far have not established any electrical defect or “current leakage” from the street light pole.

Police said the investigation into the negligence case is underway and that the findings of the technical examination and other evidence would be examined to determine if any agency or individual was responsible for the death.



NARENDRA MODI
PRIME MINISTER



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार



महिला एवं बाल विकास विभाग



DEPARTMENT OF WOMEN AND CHILD DEVELOPMENT



मिशन शक्ति
माद्री सुरक्षा
माद्री सम्मान
माद्री स्वावलम्बन



REKHA GUPTA
CHIEF MINISTER, DELHI

EMPOWERING WOMEN STRENGTHENING DELHI

Hub for Empowerment of Women (HEW) One - Stop Support for Every Woman

With one State Hub and every District Hubs, the Delhi Government ensures easy access to essential services for women



Services Offered

Free Legal Advice

Skill Training And Job Readiness

Guidance On Scholarships And Financial Assistance Schemes

Support Groups And Awareness Programmes

Information On Pensions And Welfare Schemes

For more details, visit: <https://wcd.delhi.gov.in>

For assistance, call: **Women’s Helpline: 181**

For Your growth, safety and equality—The Delhi Government is here for you

Department of Women and Child Development, Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi

DELHI FIRE SERVICE (AMENDMENT) RULES, 2026, NOTIFIED

6-m access, fire lifts, — Delhi tightens safety norms for high-rises

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 29

SIX-METRE fire engine access, protected exits, fire lifts, sprinkler and fire-suppression systems, emergency power back-ups, fire control rooms and fire-check floors and refuge areas — these are among the key safety requirements that all high-rise buildings in Delhi should fulfill under a new 18-point fire safety framework notified by the government.

The Delhi Fire Service (Amendment) Rules, 2026, notified by the Home department on August 28, link the minimum fire prevention and safety standards for buildings to their height and occupancy category under the amended Unified Building Bye-Laws (UBBL).

The amendments come in the wake of major fire incidents at Malviya Nagar Bed and Breakfast, Palam and Vivek Vihar that together claimed nearly 41 lives and left several people injured.

Home Minister Ashish Sood said the revised rules would align Delhi's fire safety standards with the UBBL. "Safety and security of every citizen of Delhi is our government's top-most priority," he said, adding that the new framework introduces modern and mandatory safety measures across buildings. "A standardised auditor inspection checklist will bring complete transparency and accountability to safety compliance. We are committed to building a safer, more resilient, and modern Delhi," he said.

The 18-point framework covers access for fire engines; protection of exits; fire and smoke barriers; extinguishers



Fire broke out at Flourish Stay B&B in Malviya Nagar on June 3. FILE

and hose reels; automatic fire detection and alarm systems; public address and voice evacuation systems; sprinklers and fire-suppression systems; internal and yard hydrants; fire pumps and firefighting water storage.

It also provides for exit signage and floor markings; fire towers and fire lifts; emergency power supply for critical fire safety equipment; fire check floors and refuge areas; fire control rooms with automated continuous monitoring systems; manually operated electronic fire alarms and specialised fire protection systems.

Further, the amended rules give the Delhi Fire Service (DFS) director powers to prescribe additional fire prevention and safety measures for buildings or occupancies where such provisions are not specified in the building by-laws. These measures may be based on international standards prescribed by the fire prevention wing.

Moreover, the government may relax, modify or remove specific requirements for certain classes of occupancy or buildings in special areas. This

can also apply to buildings that have been constructed or were under construction before the rules come into force, provided reasons are recorded in writing.

The new rules will take effect only from the date the amended UBBL-2016 is notified by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA). The Home department notification clarifies that applications pending on the date of commencement will continue to be processed under the provisions in force on the date of application submission.

An official said that structural and non-structural audits currently conducted for commercial buildings were until now the responsibility of MCD but as the rules were not clear, DFS was largely was conducting such audits.

"Now, the structural audit part will be conducted by the MCD and other agencies such as NDMC and DDA, as it will be included in the bye-laws. These are the authorities that approve the building map before construction," the official said.

"The non-structural audit will be conducted by Fire department," the official added.

PWD to inspect 139 waterlogging hotspots, submit report tomorrow

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 29

AFTER HEAVY rainfall on August 24 and 25 triggered severe waterlogging, traffic paralysis and flight disruptions across Delhi-NCR, the Delhi government on Saturday directed the PWD to conduct an intensive inspection of 139 recently identified waterlogging hotspots in its areas and submit a location-wise report with recommendations by Monday, ahead of the possibility of more showers in the coming days.

Officials said Delhi Traffic Police had identified 113 waterlogging locations during rainfall up to August 20, while 26 additional locations were identified during the showers on August 24. This was after LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu directed concerned agencies to ensure foolproof mitigation measures.

The Principal Secretary (PWD) will inspect locations on Mehrauli-Badarpur Road, while the Special Secretary will inspect MG Road, Old Delhi-Gurgaon Road and Mahipalpur Bypass, the PWD said in a statement.

Chief Engineers will inspect recurrent waterlogging locations in their respective zones.

These include New Rohtak Road and 100 Feet Road in Burari in East Zone; Balbir Singh Sidhu Marg, Prembari Underpass and Palla in the North Zone; and Dabri Nala Road, RTR Marg and Najafgarh-Kapashera Road in the South Zone.

Other locations to be inspected include Nangloi-Najafgarh Road, Jahangirpuri Metro station, Model Town and Lala Jagat Narain Marg.

The report will include the reasons for water accumulation, immediate measures that can be implemented during the ongoing monsoon and long-term corrective measures.

"We will not wait for the next spell of rain to expose the same problem. Every recurring waterlogging point needs a clear assessment and a practical solution. Accountability, quick response and continuous monitoring will remain our priority," PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said.

"For us, every waterlogged road means inconvenience for a family, a worker, a student or someone trying to reach home. That is why we are taking the issue directly to the ground. Our senior officials have inspected every identified location,

understood the reasons behind the waterlogging and assessed immediate corrective measures wherever possible," he added.

Officials said the inspections are focused on drainage arrangements, outfall conditions, siltation and blockages, pumping arrangements, encroachments and other site-specific factors contributing to waterlogging. Officers will also assess practical short-term measures that can be implemented during the ongoing monsoon and identify long-term solutions for recurring problem spots.

The inspections shall be treated as urgent and time-bound, in view of the possibility of further heavy rainfall during the remaining monsoon period, the statement added.

Meanwhile, in another measure aimed at fixing accountability, orders have been issued to provide jackets and raincoats bearing the PWD logo to all pump house operators, PTO (power take-off) pump operators and engineers. Officials said the move will make personnel deployed on waterlogging and pumping duties identifiable and help fix responsibility in case of any laxity.

EXPRESS special

No water & power connections, proper road: Inside Gurgaon's 'ready' homes

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, August 29

THEIR HOMES were declared fit for occupation — on paper.

Across Gurgaon, residents of several housing societies are still waiting for basic infrastructure such as proper roads, water and electricity, and other amenities promised to them even after their projects received Occupancy Certificates (OCs).

At ROF Alante in Sector 108, residents said they have no dedicated power or municipal water connection and lack a proper approach road to the society. At Ambience Lagoon, next to Ambience Mall, residents have also flagged missing amenities.

Unfinished projects

The issue has come under scrutiny after joint surprise inspections by the Chief Minister's Flying Squad and the Department of Town and Country Planning (DTCP) in April found that 14 of 22 inspected residential complexes with valid OCs were still under construction. Inspectors noted that many were merely concrete shells lacking basic plastering, finished floors, or operational kitchen and bathroom plumbing.

Following the findings, authorities began scrutinising OCs issued between July 1, 2025 and March 15, 2026, and found that around 1,500 OCs had been issued prematurely. "We found around 1,500 such cases where OCs had been issued prematurely, despite the building not being complete. We blacklisted the architects concerned," Gurgaon District



ROF Alante in Sector 108 (top); Ambience Lagoon. ABHINAV SAHA

Town Planner (Planning) Praveen Chauhan said.

In 2022, during the Monsoon Session of the Haryana Assembly, a reply to an unstarred question from then Badshahpur MLA Rakesh Daultabad revealed that only 93 realty projects in Gurgaon had obtained completion certificates from the Town and Country Planning Department since 1992.

Missing amenities

At ROF Alante, residents who booked units years ago for just over Rs 20 lakh said they received occupancy clearances around mid-2024. Roughly 450

families who live in the complex complained that the society lacks a proper approach road and entrance gate. "How were the OCs and licences issued?" a homeowner said.

Residents also claimed the society doesn't have a dedicated electricity connection and they have to rely on power backup. "The builder hasn't applied for a connection till date..." said a homeowner.

There is no municipal water supply either. The society relies on makeshift arrangements: water tankers and diesel generators. Around 10 tankers line up every day to provide water, while

the developer pays the diesel bills to keep the power running.

Further, residents flagged problems with the sewage treatment plant. "The STP doesn't work. In parks, waste water is flowing... Our children are suffering from skin infections," said one. Another said parts of the society did not have a boundary wall in certain places.

ROF Group, however, attributed delays to local villagers obstructing construction work.

"All required materials are available at the site, all necessary statutory permissions and approvals for execution of the work have been obtained," said Alok Srivastava, Head, Facilities and Operations, ROF Group. "However... certain local villagers have been creating undue hindrances in the execution of the project. They have obstructed work... and threatened project personnel deployed at the site," he added.

"The matter was subsequently taken up with the Senior Town Planner, who forwarded the case to the Deputy Commissioner (DC), Gurgaon. The DC appointed the SDM to inspect the site and get the work done by providing necessary police protection," Srivastava said.

3 'missing' acres

At Ambience Lagoon, the problem is of a different sort.

Advocate Sanjay Lal, president of the Federation of Apartment Owners Association, claimed the project was granted a licence in 1993 for an 18.98-acre residential development. "I bought a flat in 2001 and shifted here... The bro-

chure said there would be a water body, where you will have boating, and other recreational facilities..." Lal said.

Eight acres were de-licensed by the Haryana government in 2001 for commercial development — on which Ambience Mall now stands — while another three acres were de-licensed in 2010, which led to a prolonged legal battle over the diversion of residential land.

Lal claimed residents later found that the Floor Area Ratio (FAR) of 1.75 had already been consumed on 10.98 acres and alleged that the remaining three acres, meant for amenities and recreational facilities, had also been used.

Residents also flagged the absence of amenities, including an STP and a promised club.

The society received an OC in 2001 but, Lal claimed, is yet to receive a Completion Certificate (CC). Unlike an OC, which permits occupation after specified checks, the CC involves scrutiny of the colony's overall infrastructure and amenities.

The dispute reached the Punjab and Haryana High Court, which in 2020 quashed the two de-licensing orders and ordered a CBI probe. In January 2026, the Supreme Court overturned the ruling, holding that the HC had relied on unverified, inconclusive material and that a CBI probe was unwarranted.

Senior advocates Abhishek Manu Singhvi and Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for the developers, had argued that the approved layout showed the project was to be developed on 10.98 acres only.

Three Delhi BJP MPs attend Sajjan Kumar's prayer meeting, pulled up by party president

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 29

THREE BJP MPs from Delhi were reprimanded by the party national president Nitin Nabin for attending Saturday's condolence meeting organised for late Congress leader Sajjan Kumar, who was convicted for his role in the 1984 anti-Sikh riots.

All three — South Delhi MP Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, North West Delhi MP Yogender Chandolia and West Delhi MP Kamaljeet Sehrawat — represent Parliamentary constituencies with a sizeable populations from the Jat community settled across both rural and semi urban villages cross-crossing the city's borders with Haryana and Uttar Pradesh.

According to party sources, alarm bells began ringing after the three turned up at the condolence meeting following Sajjan's death on August 20. In addition to the BJP's top brass in the Capital, insiders said, several senior leaders based in Punjab also received complaints regarding the development.

Nabin is said to have reprimanded the three MPs after summoning them to the party headquarters, underlining that the visit was their personal decision. Sources said Nabin spoke to, and demanded, a clarification from each of them separately, and is said to have underlined that their visit went

beyond propriety, given the former Jat strongman's conviction by the Delhi High Court.

"The president is said to have underlined that their landing up together seemed to indicate that they were representing the party as a formal delegation. It was not only completely uncalled for, but also against the BJP's own stance against the genocide," a senior BJP leader said.

"Two of them are said to have submitted that they had not initially planned on visiting but did so after their remaining colleague suggested that they do so," a party source said.

The *Indian Express* reached out to all three MPs via phone and text but none responded to requests for a comment.

Meanwhile, senior Supreme Court advocate and BJP Punjab leader HS Phoolka called for a boycott of the trio.

"This when #BJP has always supported our quest for justice against this culprits and supported us in ensuring that he stays in Jail. Sympathy should be reserved for victims and their families—many of whom live the horror of those days even till now... I call for the boycott of these 3 MPs," Phoolka posted on X.

Following Nabin's meeting with the three MPs, Phoolka, in another post, said, "Grateful to @NitinNabin ji for taking a strong stance on the issue."

Son seeks support of Cong leader's 'family'

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, August 29

AT THE prayer meeting Saturday in Talkatora Stadium auditorium for three-time Congress MP Sajjan Kumar, convicted for his role in the 1984 anti-Sikh riots, his son Jag Parvesh Kumar pledged to work for those who had gathered to pay homage.

"The heritage handed over by my father is not in terms of money or materialistic things. It is in the form of you... the way he loved you, I will do the same while sitting in your feet. I want to request you all... you are the family created by my father. If you ever feel your son is helpless, please extend support to me," said Jag Praveesh evoking a response of 'Sajjan Kumar amar rahe' from the crowd of people from across Delhi.

After his speech, Jag Parvesh sits down for the "pagdi" tradition, which declares him as the head of the family.

Kumar, who died on August 20, was convicted by the Delhi High Court in 2018. He was sentenced to life imprisonment in a case pertaining to the killing of five members of a Sikh family during the 1984 anti-Sikh riots.

Since the death of Sajjan, the



Delhi Congress chief Devender Yadav at prayer meeting at Talkatora Stadium. AMIT MEHRA

Congress has been treading a careful line, and party MP Deepender Hooda had to clarify that he never called Sajjan a role model after facing flak from AAP, BJP and SAD in Punjab, where elections are due next year. "I had no intention of hurting anyone's feelings; those who know me are aware that I never harboured any intent to cause hurt to anyone," Hooda had said after a row erupted over his remarks.

While the Congress high command has maintained a measured silence on the death of Sajjan, several leaders from the Delhi unit, including president Devender Yadav, were in attendance at the prayer meeting on Saturday. SP's Jaat MP from Muzaffarnagar Harendra Malik was also present.

FIR lodged after TCS engineer killed in accident with earthmover

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 29

THE DLF Phase 3 police in Gurgaon has registered an FIR against an unidentified earthmover driver after a 27-year-old system engineer with Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) was killed when the bike's rear bucket swung into his lane in Gurgaon on Thursday night.

According to the FIR, lodged on Friday, Tushar Kumar was riding from his office in Cyber City to his uncle's home in Sector 37D around 11.30 pm when the earthmover, operating near Moulisari Avenue Rapid Metro station, hit his bike. Kumar was thrown onto the road.

He was taken to Narayana Hospital in DLF Phase 3, where doctors declared him dead on arrival. Police said the driver fled, leaving the earthmover, at the spot.

The FIR was registered on a complaint filed by Kumar's father under sections relating to causing death by negligence, rash driving or riding on a public way so as to endanger human life, and mischief causing damage or loss to property.

ASI Virender Singh clarified that GMDA had no role in the construction work at the site, which was related to the DLF Downtown project.

• THIRD EDITION OF TWO-DAY BHASHAVAAD NATIONAL TRANSLATION CONFERENCE AT IIC

Why Artificial Intelligence can't completely replace translators, for now at least

Aishwarya Khosla
New Delhi, August 29

FIRST KISS on page 18, first quarrel on cue, and so on.

It has been a running joke among ardent readers that this is the recipe followed in Mills & Boon romance novels. Can artificial intelligence or AI reproduce them satisfactorily? While that debate is still on, translation of the books has come across as an entirely different ball game.

That is why, perhaps, the romance imprint of one of the world's biggest publishers, Harlequin, proposed earlier this year running its French translations through the technology

and keeping human translators only to clean up later.

Even as writers, translators and artists continue to feel threatened by AI, Ashoka University's Centre for Translation on Saturday brought together journalist-translator Poonam Saxena; Nishat Zaidi, professor and former head of the Department of English at Jamia Millia Islamia; historian-translator Murali Ranganathan; and Moutushi Mukherjee, Senior Commissioning Editor, Penguin Random House India, for the third edition of its two-day Bhashavaad National Translation Conference at the India International Centre in New Delhi, to ask a question that

may sound alarmist, but is no longer hyperbolic — "Are translators redundant?"

As Arunava Sinha, who co-directs the Ashoka Centre for Translation, moderated the event, no panelist disputed that AI can already handle formula fiction.

Zaidi said translators, who take on that kind of work, are "wasting away their time", since it is exactly what a machine can replicate. Where the panel drew a line was literary translation, essentially texts where meaning depends on context a model doesn't have.

In Munshi Premchand's classic 'Gaban', explained Saxena, a character faces a cri-



At Ashoka University's Centre for Translation on Saturday. EXPRESS

sis, and the line would translate verbatim as: "Then there would be nothing left for him except Triveni." But in the world of the

novel, set in Allahabad (now known as Prayagraj), the phrase implies drowning oneself at the Triveni Sangam. It is about sui-

cide. "No AI translator is going to know these things," she said, because it does not have the accrued human experience, adding that she has never used AI and does not plan to.

Sinha, however, playing devil's advocate, argued that every time a human corrects an AI output, the correction trains the model.

Zaidi said the issue is not really about capability, but rather how the profession gets framed. She emphasised that translators produce knowledge, not just copies, and that a model trained only on existing text cannot generate anything genuinely new.

2025 Booker Prize-winning

author David Szalay had made a similar point, saying that AI "will always be pretending" because "it does not know, will never know what it is like to be a living body."

Mukherjee spoke of a bigger issue plaguing the publishing industry: if a translator leans on AI for a large share of a manuscript, who owns the copyright? She said editors have started reading for "tells", or over-elaborate, jargon-heavy sentences, as a matter of course now.

Sinha then posed the question: if translators were to become redundant, who would be responsible? "Publishers, AI or translators themselves?" Saxena pointed to pub-

lishers, saying that translators can only do the work they are commissioned to do, and if publishers decide to use AI instead, there is little translators can do about it.

Zaidi's response, however, was translators because the kind of reading, research, and deep interpretation that goes into literary translation is something no machine can replicate.

But the debate ended rather optimistically with Sinha saying that he had been told five years ago that translators would be wiped out within two years. "Three years after that," he said, "...here we are, all of us translators still alive."



Department of Commerce & Industries, Govt. of Chhattisgarh



Chhattisgarh isn't just attracting investment - it's building industries it has never had before. From chips to chocolate, garments to GPUs. In under two years since the Industrial Development Policy 2024-30, ₹8 lakh crore+ has arrived, and sectors the state was never known for are now taking root. This is only the beginning.

-SHRI VISHNU DEO SAI
CHIEF MINISTER OF CHHATTISGARH



SHRI VISHNU DEO SAI
CHIEF MINISTER OF CHHATTISGARH

SHRI NARENDRA MODI
PRIME MINISTER OF INDIA

CHHATTISGARH MEIN PEHLI BAAR



COCOA-BASED FOOD MANUFACTURING

A decade of chocolate-making expertise, now on the ground in Chhattisgarh.



CONSUMER ELECTRICAL MANUFACTURING

Bringing large-scale fan and electronic appliance manufacturing to the state.



GARMENT MANUFACTURING

Building livelihoods and global exports, supplying brands like H&M and Marks & Spencer.



invest.cg.gov.in



INTRAOCULAR LENS MANUFACTURING

A GMP-compliant cleanroom facility producing intraocular lenses used in cataract and eye surgeries.



AI DATA CENTRE PARK

Hosting over 1,00,000 GPUs, powering AI and high-performance computing at scale.



HYPERSCALE DATA CENTRES

₹5,000 crore expanding cloud, colocation and enterprise computing capacity.



GLOBAL BPOS

A new global BPO hub, bringing 5,000+ jobs in customer support and tech services.



SEMICONDUCTOR MANUFACTURING

₹11,000 crore+ anchoring chip manufacturing and India's electronics future.

Nabin chairs meeting on party's youth outreach plan

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 29

BJP PRESIDENT Nitin Nabin held a crucial meeting with party leaders Saturday to discuss the proposed outreach to Gen Z and youth, sources said.

According to sources, BJP leaders, mostly young faces from organisational ranks as well as some ministers from party-ruled states, were part of the meeting where it was stressed that youth outreach was a continuous process and required to be done through small gatherings instead of large ones.

Leaders, including BJP national general secretaries Smriti Irani, Vinod Tawde, Union minister Mansukh Mandaviya, MPs Ravi Kishan, Anurag Thakur, Tejasvi Surya and Sandeep Pathak, Gujarat Deputy CM Harsh Sanghavi, Chhattisgarh Finance Minister O P Choudhary and BJYM chief Hemang Joshi were present, said sources, adding that the meeting mainly focused on seeking feedback in the form of suggestions regarding the outreach to different sections of youth across categories ranging from students to professionals.

"This was a preliminary meeting, there will be more in future. The point stressed upon was the need for a reliable mechanism to ensure that issues concerning youth are heard by our leaders," a party source said. Sources said the party's preparations for polls in UP, Punjab and Gujarat were also on the agenda.

Congress leader blocks Keralam CM convoy, held

Pathanamthitta: Keralam Health Minister K Muraleedharan on Saturday said a Congress leader blocking CM V D Satheesan's convoy and allegedly using abusive language against him was inappropriate and did not suit the political culture.

He was referring to the arrest of Thiruvananthapuram DCC member Anil Kumar alias Chenthi Ani, who allegedly blocked the official convoy, demanding that the CM attend an event there though it was not in the CM's list of events, officials said.

Satheesan was on his way to Chempazhanthy to attend an event marking the birth anniversary of social reformer Sree Narayana Guru on Friday evening.

Congress workers led by Ani had organised an event in Chenthi and to mark the birth anniversary of Narayana Guru and had invited Satheesan. While Satheesan was on his way to Chempazhanthy, Congress workers signalled his vehicle to stop. An argument ensued between Satheesan and Ani, after which the former left. Muraleedharan said, "If someone blocks the CM (convoy), police will naturally have to take action." PTI

SEVEN YEARS AFTER IT WAS INSTITUTED BY HOME MINISTRY

Sardar Patel National Unity Award: Govt likely to name winner this yr

Divya A
New Delhi, August 29

SEVEN YEARS after it was instituted by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), the first Sardar Patel National Unity Award is set to be announced on October 31 this year, The Indian Express has learnt.

While the award was instituted in September 2019, and over one hundred nominations are learnt to have been received each year, sources said none of them were considered "deserving" so far. With no "befitting" selection, no award winners were announced until now.

However, according to sources, a series of deliberations have been held to announce the first tranche of awards this year, coinciding with the conclusion of the two-year celebrations to mark Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel's 150th

birth anniversary which began on October 31, 2024.

The MHA did not respond to queries emailed by *The Indian Express* in this regard.

Sources said the award will be given by the President alongside the Padma Awards next year.

According to those aware of the developments, it will be considered equivalent to the Padma Vibhushan, and there may be two or three recipients this time.

While nominations were invited from June 1 to July 31 this year, over 150 names are learnt to have been received so far. Ahead of opening up the portal for public entries, the MHA had also sent letters to all state chief secretaries and Union secretaries, asking them to send nominations.

Sources said a committee is set to be notified by the MHA

• For contribution to unity and integrity of India

THE AWARD will be given by the President alongside the Padma Awards next year, sources said, adding that it will be considered equivalent to the Padma Vibhushan

OVER 150 names learnt to have been received so far. A panel is set to be notified by MHA for going through the nominations



The medal will have a portrait of Patel on one side and the national emblem on the other. SOURCE: PIB

for going through the nominations.

Once the committee makes its selection, the candidates would be subjected to verification by the investigating agencies to ensure "that their character/ antecedents are above board," said sources.

According to the 2019 notification announcing the award,

the candidate "should have made outstanding efforts and notable contribution to promote and further the cause of national unity and integrity in a manner that may serve as an inspiration to others, and reinforce the value of a strong and united India".

The notification said that "the award committee would

EXPRESS special

In UP, welfare pitch to Gen Z, women before elections fuels BJP vs SP vs BSP battle

Yogi announces one lakh jobs for youth, free bus travels for elderly women; Akhilesh reiterates Rs 40,000 aid proposal for women; and Mayawati calls for filling up reserved vacancies

Maulshree Seth
Lucknow, August 29

WITH THE Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections less than six months away, welfare politics is hotting up in the crucial heartland state, with the ruling BJP and the Opposition SP and the BSP vying to reach out to youth and women voters.

Jobs for youth, Gen Z

On Tuesday, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said his government would give appointment letters to one lakh young people in six months.

Addressing a gathering, Adityanath also claimed to have provided government jobs to more than 9.30 lakh youth during the BJP's nine years in office.

The CM's announcement has come against a backdrop of discontent among sections of students and youth over alleged irregularities in various exam and recruitment processes, which have resulted in protests in different states in recent days — from Jantar Mantar to Jharkhand to Bihar.

Such protests were also seen in UP — in Prayagraj in May and in Lucknow in June — against various alleged irregularities in the police and lekhpal

recruitment exams and NEET paper leak.

Countering Adityanath, BSP chief and ex-CM Mayawati said that while providing government jobs was a correct step, it could be an "electoral manoeuvre" ahead of the polls.

She flagged the backlog of reserved vacancies and the continuing protests by 6,800 candidates from reserved categories over the recruitment of 69,000 teachers.

Defending the CM, BJP said his pledge to ensure one lakh government jobs should be viewed against the party-led government's track record of providing employment to youth.

The youth and Gen Z account for a significant chunk of UP's population. The final electoral roll of UP, published by the EC on April 10, 2026 following the SIR exercise, puts the state's electorate at 13.39 crore. As per the EC, there are 17.63 lakh voters aged just 18-19 years.

Sops for women

A day after announcing jobs for youth, Adityanath launched Lokmata Ahilyabai Matrusakti Yatra Yojana for free travel on state buses to women aged 60 and above. On the occasion of Raksha Bandhan, women will also get free bus

travels with one co-passenger during 27-29 August.

The scheme fits into the BJP's broader women-centric narrative around welfare, mobility and safety, including Mission Shakti — meant for women's safety and empowerment — and the 1090 women's helpline.

The Opposition's response came immediately, with SP chief Akhilesh Yadav Wednesday reiterating his party's proposal to bring Stree Samman Samridhhi Yojana under which Rs 40,000 would be given annually to every underprivileged and vulnerable woman in UP — in the event of its coming to power in the state in 2027.

Akhilesh asserted that his PDA (Pichhda, Dalit and Alp-sankhyak) plank would reaffirm SP's commitment to this scheme for "half the population", adding that the objective was to empower women socially and strengthen them economically.

The SP's proposals also include laptops and bicycles for girl students, free travels for women on government buses, housing, ambulance services and legal aid.

These announcements were made by Akhilesh at an event where party's women



Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath in Ballia on Saturday. ANI

leaders, MPs and MLAs were on the stage, including his wife and MP Dimple Yadav.

Currently, there are 6.09 crore women voters in UP, accounting for 45.46% of its total electorate, making them one of the most crucial constituencies in the state. It explains the flurry of BJP's welfare proposals for them followed by SP's promises in the run-up to polls.

Mayawati argued that beyond ensuring free travels for elderly women, governments needed the "right intent and policy" to protect women from exploitation and atrocities, while ensuring their safety, dignity and self-reliance.

She accused the Adityanath government of giving women "insecurity, neglect and humiliation", alleging that BJP treated women as little more than a

be constituted by the Prime Minister, and would include the Cabinet Secretary, Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister, Secretary to the President, Home Secretary, as members, and three-four eminent persons selected by the Prime Minister".

The award is set to comprise a medal and a citation, but no monetary grant or cash award would be attached to it. According to sources, it would not be conferred posthumously, except in very rare and highly deserving cases. The medal will be in the form of a lotus leaf, made of gold and silver, with Patel's portrait embossed on one side and the national emblem on the other.

The nominations for the Padma Awards are also managed by the MHA and announced on the eve of Republic Day each year.

Day after Trinamool student wing event, Mamata booked for 'violating' HC order

Her supporters blocked a road, stretched event beyond permitted time, say police



West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari in Birbhum on Saturday. PTI

Tanusrree Bose
Kolkata, August 29

THE KOLKATA Police on Friday lodged a suo moto case against former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee for allegedly violating the Calcutta High Court order in connection with the Trinamool Congress's student wing foundation day event on Friday.

According to police, Banerjee's supporters allegedly violated the court's direction by blocking both flanks of Cathedral Road, where the event was held, creating a chaotic situation, disrupting traffic and also continuing the programme beyond the permitted time.

The police also lodged an FIR against the organisers of the Trinamool Chhatra Parishad (TMCP) foundation day. The FIR against the TMC supremo was lodged based on a complaint filed by Sub-inspector Apu Baidya.

On Tuesday, a single bench of the Calcutta High Court granted permission to both the TMC factions to hold separate foundation day events of TMCP, the party's student wing, specifying that one flank of the road should not be blocked.

While the Mamata Banerjee-led TMC faction was allowed to hold the rally on Cathedral Road, Ritabrata Banerjee-led rebel faction was granted permission on Rani Rashmoni Avenue. The event was supposed to be held between noon and 3 pm on Friday.

The police alleged that Mamata entered into a criminal conspiracy with the TMCP members and provoked her supporters during the event. The complaint alleged that the crowd pushed aside the barricades and jostled with police personnel deployed for maintaining law and order.

The police have booked Banerjee under several sections, including criminal conspiracy, using force against a government worker to prevent them

• RUCKUS AT PARTY OFFICE: POLICE SUMMON ABHISHEK

Kolkata: Kolkata Police on Saturday issued summons to TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee in connection with the ruckus at his party office and asked him to appear at Shakespeare Sarani police on September 1. The summons was served at Abhishek's Kalighat residence late Saturday night. The police had filed FIRs against Abhishek, TMC MP Derek O'Brien and other leaders, following a ruckus at TMC's party office in Kolkata Thursday as police and KMC officials removed an alleged unauthorised hoarding atop the office. Three FIRs were filed at Shakespeare Sarani police station. Police said that during execution of the municipal order, TMC leaders formed an unlawful assembly, obstructed and restrained police and KMC officials from discharging their duties, while using criminal force against police and KMC officials. Abhishek alleged TMC leaders were harassed by the police. ENS

from doing their job, and causing hurt to another by acting rashly or negligently so as to endanger human life.

Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Friday said that the police would take action for violation of the court order.

Addressing the rally on Friday, Banerjee had criticised the West Bengal police, alleging the BJP had turned it into a "monstrous entity".

"I do not recognise this police force. The police force I worked with was humane, not inhuman. They helped people. There may have been a couple of isolated incidents, but I have seen police personnel stand their ground, suffer injuries and shed blood. They did not run bulldozers over people, fire tear gas or bullets indiscriminately. They stood beside the people," she had said at the TMCP rally.

Naveen writes to BJP MPs, seeks mines law amendment rollback: 'Black day for Odisha'

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, August 29

CALLING THE passage of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) law in Parliament a "black day" for Odisha, BJD president Naveen Patnaik on Saturday urged Odisha BJP MPs to seek reversal of the amendments.

"The Bill was passed with less than 10 minutes of discussion in Lok Sabha, despite having provisions with far-reaching implications for the people of Odisha. This was not an ordinary piece of legislation. Odisha undoubtedly will be the worst affected by this legislation," said ex-CM Patnaik in a letter to BJP MPs.

As Odisha accounts for nearly 44% of India's mineral wealth, Patnaik said the state has contributed its mineral wealth to the building of India's steel, power, mining and infrastructure sectors for decades.

Due to the amendment of the MMDR Act, passed by Par-

liament on August 13, Patnaik said the estimated annual loss would be more than Rs 12,000 crore, leading to lakhs of crores of rupees over time.

"But the bigger loss is that in a single legislative stroke the control over our own minerals and our mineral-bearing lands was taken away from us. And this happened under your watch," he added.

Patnaik, who earlier sought a special session of the Assembly to discuss the amendment's impact on Odisha, said the law is an injustice to the state's children and the youth, whose future is linked to the resources and opportunities of this State.

"It is an injustice to the people of Odisha who bear the pollution, displacement, environmental degradation and the hazards and hardships of mining. Above all, it is an injustice to the dream of an empowered Odisha, that has the confidence and resources to determine its own future," he said.



Give it a shot

Union Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal during a cricket match on the occasion of National Sports Day at the Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium in New Delhi on Saturday. PTI

Bihar Cong rebels plan to take fight with state leadership to Delhi, protest on Sep 8

Leaders claim they did not get an appointment with Kharge, Rahul to present their grievances against state leadership

Santosh Singh
Patna, August 29

THE SIMMERING tensions in the Bihar Congress since last year's defeat in the Assembly elections appear to be bubbling over as a group of the party's state leaders say that they plan to hold a protest outside the AICC office in New Delhi on September 8 to demand the removal of state Congress chief Rajesh Ram and AICC's Bihar in-charge Krishna Allavaru over alleged corruption.

Among these disgruntled leaders are party's former spokesperson Anand Madhav, former MLA Chhatrapati Yadav, and former Bihar Youth Congress chief Rajkumar Rajan, who are among the nine expelled from the party for 6 years on February 18.

They have challenged their expulsion, saying the state unit cannot expel them without due approval from AICC disciplinary

committee. The leaders claimed they had been trying to meet Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi to present their side of the story, but had not been given an appointment.

"We are the ones who flagged corruption at party organisation level. We had met Mallikarjun Kharge and senior leaders K C Venugopal and Ashok Gehlot on November 3 last year in a hotel in Patna. They assured us that we would be granted an audience after the Assembly elections. But despite our repeated attempts, we were not given time either by Kharge or by Rahul Gandhi," Anand Madhav told *The Indian Express*.

Madhav, who was chairman of the party's research wing in Bihar, said: "We are demanding the withdrawal of notices given to 47 Congress leaders, including us. The state unit exceeded its power and expelled nine of

us. According to the Congress constitution, they cannot do it."

Madhav said being denied a ticket for the Assembly polls was one of the reasons for their unhappiness with Allavaru and Ram. "The main reason was how even organisational posts are being sold out. There has been a sustained attempt to make it Congress-mukt Bihar by some Congress leaders themselves," he alleged. Rajesh Ram told *The Indian Express*, "All these leaders talking about protesting in Delhi have been expelled from the party. Our mandate from our top leaders is to strengthen the party. Criticism from any quarter will further motivate us to do better. The party has responded by expelling those making irresponsible statements."

"They (the expelled leaders) had been asked by our leaders in Delhi to discuss their issues with Bihar Congress head, but

“We are demanding the withdrawal of notices given to 47 Congress leaders, including us. The state unit exceeded its power and expelled nine of us. According to Congress constitution, they cannot do it.”

ANAND MADHAV
CONG'S FORMER SPOKESPERSON

they refused to do so," said Bihar Congress spokesperson Asit Nath Tiwari. Following the loss in elections, the state unit's disciplinary committee issued show-cause notices to 47 leaders, accusing them of engaging in anti-party activities. The leaders dismissed the allegations, accusing the state leadership of acting arbitrarily and conducting a partisan crackdown.

Soon, red hexagonal label to warn of high fat, sugar, salt in snacks

Ananthakrishnan G & Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, August 29

PROMPTED BY the Supreme Court, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has proposed introducing a red hexagonal front-of-pack label to warn consumers if packaged foods are high in salt, added sugar, or added fat.

“The proposal is intended to provide a simple, prominent and easily comprehensible warning to consumers regarding food products which are high in specified nutrients of concern,” the compliance affidavit filed by Kavitha Ramaswamy, Joint Director, FSSAI, before the SC said. The apex court is hearing a plea by a Kerala-based non-profit organisation, 3S and Our Health Society.

While there is no notification yet — nor a timeline for implementation — the country’s apex food safety regulator has stated

in its affidavit that the warning label, in English, will be carried on the front of the packet in a font size one point larger than the one used in the nutritional information table provided at the back of the pack.

The plan to introduce the Front-of-Pack Nutrition Labelling will be executed in two phases, as per the affidavit. In the first phase, only products with a high content of at least two of the ingredients will carry the warning label. In the second phase, the warning will extend to products high in even one ingredient.

The FSSAI affidavit proposes the warning label for packaged foods high in two or more ingredients of concern based on thresholds specified under the Dietary Guidelines for Indians, 2024, issued by the Indian Council of Medical Research-National Institute of Nutrition.

“The label shall indicate the applicable declarations such as ‘high fat’, ‘high sugar’, ‘high salt’

E. EXPLAINED

Nutrient threshold, use of ‘added’ term

EXPERTS SAY the two or more nutrient threshold in phase I may render the move ineffective as many unhealthy products would not need to add warning label since they are high in just one nutrient. They also flagged the challenge of the use of the term “added” as it is difficult to estimate.

and/or ‘highly sweetened beverage’, as the case may be, to enable consumers to identify products high in the specified nutrients,” the affidavit states.

Single-ingredient food products and “food products which are inherently rich in fat, sugar

or salt, such as ghee, edible oil, salt, sugar, jaggery and honey, subject to the applicability of other requirements under the food safety and labelling regulations”, will be exempted from the labelling requirement, the affidavit stated. The FSSAI said the two-phase plan is “to facilitate consumer acceptability and provide industry adequate time for reformulation”.

Advocate Rajiv Shankar Divedi, appearing for the petitioner, said, “We have received the FSSAI compliance affidavit. We have prepared a revised draft, which has been circulated on the petitioner’s website. We have invited comments from the public on the said rejoinder (affidavit). After getting all the comments, we will file our rejoinder.”

Nutrition experts have welcomed the move to introduce warning labels but have some concerns about the implementation. Dr Arun Gupta, Convener of Nutrition Advocacy in Public

Interest (NAPI)–India, said: “In principle, FSSAI has agreed to the warning labels, but they have put in a whole lot of conditions that make it ineffective. Take for example the two or more nutrient threshold in the phase I of implementation. Many unhealthy products would not need to add the warning label because they are high in just one nutrient.” He said the FSSAI has also not given any timeline for phase II when all products high in fats, sugars or salts will have to carry the warning.

Another challenge is the use of the term “added”. “The food products will have to carry the warning only when there are added sugars or added fats. One, this is difficult to estimate. Two, it is not just the added fat or added sugar that harms the health; high levels of natural sugars can also be bad.” He also said the font size proposed is too small and the message should be carried in Hindi as well.

Bar Council lacking respect of members not a good sign, says Justice Nagarathna

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 29

SUPREME COURT judge Justice B V Nagarathna on Saturday said a Bar Council that does not earn the respect of its members is “not a good sign for the legal profession” and called on Bar Councils to examine their role in upholding professional ethics.

Addressing the 13th convocation of National Law University Delhi, Justice Nagarathna said, “Bar Councils, whether Central or the States, must introspect on their role and importance in upholding professional ethics, morality and professional competence. When a Bar Council does not earn the respect of its members, it is not a good sign for the legal profession.”

This comes after demands seeking resignation of Bar Council of India (BCI) Chairman Manan Kumar Mishra over an August 13 directive asking state Bar Councils not



Justice B V Nagarathna

to enroll students of 2026 NALSAR batch.

Mishra withdrew the circular hours later, saying the BCI had closed the proceedings after concluding that the students had “no role in any disturbance or movement”. Earlier, BCI co-Chairman and senior advocate Y R Sadasiva Reddy addressed a letter to Mishra, asking him to resign.

Speaking at the National Law University, Justice Nagarathna referred to pendency, delays and litigation costs. The Bar in India must rethink its role in serving litigants, safeguarding democracy and

upholding the rule of law and that the Bar must “rise and speak in a singular voice” on sustaining the justice delivery system, Nagarathna said.

The top court judge said that lawyers must preserve a space where they can advise, argue and represent clients without external interference, as they are the “safety valves of democracies”.

“The independence of the Bar is not an entitlement given to lawyers for their own benefit,” said Justice Nagarathna. “It exists because a constitutional democracy requires a body of professionals who can advise, argue, challenge and represent without having to ask the permission of the State, the market, or even their own clients before doing so...do not allow the pursuit of a successful career to make you forget what makes your profession worth preserving in the first place. Guard its independence.”

ELGAAR PARISHAD CASE

Special court rejects NIA plea to cancel bail of four accused

Sadaf Modak
Mumbai, August 29

A SPECIAL court on Saturday refused to cancel the bail of four accused in the Elgaar Parishad case, holding that the NIA had failed to produce evidence that their presence at a January gathering at the Mumbai Press Club amounted to a violation of their bail conditions.

The four — lawyer Sudha Bharadwaj, Telugu poet Varavara Rao, activist Vernon Gonsalves and lawyer Arun Ferreira — are accused of helping organise the Elgaar Parishad event on December 31, 2017, which allegedly featured provocative speeches that led to caste clashes in Bhima Koregaon. The NIA had sought cancellation of their bail, alleging that they had breached a condition prohibiting them from contacting or communicating with co-accused. The agency claimed the four attended a January 19 gathering at the Press Club to discuss ways of furthering the ‘Urban Naxal’ movement.

Special Judge Chakor S Baviskar said the four had indeed gathered with other invitees at the Press Club and may have spoken to one another, possibly even discussing the case. But

that, by itself, could not establish a breach of their bail conditions.

“The prosecution has to establish it at least with some sort of acceptable evidence,” the court said, noting there was no evidence to show that the accused had gathered with the specific intention of propagating the activities of the banned CPI (Maoist). The court said the purpose of the bail condition was to prevent the accused from engaging in “similar activities” to those alleged in the case. “Sans any evidence to that effect, certainly, mere gathering of the accused falls short to conclude that the bail condition is breached,” it said. The court, however, said the accused should have exercised greater caution and refused themselves from the gathering to avoid any complications. The defence had argued that the four were invited by a third party and were unaware that the others would be present. Lawyers Yug Chaudhry and R Satyanarayan, appearing for Bharadwaj and Rao respectively, said the discussion was general and included issues such as prison conditions.

The court also noted that the accused routinely meet in court and corridors during hearings

and may speak to one another or discuss the case. Merely because the venues shifted from the courtroom to the Press Club, it said, could not amount to a breach of bail conditions.

It also examined CCTV footage of the gathering, which had no audio. The court said the mood and body language visible in the footage did not indicate that the accused were discussing serious issues such as the ideology of the banned organisation.

Bharadwaj was granted bail by the Bombay High Court in December 2021, while Rao was granted interim bail on medical grounds in February 2021, which was later confirmed by the Supreme Court in August 2022. Gonsalves and Ferreira were granted bail by the Supreme Court in July 2023. The trial is yet to begin. The NIA had approached Mumbai Press Club of office-bearers in April, two days after three members were suspended over the January 19 event. The suspensions followed an internal committee report that raised concerns about the bail conditions of the accused who attended the gathering. The three members were reinstated after elections at the club last month.

Andhra CM launches AI-powered platform for CAs and MSMEs

Express News Service
Hyderabad, August 29

ANDHRA PRADESH Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on August 27 launched Pramaan OS, an AI-powered practice operating system for Chartered Accountant firms and the MSMEs they serve.

According to Pramanique Fintech Pvt Ltd, the Andhra Pradesh-incorporated technology company that developed the OS, Naidu reviewed the platform’s AI-driven accounting automation, statutory compliance management and information security capabilities, and appreciated the initiative and its scope for national expansion.

The firm said its AI architecture is intended to organise and interpret financial and business information, automate routine workflows, identify gaps and exceptions, assist with compliance-related activities, generate insights and improve communication between professionals and clients.

For CA firms, the company said, the platform could reduce the time spent collecting docu-



Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu

ments, following up on routine tasks, monitoring deadlines and carrying out repetitive processes, allowing professionals to focus more on professional judgement and advisory work. For MSMEs, it is intended to provide a more organised and accessible financial and compliance environment.

The company described its journey as “Amaravati to America”. It said the journey began with interactions with hundreds of CAs at DAKSHA, a CA conference organised by the Southern India Regional Council of ICAI in Guntur on July 7 and 8, before extending across India.

MAHARASHTRA SMALL SCALE INDUSTRIES DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION LIMITED
(A Government of Maharashtra Undertaking)
Marhati Maharashtra Government Emporium,
A-8 State Emporium Complex, Baba Khadk Singh Marg, Opp. Hanuman Mandir Connaught Place, New Delhi - 110001 Contact No. 011-23363366, Mob. 9667088649 Email: mssidcltd@gmail.com
GRAND EXHIBITION AND SALE OF GANESH IDOLS
Maharashtra Small Industries Development Corporation Ltd., Mumbai is organizing a grand exhibition and sale of Attractive, Traditional, Eco-Friendly Ganesha Idols made from Shadu clay by skilled artisans from Pen, Dist. Raigad, Maharashtra at the Marhati Maharashtra Government Emporium, A-8 State Emporium Complex, Baba Khadk Singh Marg, Opp. Hanuman Mandir, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001 from date 03.09.2026 to 14.09.2026 from 10.00 am to 6.00 pm.
All Lord Ganesha devotees and citizens are requested to take benefit of this exhibition and sale.
In-Charge Manager
Marhati Maharashtra Emporium, New Delhi

Karnataka man acquitted in 2015 murder case hacked to death in public

Atiya Firdos
Bengaluru, August 29

A MAN acquitted in a 2015 murder case was hacked to death in public in Karnataka’s Hubbali on Friday afternoon, with the police suspecting the killing was linked to an old enemy.

According to the police, the victim, Dadapeer Udayakar, was riding a two-wheeler near Siddeshwara Park in Banashankari Layout in Vidyanagar around 1 pm when two unidentified men allegedly intercepted him and attacked him with sharp weapons. The assailants fled the spot after the attack.

According to preliminary information, Udayakar was an accused in the 2015 murder of a person named Maruti.

He was acquitted in the case in 2017, the police said. However, the police are yet to ascertain whether the killing was connected to the earlier case or any existing enmity.

Senior police officials, including Hubbali City Police Commissioner N Shashikumar, visited the spot and reviewed the circumstances.

Police teams have been formed to trace the attackers and CCTV footage from the area is being examined to establish their movements.

“We are trying to zero down on the accused and will register a case,” Shashikumar told the media on Friday.

A senior police official said the accused are yet to be traced and further investigation is underway.

NATIONAL LAW UNIVERSITY, TRIPURA

Re-Advertisement No. NLUT/Faculty-Recruitment/2026/01
Date: 27.08.2026

RECRUITMENT NOTICE FOR TEACHING POSITIONS

Applications are invited from the prospective and eligible candidates for the post of **Professor of Law (UR-2), Associate Professor Law (UR-2), and Assistant Professor Sociology (SC-1)**, on regular basis. Pay Scale and qualifications as per UGC Regulations. Please visit University website www.nlutripura.ac.in for number of posts, qualifications, General Instruction, Eligibility criteria and other details.
Date for release of online application form **31st August, 2026**
Last Date for submission of filled in application **16th September, 2026.**
*Those Candidates who have already applied earlier need not to apply again.

Sd/-
Registrar (I/C)

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
MINISTRY OF DEFENCE EX-SERVICEMEN CONTRIBUTORY HEALTH SCHEME
STATION HQ (ECHS CELL), DELHI CANTT
Phone : 011-25694821, email: oicechscelldelhi@gmail.com

EMPLOYMENT NOTICE
1. ECHS invites applications to engage following Medical, Para Medical & Non Medical Staff on contractual basis in 10 x ECHS Polyclinics Delhi Cantt, Shakurbasti, Sohna Road, Dundaheera, Dwarka, Lodhi Road, Timarpur, NOIDA (Sect-37), NOIDA (Sect-82) & Greater NOIDA for a period of one year renewable for additional period of one year/till attaining the maximum age subject to performance of candidates/other conditions according to the criteria as mentioned against each post:-

Category	Minimum Qualification	No of Vac in FY 2026-27	Fixed Remuneration
Medical Specialist	MD/MS in Specialty concerned/DNB. Minimum 03 years in the specialty after PG.	04	Rs. 1,30,000/-
Medical Officer	MBBS. Minimum 03 years work experience after internship.	17	Rs. 95,000/-
Dental Assistant/ Hygienist	Diploma Holder in Dental Hygienist/Class-I DH/ DORA Course (Armed Forces). Minimum 05 years work experience.	03	Rs. 36,500/-
Physiotherapist	Diploma/Class-I Physiotherapy Course (Armed Forces).	02	Rs. 36,500/-
Clerk	Graduate/Class-I Clerical Trade (Armed Forces). Minimum 05 years work experience	04	Rs. 36,500/- Rs. 29,200/-

2. For Terms & Conditions, Application Form & Remuneration. Kindly see our website www.echs.gov.in. For additional details, please contact Stn HQ (ECHS Cell) Delhi Cantt at Telephone No 011-25694821, Mobile No 8448198118 & email ID oicechscelldelhi@gmail.com. Preference will be given to the Ex-servicemen. **3. Last date of receipt of application as per format given at our website.** Application as per requisite format along with self attested photocopies of testimonials in support of Educational Qualifications and Work Experiences will be submitted to OIC, Stn HQ (ECHS Cell) Delhi Cantt-110010 by 26th September 2026. Any application received after 26th September 2026 will not be accepted. **4. Interview Date, Timing & Venue.** The same will be intimated to candidates through email and telephonically. Candidates must bring all the original certificates/mark sheets/degree of 10th/Matric, 10+2 & Graduation/Post Graduation/Diploma/Course, work experience and discharge book, PPO, service records and 02 x PP size colour photographs at the time of interview. No TA/DA is admissible. Only candidates meeting the Qualitative Requirements may apply. **5.** Individual once appointed no request for change of ECHS Establishment will be considered in first 12 months of employment.

India Tourism Development Corporation Limited
(A Government of India Undertaking)
Registered Office: SCOPE Complex Core-8, 6th Floor, 7 Lodhi Road, New Delhi-110003
CIN: L74899DL1965GGI004363, Email: manishkumar@itdc.co.in, [011-24360303](tel:011-24360303), www.itdc.co.in

NOTICE OF THE 61st ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, E-VOTING INFORMATION AND BOOK CLOSURE
1. Notice is hereby given that the 61st Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Members of the Company will be held on Tuesday, the 22nd September, 2026 at 12:00 Hours IST, through Video Conferencing (VC)/Other Audio Visual Means (OAVM), without the physical presence of the members at common venue, to transact the business set out in the AGM Notice dated 27th August, 2026. The information and instructions for Members attending the AGM through VC/OAVM and e-voting during AGM, are explained in Notes to the Notice of AGM.
2. In accordance with the circulars of MCA and SEBI, the Notice of AGM and the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 have been sent by email to all those Members of the Company, whose email addresses are registered with the Company/Registrar Transfer Agent (RTA) or the Depository Participant(s). The aforesaid documents are also available on the website of the Company at <https://itdc.co.in/> and also on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited and NSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com, respectively and on the website of KFin Technologies Limited, the Registrar & Share Transfer Agent of the Company at <https://evoting.kfintech.com>.
3. A letter with the web-link and path to the Annual Report 2025-26 and 61st AGM Notice have been sent to the shareholders whose email addresses are not registered with Company.
4. Notice is hereby given that pursuant to Section 91 of the Act and Regulation 42 of the Listing Regulations, the Register of Members and Share Transfer Book of the Company will be closed from Friday, the 18th September, 2026 to Tuesday, 22nd September, 2026 (both days inclusive) for the purpose of annual closing. The record date for payment of dividend to the shareholders is Tuesday, the 15th September, 2026.
5. In compliance with the provisions of Section 108 of the Act read with relevant Rules thereunder and Regulation 44 of the Listing Regulations, the Company is pleased to provide its Members, facility to exercise their right to vote at the 61st AGM and the business may be transacted through remote e-voting services. Remote e-voting is optional. The facility of e-voting shall also be made available at the AGM. Members attending the AGM and who have not already cast their vote by remote e-voting shall be able to exercise their right to cast vote at the AGM.
6. The remote e-voting period will begin on Thursday, the 17th September, 2026 from 09:00 A.M. and will end on Monday, the 21st September, 2026 at 05:00 P.M. The remote e-voting shall not be allowed beyond the said date and time.
7. The manner of remote e-voting and e-voting at the AGM by the Members holding shares in physical mode or dematerialized mode and for the Members who have not registered/updated their e-mail addresses with the Company/Depository, is provided in the Notice of the AGM.
8. The Cut-off date for determining the eligibility of the Members to vote by remote e-voting at the AGM is Tuesday, the 15th September, 2026. A person whose name is recorded in the Register of Members or in the Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories as on the cut-off date, shall only be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting.
9. Any person, who acquires shares of the Company and becomes Member of the Company after dispatch of the Notice of AGM and holding shares as on the cut-off date i.e. Tuesday, the 15th September, 2026 may follow the same instructions for remote e-voting and e-voting at the AGM as mentioned in the Notice of AGM. Detailed procedure for obtaining Login ID/User ID and Password is also provided in the Notice of the AGM.
10. Members who have already voted prior to the AGM may attend the AGM but shall not be entitled to vote at the AGM.
11. Physical shareholders are hereby notified that based on SEBI Master Circular number: HO/38/13/4(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/1/4298/2026 dated February 06, 2026, all holders of physical securities in listed companies shall register the postal address with PIN for their corresponding folio numbers. It shall be mandatory for the security holders to provide mobile number. Moreover, to avail online services, the security holders can register their e-mail ID. Shareholders can register/update the contact details through submitting the requisite ISR-1 form along with the supporting documents. ISR-1 Form can be obtained by following the link: <https://ris.kfintech.com/client-services/isc/default.aspx>. Detailed FAQ can be found on the link: <https://ris.kfintech.com/faq.html>
12. Members holding shares in dematerialised mode, who have not registered/updated their email addresses with the Depository Participant(s), are requested to register/update their email addresses with their Depository Participant(s).
13. Members are requested to read the Instruction pertaining to e-voting printed in the AGM Notice carefully. Any query pertaining to e-voting, please visit Help & FAQs section available at RTA website (<https://evoting.kfintech.com>). In case of any other queries/grievances connected to remote e-voting or shares, you may contact Mr. G Sankara, an official of RTA, at toll free number 1800-309-4001 or at email: evoting@kfintech.com.
14. Shareholders may note that as per SEBI Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/1/3750/2026 dated 30th January 2026, a Special Window has been opened for a period of one year, i.e., from 5th February 2026 to 4th February 2027 to facilitate transfer and dematerialisation of physical securities which were sold/purchased prior to 1st April 2019 and for transfer requests which were submitted prior to 1st April 2019 and were rejected/returned/not attended to due to deficiency in the documents/process/or otherwise. Concerned shareholders are advised to take note of this opportunity and re-lodge their transfer requests along with requisite documents. For any requests/queries, Investors/Transferees may Contact RTA of the Company at Selenium Building, Tower-B, Plot No. 31 & 32, Financial District, Nanakramguda, Serlingampally, Hyderabad, Telangana, 500032, Toll Free - 1800 309 4001; Email- eiinward.ris@kfintech.com.
15. **TDS on Dividend:** Shareholders may note that in terms of provisions of the Income Tax Act, 2025 ("the Act") as amended by the Finance Act, 2025, dividend paid or distributed by a company on or after 1st April, 2020 is taxable in the hands of the shareholders. The Company is, therefore, required to deduct tax at source at the time of payment of dividend to the shareholders. In order to enable us to determine the appropriate TDS rate, as applicable, shareholders are required to submit necessary forms/documents in accordance with the provisions of the Income Tax Act upto 15th September, 2026. The necessary documents, as applicable, required to be emailed at manishkumar@itdc.co.in to enable the company to determine appropriate TDS rates.

For India Tourism Development Corporation Limited
Date: 28.08.2026
Place: New Delhi

Sd./- V.K. Jain
(Company Secretary)

epaper.indianexpress.com

Kishtwar girl’s rape-death probe handed to Crime Branch amid cover-up allegations

Arun Sharma
Jammu, August 29

AMID ALLEGATIONS of a cover-up, the J&K government has ordered the Crime Branch to investigate the alleged sexual assault and death of a tribal teenager in Kishtwar.

The move comes days after allegations of prolonged sexual abuse of the minor and a subse-

quent abortion attempt that preceded her death sparked protests across the district.

Officials told *The Indian Express* that the Crime Branch has initiated the process to take over the investigation from the Special Investigation Team currently probing the case. The move comes after at least six people, including a nurse and a sweeper at the Kishtwar district

hospital, were arrested for alleged complicity after the girl was brought there for an alleged abortion attempt that proved fatal.

The others arrested are the accused headmaster and three of his relatives.

The petition said the girl was seven months pregnant at the time of her death.

The handover comes amid a writ petition filed by the girl's father in the Jammu, Kashmir and Ladakh High Court, which alleges a cover-up.

The father said he became aware of his daughter's pregnancy only after she was taken to a health centre a fortnight before her death. He further alleged that the headmaster and others linked to him — including a local chemist and two teachers — tried to cover it up.

“The role of each of these persons, their communication with the accused, and their knowledge concerning the pregnancy and the circumstances thereafter require investigation,” he submitted.

‘Papa, save me’: Woman, her newborn die in MP hospital, probe underway

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, August 29

HOURS BEFORE Kalpana Mishra died, shortly after giving birth to her first child at a government hospital in Madhya Pradesh's Rewa, she pleaded with her family to take her home. “If this kind of treatment continues, these people will kill me,” the 25-year-old is purportedly heard saying in a video recorded inside the hospital. “I won't survive. Please save me, my life is in danger.”

Within hours, Kalpana and her newborn were dead.

The hospital has said Kalpana has not done necessary check-ups during her pregnancy and that her blood pressure and heart rate had spiked.

A formal inquiry has been ordered into the death.

In videos from her final hours, she appears distressed, repeatedly reaching towards relatives as hospital staff try to stop her from leaving.

Kalpana, a resident of Hatwa in Rewa district, was admitted to Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital on August 25. She underwent a C-section around 8.30 pm the next day and delivered a baby.

According to her relatives, her condition subsequently deteriorated, and she died while undergoing treatment on Thursday. The newborn did not survive either.

Her father, Ramsharan Mishra, claimed he repeatedly asked doctors to examine Kal-

pana and keep a closer watch on her condition, but she was not given adequate care.

“Kalpana was my only daughter... Today, she has left us. The police must register an FIR against those responsible. The doctor on duty and the staff should be suspended. Before her death, she told me, ‘Papa, save me. These people will kill me,’” he claimed.

Meanwhile, hospital superintendent Dr Rahul Mishra said Kalpana had not undergone the recommended number of antenatal check-ups.

“The incident is unfortunate. The family made a very serious lapse. As per protocol, a pregnant woman should undergo at least eight examinations. Looking at her docu-

ments, we found that she had been examined only twice, and both examinations were done at a private hospital. Because her blood pressure and heart rate increased, Kalpana lost consciousness,” he said.

Mishra described the deaths as tragic and said the question of why Kalpana did not regain consciousness would form part of the investigation.

“A high-level inquiry committee has been constituted and two nursing officers have been suspended. This is a medical matter. Why the patient did not regain consciousness is a subject of investigation, and action will be taken against whoever is found responsible based on the inquiry's findings,” he said.



H.P. STATE HANDICRAFTS & HANDLOOM CORPORATION LIMITED
(A State Government Undertaking)
SDA Commercial Complex, Kasumpti, Shimla-171009
CIN: U32301HP1974SGC003419 | GST: 02AAACH4039F1Z6
Tel.: 0177-2621557, 2621275

TENDER NOTICE
NOTICE INVITING TENDERS (NIT) FOR ALLOTMENT OF DIFFERENT SALES COUNTERS ON MINIMUM SALE GUARANTEE (MSG) BASIS.
Managing Director, H.P. State Handicrafts and Handloom Corporation Ltd hereby electronically invites competitive bids/offers from the original manufacturers or traders having a valid Goods and Service Tax (GST) number for allotment of different sales counter(s) situated in the different emporia of the Corporation. The schedule of receipt and opening of bids and other details are as under:-

Date and time for uploading of bidding documents on e-procurement portal		Date and time for online submission of bids, required documents and deposit on processing fee & earnest money		Date & time of opening of Tender/ Technical bid
From	To	From	To	Tender Opening
31.08.2026 4.00PM	21.09.2026 4.00 PM	31.08.2026 4.00 PM	21.09.2026 4.00 PM	22.09.2026 11.00AM

1. The bidder/tenderer shall deposit a non refundable one time processing fee of Rs. 5,000/- for participation in the tender.

2. The bidder/tenderer is required to deposit earnest money of Rs. 25,000/- for each counter, it chooses to bid for.

3. The EMD of successful bidders would be adjusted against the performance security and EMD of unsuccessful bidders would be refunded without interest, within 15 days after finalization of the tender.

4. Corrigendum, if any, will be published on <https://hptenders.gov.in> (website only) and also on the website of the Corporation <http://www.himcrafts.com>. Bidders should register themselves on the website <https://hptenders.gov.in>. The bids shall be opened in the office of Managing Director, HPSHHC Shimla by the authorized officers.

5. The detailed tender/bid notice inter-alia including eligibility, qualification criteria, scope of work, procedure for deposit of processing fee & EMD, Counter Numbers, terms & conditions can be viewed or downloaded from <https://hptenders.gov.in> and <http://www.himcrafts.com>.

6. The bidders have to upload clear copies of all the required documents. Documents that are illegible, incomplete, or not duly signed may not be considered and may lead to rejection of bid.

7. The bidders are advised to quote their best/competitive offer for allotment of counter(s) in different emporia of the Corporation.

8. If the date of opening of tender is declared a holiday, the tender will be opened on next working date at the same time.

9. The Managing Director reserves the right to accept or reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason thereof, in accordance with the terms and conditions of the tender.

Sd/-

Managing Director



AMARAVATI GROWTH AND INFRASTRUCTURE CORPORATION LIMITED (AGICL)
Rayapudi, Amaravati - 522237 (A.P.)

E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE
S. No. NIT No. & Name of Work
1. NIT No. 36/PROC/MAU61/194/2026-HB/2nd Call, Dated: 29-08-2026
Name of Work: "Providing Façade Glazing & Cladding works like Glass, Cladding, Crown, Atrium, Canopy Skylight, Column Cladding, PV Panel & BMU works in Integrated Andhra Pradesh State Secretariat & HoD Offices (GAD Tower) in Amaravati Government Complex, Andhra Pradesh" Est. Cost - Rs.442.00 Crores
2. NIT No. 37/PROC/MAU61-USIOHB(OTH)/148/2026-HB/2nd Call, Dated: 29-08-2026
Name of Work: "Providing Façade Glazing & Cladding works like Glass, Cladding, Crown, Atrium, Canopy Skylight, Column Cladding, PV Panel & BMU works in Integrated Andhra Pradesh State Secretariat & HoD Offices (Tower 3&4) in Amaravati Government Complex, Andhra Pradesh" Est. Cost - Rs.727.00 Crores
3. NIT No. 38/PROC/MAU61-USIOHB(TWR)/1/2026-HB/2nd Call, Dated: 29-08-2026
Name of Work: "Providing Façade Glazing & Cladding works like Glass, Cladding, Crown, Atrium, Canopy Skylight, Column Cladding, PV Panel & BMU works in Integrated Andhra Pradesh State Secretariat & HoD Offices (Tower 1&2) in Amaravati Government Complex, Andhra Pradesh" Est. Cost - Rs.909.00 Crores

The bid can be downloaded on AP e-procurement portal from 31.08.2026 to 07.09.2026 up to 14.00 Hrs. Due date for submission of Bid is 07.09.2026 up to 15.00 Hrs, Technical bid opening 07.09.2026 @16.00Hrs. For further details Please refer to www.approcurement.gov.in and www.agicl.org.
Sd/- Chief Engineer (H&B), APCRDA, Amaravati



JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F), email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice
Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Chand Mohan alias Papi S/O Kasturi Lal Rajput R/O House No. 44, Bhagwati Nagar, Jammu is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 80/2003 U/S 279/337/338 RPC, of P/S Bahu Fort, Jammu. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-
Name : Chand Mohan alias Papi
S/O : Kasturi Lal Rajput
Address : House No. 44, Bhagwati Nagar, Jammu.
Age : 55-60 Years

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-
1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail ID : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949
4. SP City South : 0191-2430002
5. SDPO City East : 01912433778
6. P/S Bahu Fort : 0191-2475133

Sr.

Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP NO. DIP/J-8978/26 DATE: 29.08.2026



UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR
OFFICE THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD (R&B) PROJECT DIVISION- III, JAMMU
SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER
Short e-NIT No. 44 of 2026-2027 Dated 27-08-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir e-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State / Central Governments for each of the following works:-

S. No.	Name of Work:	Name of Division	Advertised cost (Rs. in lakh.)	Cost of Tender document (in Rs.)	Earnest Money (in Rs.)	Time Allowed for completion	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
1.	Upgradation of Govt Qtr. no. 26 A Gandhi Nagar Jammu. CNo-123 P	PWD (R&B) Project Div. III, Jammu	19.20	600	2% of Advertised Cost	75 Days	(1300 Hrs) on or after 03-08-2026	A, B & C
2.	Construction of Room at Govt. Quarter No. 10-B Gandhi Nagar Jammu. CNo-124 P	PWD (R&B) Project Div. III, Jammu	14.40	600	2% of Advertised Cost	60 Days	(1300 Hrs) on or after 03-08-2026	A, B, C & D
3.	Upgradation of Flat No 17, Gandhi Nagar Jammu. CNo-127 P	PWD (R&B) Project Div. III, Jammu	0.96	600	2% of Advertised Cost	20 Days	(1300 Hrs) on or after 03-08-2026	A, B, C & D
4.	Upgradation of Flat No. 47 and Flat No. 03 Last Mark, Gandhi Nagar Jammu. CNO-128 P	PWD (R&B) Project Div. III, Jammu	3.84	600	2% of Advertised Cost	30 Days	(1300 Hrs) on or after 03-08-2026	A, B, C & D
5.	Upgradation of Flat No 48 Last Mark, Gandhi Nagar Jammu. CNO-129 P	PWD (R&B) Project Div. III, Jammu	1.92	600	2% of Advertised Cost	30 Days	(1300 Hrs) on or after 03-08-2026	A, B, C & D
6.	Upgradation of Govt. Flats at Panna chowk, Jammu. CNo-130 P	PWD (R&B) Project Div. III, Jammu	19.20	600	2% of Advertised Cost	75 Days	(1300 Hrs) on or after 03-08-2026	A, B & C

Position of AAA: Accredited
Position of T&S: Under Process
The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen / downloaded from the departmental website <http://jtenders.gov.in> as per below schedule:-

1. Date of Issue of Tender Notice	27-08-2026
2. Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 27-08-2026 to 02-09-2026 upto 1800 Hrs
3. Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	31-08-2026 at 1200 Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Project Division III, Jammu
4. Bid submission Start Date	27-08-2026
5. Bid Submission End Date	02-09-2026 upto 1800 Hrs
6. Date & Time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	03-09-2026 on or after 1300 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Project Division III, Jammu
7. Date & time of opening of Financial Bids	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

No:- PWD(R&B)/PD-III/5081-93
Dated: 27-08-2026

Sd/-
(Er. Rajat Gupta)
Executive Engineer
Project Division III, Jammu

DIP NO. DIP/J-8999/26 DATE: 29.08.2026



CHOLAMANDALAM INVESTMENT AND FINANCE COMPANY LIMITED
Corporate Office: "CHOLA CREST", C54 & 55, Super B-4, Thiru.Vi.Ka Industrial Estate, Guindy, Chennai - 600 032.

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES
E-auction Sale Notice for the Sale of Immovable Assets under Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, r/w rule 8(6) & 9 (1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. (Rule 8 & 9)
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower / Co-Borrower/ Mortgagee (s) that the below described immovable properties mortgaged to the Secured Creditor, the Physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Company Limited the same shall be referred herein after as Cholamandalam investment and Finance Company Limited. The Secured Assets will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is", and "Whatever there is" basis through E-Auction.
It is hereby informed to General public that we are going to conduct public E-Auction through website <https://bankauctions.in/>

Loan Account No. TL01NDL00000051163, Name of Borrower, Co-Borrower, Mortgagees: 1. M/s. Guru Ji Enterprises, (Borrower), Plot No. 76-77, Left Portion Ground Floor, Wazirpur Group Industrial Area, North West Delhi - 110 052. 2.Mr. Som Dutt Bhandari, (Co Borrower) (Deceased) 3. Mrs. Pooja Bhandari, (Co Borrower) 4. Mr. Vishal Bhandari, (Legal Heir of the Deceased) (Co Borrower) No 3 & 4 are residing at: Plot No. 66, Block –B, 1st Floor, Jeevan Niketan, LIC Colony, Near 910 Bus Stop, Paschim Vihar, West Delhi – 110 087. 5. Mr. Vikash Bhandari, (Legal Heir of the Deceased), B - 27, 1st Floor, LIC Colony, Near ST. MARHS School, Paschim Vihar, West Delhi - 110 087. **Outstanding Amount: Rs. 2,14,17,630/- as on 26.08.2026.**
DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY :
All that a piece and parcel of the Property bearing Entire First Floor without roof rights, "the said floor" Part of Property no.66, area measuring 196.96 sq. yds., situated in the layout plan of The Northern Zone Insurance Employees Co-operative House Building Society Limited known as Block-B, Jeevan Colony LIC colony, Paschim Vihar, New Delhi – 110 087 and which is bounded as under:- East :- Plot no.65, West :- Plot no.67, North :- Service Lane 15 Ft wide, South :- Road 80 Ft wide.
Reserve Price : Rs. 2, 28,80,000/-, EMD : Rs. 22,88,000/-, Bid Increment Amount : Rs.1,00,000/-
E-Auction Date and Time : 18.09.2026, - 11 AM to 12 PM (with unlimited extension of 3 min each)
Last Date of Submission of EMD : 17.09.2026, Date of Inspection of Property : As per the appointment

1. All Interested participants / bidders are requested to visit the website <https://bankauctions.in/> & www.foreclosureindia.com. For details: help, procedure and online training on e-auction, prospective bidders may contact M/s.4 Closure, (Contact Person: Mr. Shailendra, Ph. No. 9515160061, Email: shailendra@bankauctions.in).

2. For further details on terms and conditions please visit:- <https://bankauctions.in/> & <https://cholamandalam.com/news/auction-notices> to take part in e-auction or contact Mr. Ved Prakash Mishra - 9910144252 / Mr. Naveen Kapoor - Ph: 77550 01547 / Mr. Kapil Sharma - Ph: 9205308879.

THIS IS ALSO A STATUTORY 15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9 (1) RULE 8 & 9 AND OF SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002

Date: 30.08.2026
Place: Delhi

Sd/-

Authorized Officer
Cholamandalam investment and Finance Company Limited.



GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE MISSION DIRECTOR:
AMRUT ASSAM DISPUR, GUWAHATI-6
Email: amrutassam2016@gmail.com

No.AS/AMRUT-2.0/31/2025/109
Short e-PROCUREMENT NOTICE/INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB)
Online Bids through e-procurement portal www.assamtenders.gov.in are invited from the Government registered Class I or II or its equivalent contractors/firms registered under PWD Assam and having extensive experience in the relevant field for the following work:

Name of Activity	Tender Value	Bid security (EMD)	Tender fees	Last date & Time of Bid submission	Date & Time of Bid opening
Rejuvenation of Water Body at Dhakuakhana Town, Dist:- Lakhimpur under AMRUT-2.0 with Operation & Maintenance for 1 year.	₹ 55,00,000.00 (Capex): ₹ 54,00,000.00 + O&M: ₹1,00,000.00)	1,10,000.00	5,000.00	23/09/26 at 14:00 hours	24/09/2026 at 14:00 hours

The tender documents can be downloaded from www.assamtenders.gov.in from 07.09.2026 (12:00 hours) and Pre bid date and time: 14/09/2026 at 12:00 hours at the Office of the Mission Directorate, AMRUT, Assam, Dispur, Guwahati-6. The bid will be opened online on the E-procurement portal as per schedule mentioned above.
Completion time of the project: 6 months.
The TIA reserve the right to accept or reject any bid/tender, and to cancel/annul the bidding process and reject all the bids at any time prior to the contract award without assigning any reason thereof.

Sd//

Mission Director, AMRUT Assam, Dispur, Guwahati-6

DIPR/CF/IXP/1397/30-AUG-26



उत्तर प्रदेश राजकीय निर्माण निगम लि०
विश्वेश्वरय्या भवन, विभूति खण्ड, गोमती नगर, लखनऊ-226010

पत्रांक: 1708/का०अनु०-1/रानि/2026 दिनांक 27.08.2026
सूचना
सूचित किया जाता है कि उत्तर प्रदेश राजकीय निर्माण निगम लि० में विभिन्न न्यायालयों में चल रहे वादों की प्रभावी पैरवी एवं आवश्यक विधिक परामर्श हेतु एक सेवानिवृत्त जिला न्यायाधीश अथवा मा० उच्च न्यायाधीश को विधिक सलाहकार के रूप में रखा जाना है।
उक्त पद पर आवेदन करने की अन्तिम तिथि 07.09.2026 है।
आवश्यक विवरण निगम की अधिकारिक वेब-साइट www.uprnn.upsdc.gov.in पर उपलब्ध रहेगें।
अतिरिक्त महाप्रबन्धक (कार्मिक)



JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F), email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice
Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Mohd Ramzan S/O Abdul Sitar R/O Shami Pura Kashmir is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 38/1992 U/S 20/23/29 NDPS Act of P/S Bahu Fort, Jammu. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded.

It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-
Name : Mohd Ramzan
S/O : Abdul Sitar
Address : Shami Pura Kashmir

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-
1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail ID : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2605949
4. SP City South : 0191-2430002
5. SDPO City East : 01912433778
6. P/S Bahu Fort : 0191-2475133

Sr.

Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP NO. DIP/J-8980/26 DATE 29.08.2026

Nepal Disaster

SUNDAY, AUGUST 30, 2026

9



Survivors from flood-ravaged Betrawati in Umerkot district wait for help and transport at a camp on Saturday. TASHI TOBGYAL

FOUR DAYS SINCE THE DEVASTATING FLASH FLOODS IN NEPAL, SURVIVORS RETURN HOME TO SAFETY AS TRAUMA CONTINUES FOR FAMILIES OF THOSE MISSING

‘We felt we had been reborn’

Saree becomes lifeline for 21 TN pilgrims in flood escape

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, August 29

A SAREE lowered from the top of a mud-covered embankment became a lifeline for a group of mostly older pilgrims as floodwaters and falling boulders engulfed a mountain road near the Nepal-Tibet border. The 21 survivors reached Chennai from Kathmandu on Friday night, recounting an escape that required them to scramble from their bus, climb through mud and thorny undergrowth and spend a day and a half awaiting evacuation.

The others travelling in their three-bus contingent remained unaccounted for on Saturday, as did a separate group of 49 pilgrims from Chennai. Navu Kabirdas and his wife, Vijaya Bhuvaneshwari, residents of Murugu Nagar in Velachery, said they felt as though they had been reborn.

The couple were among 57 people travelling through Rasuwa in three buses arranged by a Kumbakonam-based agency. Their bus, the second in the convoy, had briefly stopped for repairs after getting stuck in mud. Bhuvaneshwari said those few minutes ultimately saved them.

“Suddenly, we heard a loud noise like a bomb explosion, and stones began falling on the van,” Kabirdas said. “Then the floodwater came rushing in as though a dam had been opened.”

Bhuvaneshwari said she saw the bus behind them beginning to tilt but could not bear to continue watching. Their Nepalese driver recognised the danger, told everyone to get out and run upwards, and fled the vehicle. The passengers followed.

The 21 survivors, most of them over 50, had to climb a muddy rise approximately one storey high. Poongodi, a member of the group who had reached the top, put on her sweater, removed her saree and lowered it towards the others. “We held tightly on to both the saree and a cable that was there and climbed up,” Bhuvaneshwari said. “Finally, one woman alone was unable to climb. We told her to tie the saree around her waist, and the people in our group held on to it and lifted her straight up,” Sathya, a Panchayat

Union School headmistress from Kanchipuram district, said the pilgrims had left Syabrubesi at 8 am for Chinese immigration. Their bus was in the middle when they saw what initially appeared to be a cloud of dust. “Rocks and mud were rolling towards us like a tsunami wave, rising to a height of about 70 to 80 feet,” she said. “We had seen things like this only in English films.”

The passengers escaped through the driver’s side, with mud already above their ankles. “There was no path to climb the mountain. If we climbed four feet, we would slide down five feet,” Sathya said.

After reaching an Armed Police Force camp, the group received water and biscuits. Through people who still had a cell-phone signal, they sent a photograph to Tamil Nadu as proof that they were safe. At one point during the climb, they saw a man trapped in the mud waving for help. They alerted rescue personnel, who later rescued him, Bhuvaneshwari said.

The following day, the pilgrims walked for three hours through thorny bushes and along a narrow mountain path to reach a helicopter evacuation point. “If we made a mistake, we would fall 50 feet below,” Kabirdas said. “At one point, we went the wrong way. A Nepalese man guided us. We had to climb down and then go upwards in another direction. Climbing down was more difficult than climbing up.”

Sivaranjani, a survivor from Tiruchi, said their bus had escaped because it was positioned in a triangular space at a bend. “When that enormous wave came, it struck the rock directly opposite and moved away,” she said. “All 21 of us got down one by one and climbed the mountain, slipping as we went.”

They were flown to safety in a military helicopter and subsequently travelled through Kathmandu and New Delhi before reaching Chennai. Some had lost passports and other documents.

“The vehicle travelling with us was swept away by the water behind us,” one survivor said, thanking the Nepal government, Nepal Army, Indian Embassy and Tamil Nadu government. “For us, this was truly a miraculous journey.”



A survivor receives medical help at a camp in Umerkot district. TASHI TOBGYAL

Hydropower capacity hit, Nepal seeks advance power imports from India

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 29

THE NEPAL government has sought advance approvals to import electricity from India from September to mitigate a generation shortfall caused by the recent disaster, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Electricity trade between Nepal and India is seasonal, with Nepal exporting surplus power to India during the monsoon and importing electricity during the dry winter months when domestic hydropower generation declines. Usually, Nepal makes such requests for electricity imports from India around October. This year, however, the request has come earlier after flash floods damaged the country’s power generation capacity, Indian government officials said.

The request is being processed under an existing framework for considering such cross-border power supply arrangements, with Indian authorities working to facilitate additional electricity to Nepal as required, Indian officials aware of the matter said.

According to some assessments available with Indian officials, Nepal’s domestic



The spot where the Trishuli Hydropower Station once stood in Nuwakot district. The project was developed jointly by the governments of India and Nepal. TASHI TOBGYAL

power generation capacity has fallen by around 550 MW following damage to hydropower facilities. Consequently, cross-border power flow to India is currently reduced by approximately 400 MW from previous peak export levels of around 900-1,000 MW, the Indian government officials said. However, the officials said the shortfall is temporary and does not warrant any exceptional

emergency procurement or alternative arrangements to meet India’s domestic demand. India has sufficient reserve capacity to absorb the reduction in imports from Nepal and ramp up generation as required, without affecting grid stability or domestic electricity supply, the official added. Queries sent to Nepal Embassy in India and the Power Ministry did not elicit any response.

41 pilgrims return to Mumbai after days of uncertainty



At Mumbai’s Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Airport on Saturday. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

Ishika Gupta
Mumbai, August 29

FOR FAMILIES who had spent the past two days waiting for a phone call, Saturday evening brought the first real relief.

Forty-one pilgrims from Maharashtra and neighbouring states, stranded in Tibet and Nepal after completing the Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra amid flash floods, arrived at Mumbai’s Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport on Saturday.

“For the past 48 hours, I was in a constant state of panic. But finally seeing my wife in person has put me at ease. I have nothing but gratitude for the state authorities and the External Affairs Ministry,” said Borivali resident Subodh Sathe, whose wife, Shama, was among those who returned. For Sathe, the anxiety had begun with a delay that could have changed the course of his wife’s journey. Shama was spared the worst of the floods after an issue with a fellow passenger’s ticket delayed her travel, Subodh said.

Smita Pawar, Revenue Commissioner of the Pune division, was travelling with three family members when she and her sister-in-law, Yogini Patil, fell ill. With their oxygen levels dropping, Pawar developed hypoxia and her body began turning bluish-black.

“We were scheduled to cross the border on the same day the floods occurred, but had to go to the hospital instead,” Patil said. The group, led by Pramod Kene under the Jai Girmari Shivdutt Mandir Trust, included pilgrims from Mumbai, Pune and Karnataka.

The pilgrims were part of a larger group that had been stranded in Saga, Tibet, after completing the Kailash Yatra earlier this week. Following intervention by Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis, they travelled to Kathmandu early Friday morning after crossing the Nyalam check-post.

For some of the pilgrims, the ordeal has not shaken their faith. “It was an act of God, but we believe God saved us. Our faith hasn’t wavered one bit,” said 65-year-old Pune resident Hemlata Borse. It was Borse’s third trip to Nepal. Despite what she had experienced, she said she wanted to return to the country.

Eight tourists from Borivali and Andheri remain unreachable. Authorities are in contact with their relatives and are trying to establish communication.



The bus in which the 21 Tamil Nadu pilgrims were travelling, in Rasuwa

Techie awaits news of wife missing after floods

Express News Service
Pune, August 29

MANMATH KULKARNI, a 60-year-old IT entrepreneur based in Mumbai’s Goregaon East is anxiously awaiting news of his wife, who has been missing since Thursday morning after a group of trekkers — including several former colleagues from Oracle’s early days in India — went incommunicado near the Nepal-China border. The group was part of a larger group led by Dr Milind P Chitley, veteran mountaineer who is also reported missing in Nepal’s flash floods.

Kulkarni’s wife, Veena (58), left Mumbai on the morning of August 23 for Kathmandu, travelling with fellow former iFlex

Solutions employees Venkat Subramanyam and L Shankar, along with their spouses. Their group joined as part of the annual trek led by Dr Chitley, included around 10 to 12 people, mostly husband-wife pairs who had worked together decades ago. Others included NRK Raman and his wife, V Shankar and wife and Padma Mahadevan.

According to Kulkarni, the group reached Kathmandu on August 25 and set out early the next morning for Timure, arriving there by evening and checking into their hotel. Everything appeared normal through the following morning. “At 6 am they were still in the hotel. Around 8 am they had reached the Nepal-China border,” Kulkarni recounted. He had spoken to his wife

around that time, when she mentioned the group was waiting for one member’s passport that he had forgotten in Kathmandu to be delivered before they could cross. “In another half an hour or 45 minutes, we should be crossing over,” she told him.

“The conversation ended there. After that, I tried calling her at 9:45 am but I couldn’t get through,” Kulkarni said. It wasn’t until 3:30 pm, when his brother called asking if he had seen the news, that the family realised something was wrong.

Kulkarni, who did not join the 14-day trek due to work commitments, said the entire 10-12 member group of former Oracle employees, along with Dr Chitley and the rest of the 50 odd people remains unaccounted for.

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, August 29

A CALL that went unanswered. A phone that went silent. Four days after devastating flash floods swept through Nepal, families of two men in Uttar Pradesh have had no news of them. Ravish Singh, 48, a welder from Gorakhpur, and Karan Sharma, 32, an electrician from Kushinagar, were working on the 216 MW Upper Trishuli-1 Hydropower Project in Nepal’s Rasuwa district.

Ravish called his wife, Kalawati, on August 26, at 8.50 am. “She could not answer the call as she was busy with household chores. The couple usually spoke two or three times a day,” said his younger brother,



Karan Sharma & (right) Ravish Singh worked at Upper Trishuli-1 Hydropower Project

Ajay Singh, a sub-inspector posted in Ballia. “When she called Ravish in the afternoon, his phone was unreachable. She tried several times but could not get through,” he said.

Two to three hours later, the family

learned about the floods in Nepal. “My sister-in-law has been upset that she could not answer Ravish’s call that morning. Since August 26, she has made hundreds of calls, hoping that he would pick up,” Ajay said. They had last seen Ravish two months ago when he came home to see his wife and two children. Ravish’s brother, Raj Kumar Singh, left for Nepal on Friday to search for him.

In Kushinagar, Karan’s wife and children are facing a similar wait. He had come home in June for 15 days after his father developed a heart problem. “On the day the floods hit, we could not contact Karan. Then his phone was switched off,” said his brother, Shiv Karan Sharma. He, too, has travelled to Nepal to look for his brother.

Let the Western Ghats breathe



ASEEM SHRIVASTAVA

THE CANOPY closes overhead as the monsoon sky lowers, and the Kataklean dark forest of North Kanara slips into an almost absolute blackness. It is the middle of the day. A few hundred yards in, the light dies so completely that you reach for a torch just to discern the brook gurgling a few yards away. Hornbills call through the dripping understorey, mountain imperial pigeons murmur in the vaulted gloom, and eagle owls send low hoots echoing between ancient trunks. Here, in this living darkness, the dry, fragmented woodlots that pass for forests in “New India” reveal themselves as paltry shadows of the *aranya* that inspired poets like Rabindranath Tagore — a primordial realm that still breathes and governs itself, reminding all that true wilderness does not merely survive in India; it thrives in the damp air and the dark. If we let it.

Having done my doctoral dissertation on forest management and seen jungles across four continents, I thought I knew what a forest was. I was wrong.

The Kataklean darkness is merely the most intimate face of a mountain chain whose influence extends far beyond its forested slopes. The Western Ghats, running 1,600 kilometres along the edge of the pen-

insula, are nothing less than the living ecological spine of India. Recognised as one of the world’s eight hottest biodiversity hot-spots, these mountains harbour extraordinary life — nearly half of India’s flowering plant species, a third of its vertebrate fauna, and over 300 globally threatened species find refuge here. Several species, like the Kataklean Marsh Nut and the Gund Day Gecko, are exclusive to the very forests I visited.

Yet the significance of the Ghats runs deeper than species counts. They gather the first impact of the southwest monsoon and release it as the lifeblood of the Deccan: The Godavari, Krishna, Kaveri, and Tungabhadra rivers originate here, sustaining hundreds of millions across six states. Their dense forests temper regional climate, draw down carbon, hold the soil in place, and soften the runoff and flooding that would otherwise devastate downstream plains.

It is no exaggeration, then, to call these rainforests “India’s Amazon”. Like their South American counterpart, they behave as a vast living organism — breathing in carbon dioxide, exhaling oxygen, and cycling moisture back into the atmosphere to sustain the monsoon itself. Their layered canopies, dripping with epiphytes and echoed by the calls of hornbills and lion-tailed macaques, weave a self-renewing tapestry of life that sustains the climate and waters of the entire peninsula. Just as the Amazon Basin constitutes the lungs of South America, the Western Ghats are the lungs and wellspring of India. As ecologists like Madhav Gadgil have long noted, their continued integrity is not merely a conservation priority; it is a matter of civilisational ecological survival.

The Kataklean darkness is merely the most intimate face of a mountain chain whose influence extends far beyond its forested slopes

In pursuit of ‘development’

Meanwhile, something else is planned in Kataklean’s neighbourhood. The proposed Rs 10,000-crore, 2,000 MW Sharavathi Pumped Storage Project in Karnataka’s Shimoga and Uttara Kannada district remains under an interim stay by the Karnataka High Court, with work frozen until further orders. It aims to link the Talakalale and Gerusoppa reservoirs on the heavily hydropower-dammed Sharavathi, through massive underground tunnels and powerhouses, pumping water uphill during off-peak hours and releasing it to generate power during peak demand.

The project sits entirely within the Sharavathi Valley Lion-Tailed Macaque Wildlife Sanctuary, which enjoys one of highest levels of protection under the Wildlife Act, where such infrastructure is strictly prohibited. An expert panel constituted by a Standing Committee of National Board of Wildlife recommended against approval, citing irreversible ecological harm and questioning its technical justification. The panel found it would yield no new net energy to the grid, instead producing a net loss of approximately 500 MW due to pumping requirements.

The stakes are enormous. The project requires clearing over 50 hectares of dense primary evergreen forest, fragmenting crucial wildlife corridors between the Anshi-Dandeli and Bhadra-Kudremukh landscapes. Experts warn of extreme landslide risks in this geologically fragile zone, where blasting for underground structures like tunnels and powerhouses with heavy industrial explosives threatens catastrophe. With an installed renewable energy capacity of 20.23 GW, Karnataka needs diversified solutions

such as Battery Energy Storage Systems, pumped storage, compressed air energy storage and gravity energy storage to manage the intermittency of renewable energy.

Critics acknowledge this need. But meeting this need by destroying forever, a carbon-storing ecological backbone such as the Sharavathi Lion-Tailed Macaque Wildlife Sanctuary, which justly enjoys the highest levels of legal protection, is indefensible.

Cultural, ecological renewal

To defend the ecology of the irreplaceable Western Ghats entails renewing our ties to the natural world. No trite nostrum along the lines of “sustainable development” will suffice. Sustainability is about what we can go on taking from nature without finding the courage to face our organised, well-disguised greed. Ecological renewal and reciprocity imply that we honour what our ancestors have bequeathed to us — a stable, healthy ecology. It means we creatively renew a culture long integrated with nature, until the winds of accelerating industrial modernity begin to sunder them. We pass on what was passed down to us. We act for future generations the way our ancestors acted towards us. We act towards trees and animals, mountains and forests, rivers and coastlines with the reverence the cosmos deserves. This means putting an end to the plunder that corporate-consumer civilisation is routinely engaged in through mining and infrastructure, roads and expressways, dams, airports, and power plants. Not allowing *aranya* to be sacrificed to ecologically subsidised cities.

Shrivastava is a writer and teacher

Small dreams too important to ignore



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

ALMOST FROM the day that Narendra Modi became prime minister, he has urged Indians to dream big dreams. At international events he has boasted often that India no longer has small dreams. And we have been reminded so often that by 2047 India will be a developed country that on social media, there are jokes about how the prime minister seems to believe that 2047 is the year that comes after 2026. Following Modi’s lead, his chief ministers routinely tell us in expensive full-page newspaper advertisements and glittering TV promotions that their states, in keeping with ‘the vision of Modiji’, are aiming to become trillion-dollar economies by 2047.

It is a good thing to dream big dreams. I totally support big dreams and have been very proud of the pace at which the Modi government and sundry other ‘double-engine’ governments have speeded up the building of glittering, new highways. They look dismal as they disintegrate when the rains come, but that is another story. I also support the idea of building ‘smart cities’ and bringing high-quality urban services to rural parts and have said more than once that Modi’s toilet-building programme has been transformative. Those long lines of men squatting beside the tracks is no longer a common sight when you look out of the window of your Vande Bharat trains. But, in building big dreams some very important small dreams have been forgotten.

If you have been following the ‘School *Theek Karo*’ campaign of the Cockroach Janta Party, you would have been horrified by the state of rural schools. And this is not even half the story. Did you know that there are no properly trained teachers teaching in government schools? Trained teachers are not going to miraculously appear out of thin air. To create enough of them, we will need to build hundreds of thousands of teacher training schools. Some months ago, I quoted in this column the educationist, Michel Danino, saying this as the second of the three most important reforms needed. He believes that the District Institutes of Education and Training need a ‘complete overhaul’. So does the entire education system so that children are taught to think and not learn by rote. Schools also need libraries, playgrounds, clean water and toilets.

These may sound like small things compared to national highways and bullet trains, but they are not. They might be more important. There are other small dreams that have been recklessly forgotten. There is the dream of having clean air in our cities, clean water in our sacred rivers and efficient waste management so that our ‘smart cities’ do not seem to be sprouting out of garbage dumps. A Yale University survey reported last week that when it came to environmental matters, India was at the very bottom of a list of 177 countries. Only Laos is dirtier and more degraded than India.

So instead of the big dream that has made not singing *Vande Mataram* a crime, what about making it a non-bailable offence for political leaders to forget the meaning of its first line? *Sujalam, Suphalam, Malayaja-sitalam*. A land of pure water, abundant fruit trees and clean air is what the poet described. And this is most certainly not an accurate description of our dear Bharat Mata as she is today. As for the damage reckless construction activity has done to our mountains, it is beyond criminal. The disaster last week in Nepal should remind our political leaders about what happens when the environment is criminally neglected.

What then has gone so wrong with our policies that they have brought us to this sorry pass? Could it be that in pursuit of big dreams, political leaders have forgotten the importance of small dreams? Have our policy-makers failed totally to notice that young Indians, among them schoolchildren, are now regularly taking to the streets to demand such small things as teachers and clean toilets in their schools? They also declare openly that what makes them feel most hopeless is the absence of decent jobs. It is true that in the past decade a handful of very rich Indians have got very much richer and are not shy of showing off their enormous wealth. Personally, I have no problem with this.

What I have a problem with is that millions more Indians have not got rich as well. Why has this not happened? Could it be because the Prime Minister lulled himself into believing that he had truly made doing business in India easier? It is not easier to do business for most Indians and one big reason for this is that corruption in his ‘double-engine’ governments is so deeply rooted at almost every level that only those who can pay huge bribes find it easier to do business.

In this time of big dreams, it is vital, if Modi wants to win back his fading popularity before that crucial election in Uttar Pradesh next year, that he personally concentrates on small things. And that he gets his high-flying chief ministers to plant their feet back firmly on the ground and explain why there have been so many big failures when it comes to the small dreams of ordinary Indians. The ugly truth is that below the shining highways that stand suspended today over towns and cities across India, far too many things have remained unchanged, and they need to start changing fast.

Lakshmi Iyer is the author of ‘Why Is My Skin Brown?’

Editor (Planning & Projects) Shalini Langer curates the fortnightly ‘She Said’ column

Spider-Man is watching you. His inspiration: AI companies



BLJIN JOSE

I WATCHED *Spider-Man: Brand New Day*. In the latest instalment, Tom Holland’s Peter Parker can be seen using an AI-powered assistant to engage in mass surveillance. This is not the first Marvel movie to use futuristic surveillance on unsuspecting citizens, and it is definitely not the last. Remember *Captain America: The Winter Soldier*, where Nick Fury describes Project Insight as “We’re going to neutralise a lot of threats before they even happen”? This led to Steve Rogers’ famous counter: “I thought the punishment usually came after the crime.”

In *Brand New Day*, Parker uses an AI assistant to access every security camera in the entire city and run facial recognition algorithms to track a specific person. While this looks slick, in the process, our friendly superhero ends up violating the privacy of millions of innocent civilians.

In 2026, this is no longer fiction, and that is something which is deeply concerning. The system here eerily feels similar to the type of technology developed by AI surveillance companies like Peter Thiel’s Palantir or Flock Safety. However, the film barely explores the implications, making one wonder if mass surveillance is being normalised at scale. The movie casually slips in the technology; there is even a short conversation with Peter’s friend who works for the NYPD where she briefly mentions surveillance with facial recognition tech being illegal.

A closer look reveals that in most MCU narratives, surveillance tech is justified in the same way as CEOs and governments worldwide do: Advocating it as a tool for safety, something that is necessary to catch terrorists or dissidents, or to save innocents. On July 26, CNN reported on the mounting concerns over police misuse of Flock Safety’s automated licence-plate reader cameras.

Flock Safety is a US-based surveillance tech company that offers hardware and software, including automated licence-plate readers (ALPR). Its camera network currently operates across 49 US states, making it one of the largest ALPR networks in the country. In simple words, the technology allows law-enforcement agencies to record vehicle movements, creating reports that can show where people travel. The CNN report studied cases in which police officers allegedly accessed Flock Safety’s system for reasons that were unrelated to lawful investigations, and this has raised concerns about abuse of surveillance tech and inadequate oversight. There have been instances where police officers were caught using Flock to spy on their exes or stalk women.

A report by the Electronic Frontier Foundation in November 2025 claimed that law enforcement agencies are using Flock’s technology to monitor protesters and activists, raising concerns about the use of surveillance systems in politically sensitive contexts. Though Flock Safety does not use facial recognition in its licence-plate reader systems, its technology is yet another example of mass automated surveillance.

Palantir has been increasingly deploying AI-powered intelligence tools into military operations through its platforms like Gotham, Foundry, and Skykit. Earlier this month, *Al Jazeera* reported that Palantir had significantly expanded its work with the Israeli military after announcing a strategic partnership in January 2024. The report claimed that the company subsequently expanded operations supporting Israel’s military operations in Gaza, amid scathing criticism over its role in AI, military technology and warfare.

The technology and the companies that are building it seem to be oblivious to the ethical concerns surrounding their use. Unfortunately, this remains true even for Spider-Man, who may be systematically violating the privacy of denizens of his fictional universe. Regardless, *Brand New Day* has triggered a spate of social media content that uses the movie to talk about the perils of AI and mass surveillance. It is a good start.

The writer is Assistant Editor, indianexpress.com

What two gramophones tell us about Vande Mataram



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY AKHILESH JHA

HARIPURA WAS not merely another annual gathering of the Indian National Congress. In early 1938, Congress assembled there in Gujarat for its 51st Annual Session after the Congress Working Committee meeting in Calcutta in October 1937. And in those intervening months, much had changed in the way *Vande Mataram* was to be seen, heard and presented.

The ceremonial journey of the young President-elect Subhas Chandra Bose to the Congress pavilion became a spectacle of political imagination. For a four-mile journey from Haripura, Bose was carried to the pandal, curated by Nandalal Bose, in a magnificent *rath*. It was drawn by 51 bullocks. Richly caparisoned, their horns painted, the bullocks moved in pairs, each pair carrying tricolour flags upon their heads. And around their necks hung tuned bells. They were *Vande Mataram* bells with engraved letters.

Bose reached the session with singers and musicians who had travelled with him from Calcutta in the second-class bogies of the Nagpur Mail. RR Mukherjee was the master musician. As the Bengal troupe sang *Vande Mataram*, the senior leadership of the Congress, including Mahatma Gandhi, stood in attention. Sarojini Naidu found the Haripura *Vande Mataram* ‘exquisitely’ sung, with ‘deep and thrilling emotions’. Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay praised the young Bengali troupe for providing ‘a fine emotional setting for the whole session’.

The experiments with *Vande Mataram* can hardly be separated from what had happened only a few months earlier at the CWC meeting in Calcutta in October 1937. In many ways, the pride and position of the song had been compromised there. Haripura was determined to restore it.

(Above) The 1938 gramophone label; the one that came out later

It is important to remember that the Congress had, for years, referred to *Vande Mataram* as the ‘National Anthem’ in the proceedings and reports of its annual sessions. Many such reports during the 1920s were edited and prepared by Pt Jawaharlal Nehru, then serving as General Secretary of the Indian National Congress.

At Haripura, therefore, *Vande Mataram* was not being introduced to the Congress. It was being reaffirmed. And Bose did not allow that reaffirmation to remain confined to the Congress pandal. In 1938, he had a special gramophone record cut to restore the pride of *Vande Mataram*. The responsibility was given to the most credible name in Indian orchestration of the period: Timir Baran. For the first time, the complete *Vande Mataram* was composed in the two versions: a grand choral rendering as an anthem and an instrumental arrangement conceived in the character of a military march. Against the usual 10-inch-diameter gramophone record, this recording was issued on a 12-inch disc. The larger disc combined respect with the need to fit all six stanzas on one side.

The label had a tricolour bearing the *charkha*. Then came two declarations which, read against the events of Calcutta in 1937, appear almost like statements of resolve. The first was: BANDE MATARAM-SAMPOORN. Sampoon, complete. Not two stanzas. All the stanzas were sung and re-

worldview I have decided to box you in.” Unlike other days, I reshared my post, feeling that it resonated just as well today as it did five years ago. At the heart of that speech, I was grappling with racism and colourism.

Growing up, what I identified with were my body (fat) and my colour (dark). My *appa* was my favourite parent. Anytime I would feel ‘less than’, I would hold my arm next to his and revel in how much fairer my skin colour was. We would joke about it; he would crinkle his nose, smile, and the world would be alright again. In the shadow of the fair-skinned, I was very aware of pretty privilege. I envied my beautiful peers. I was yet to understand what ‘beauty lies in the eyes of the beholder’ meant. As a 50-year-old now, I look back on the younger me with pity and shards of empathy. She was the ‘pick me’. Eager to blend in and be accepted. Starved for appreciation, she was a naive child.

She enjoyed the ritual of her *amma* applying *paal yedu* (milk cream) mixed with *kadalai maavu* (gram flour) and *manjal* (turmeric) on her face, feeling the moisture es-



SHE SAID
BY LAKSHMI IYER

cape, and the skin tighten. She helped herself to her *atha’s* (aunt’s) Fair & Lovely cream on occasion. As a young working woman, she loved the hours of pampering at the beauty parlour. The facials, the waxing and the momentary glow of money well spent. As adult life took over, the obsession with beauty receded, giving way to grown-up worries.

Race entered my life, in a different way, in my 30s. I was suddenly the mom to white-passing Navajo twins. The role reversal was fascinating. Was I relieved my children were conventionally beautiful? I can only speculate. Race was never far away from my thoughts. It reared its head each time we were out, shopping, walking, and existing.

In 2014, I gave birth to a beautiful girl. *Karuppu* (dark). That was the first observation her *paati* (grandmother) made. No malice. Concern, yes. I was offended. I went mute.

Then, a decade later, I watched my youngest come in from the sun, and the words crossed my mind. Tanned. Dark.

I did not voice it out. I was mortified that I, the recipient of backhanded compliments,

REPAYMENT PLAN WAS APPROVED WITH 80.8% OF VOTES CAST IN ITS FAVOUR

How Chandra’s Rs 6.25-cr plan got through despite bank opposition

George Mathew
Mumbai, August 29

THE NATIONAL Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order that approved Zee founder Subhash Chandra’s proposal to pay just Rs 6.25 crore to creditors in personal insolvency proceedings came after the majority of creditors supported the repayment plan. But banks now say that at least five entities — which held 61.78% of the votes cast and backed the repayment plan — are linked to Chandra either as associates or related parties.

As many as 23 creditors participated in the voting under the insolvency mechanism, and banks which opposed the plan, got a vote share of only 19.186%. The admitted claims amounted to approximately Rs 22,006.57 crore. But the approved repayment plan proposed payment of only Rs 6.25 crore to creditors and Rs 25 lakh towards process costs.

Much of the liability relates to personal guarantees and indemnities given in connection with borrowings by companies associated with the Essel Group. Under the resolution mechanism of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), once the requisite majority of creditors approves a repayment plan and the tribunal sanctions it, individual dissenting creditors cannot simply walk away from the process and demand a different settlement.

In its application, IDBI Trusteeship Services said the votes cast by the creditor Veena In-

vestments Pvt Ltd, and its subsidiaries Direct Media Distribution Ventures Pvt Ltd and World Crest Advisors LLP, ought not to have been considered by the resolution professional. It said these entities allegedly fall within the category of associate parties.

A resolution professional is a person appointed to manage the affairs of a company undergoing the insolvency process and facilitate its resolution.

HDFC Bank said Veena Investments Pvt Ltd, Direct Media Distribution Ventures, World Crest Advisors LLP, Lemonade Capital Advisors LLP and Corpcall Capital Advisors LLP fall in the category of associates of the debtor and that their vote share cannot be taken into account while counting the vote share in favour of the repayment plan.

When contacted, Subhash Chandra’s office said in a statement: “We would like to state that this claim is not true and inaccurately represents the facts. Some of the associate entities referenced in the reports, belonged to Jawahar Goel, whose business interests were separated from Subhash Chandra in 2008-09 through a family business separation process.”

“The separation process and subsequent division of the business was duly informed to the stock exchanges and the regulator. Further, the term ‘associate entity’ is well-defined in the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code statutes. In accordance with the provisions of the Code, the com-

• Who voted for and against the repayment plan

NO	NAME OF CREDITOR	VOTING	APPROVAL OF REPAYMENT PLAN
1	Anil Kumar	0.67%	Favour
2	Axis Bank Ltd	2.86%	Against
3	Axis Trustee Services	0.04%	Did not vote
4	Axis Trustee Services	0.18%	Did not vote
5	Axis Trustee Services	0.11%	Did not vote
6	Canara Bank	1.60%	Against
7	IDBI Trusteeship (CINDA FPI)	11.85%	Favour
8	Catalyst Trusteeship (HDFC AMC)	0.06%	Did not vote
9	Corpcall Capital Advisors LLP	10.30%	Favour
10	Direct Media Distribution Ventures	1.15%	Favour
11	HDFC Bank Ltd	3.17%	Against
12	IDBI Trusteeship (Edelweiss Fund)	2.60%	Did not vote
13	IDBI Trusteeship (Franklin Templeton)	3.36%	Against
14	Indiabulls Housing Finance	1.98%	Favour
15	IndusInd Bank Ltd	1.11%	Did not vote
16	Kautilya Traders Pvt Ltd	1.02%	Favour
17	Lemonade Capital Advisors LLP	16.85%	Favour
18	LIC Housing Finance	6.09%	Against
19	RBL Bank Ltd	0.55%	Against
20	Sunil Jain	0.18%	Favour
21	Union Bank of India (UK) Ltd	0.76%	Against
22	Veena Investments Pvt Ltd	4.99%	Favour
23	World Crest Advisors	28.49%	Favour
24	Total	100%	

panies concerned do not qualify as associate entities of the Group,” the statement said.

World Crest has a vote share of 28.49%, Lemonade 16.85% and Corpcall 10.30% share in the voting. Veena Investments has 4.99% share. Catalyst Trus-

teeship (CINDA FPI) with a vote share of 11.85% also favoured the repayment plan. The plan was approved with a majority of 80.814% votes favouring the plan. All the banks voted against the repayment plan. However, they only had a

19.186% vote share. Among banks and NBFCs, HDFC Bank had 3.17% vote share, LIC Housing Finance 6.09% share and Canara Bank 1.60%.

The debtor’s counsel argued that Direct Media and World Crest are corporate subsidiaries of Veena Investments. Legally, if the parent company itself cannot be classified as an associate of the debtor due to a lack of direct ownership or control by the PG, its downstream subsidiaries automatically escape the associate classification.

“It is stated that Direct Media Distribution Ventures Pvt Ltd and World Crest Advisors LLP are subsidiaries of Veena Investments Pvt Ltd, which is allegedly controlled by Sushila Devi Goel, wife of Jawahar Goel, the brother of the Personal Guarantor,” the order says.

The claims submitted by Lemonade Capital Advisors LLP and Corpcall Capital Advisors LLP are stated to be founded upon deeds of guarantee allegedly executed by the PG in connection with financial facilities availed by another group entity — Churu Enterprises LLP. It has further been contended that the proximity and relationship between these entities and the PG stand reinforced by the fact that the partners of these two entities are also directors in companies disclosed as “other related parties” in the consolidated financial statements of Veena Investments Pvt Ltd for the financial year 2020–2021, the order says. **FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**

Chandra’s settlement comes as IBC turns 10, with bank haircuts at five-year high

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, August 29

A RECENT order of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) involving Zee Group founder Subhash Chandra has yet again exposed one of the highly debated issues under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) framework—deep haircuts. The August 25 order approved a repayment plan under which Chandra will pay just Rs 6.5 crore to creditors against admitted claims of Rs 22006.57 crore. This amounts to a 99.97% haircut, one of the highest in the insolvency regime’s history.

The term “haircut” has not been defined in IBC. However, in the banking system, a haircut refers to the percentage reduction in the value of an asset used as collateral to protect the lender from potential losses.

As the Banks are considering an appeal at National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT), here’s a look at what has been the overall haircuts status under the IBC so far.

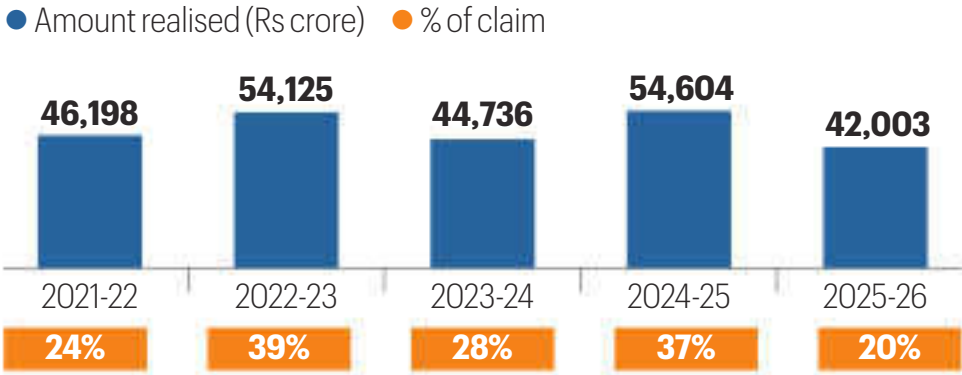
The Recovery

The IBC was enacted in 2016 to provide a comprehensive system to rescue companies under financial stress or high debt through resolution and repayment to creditors. However, whether resolution or recovery is more important has remained a central question around its functioning.

According to data available with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, between financial years 2021-22 and 2025-26, a total of 1077 cases were resolved under the IBC, with a realisation of Rs 2.47 lakh crore for creditors. However, the average recovery was close to 29%.

The data shows that recovery against admitted claims

• Creditor’s haircuts



SOURCE: MINISTRY OF CORPORATE AFFAIRS

in the financial year 2025-26 (FY26) was 20%, the lowest in the last five years. Similarly, the total realisation was 37% in FY25, 28% in FY24, 39% in FY23 and 24% in FY22.

This ultimately means that a bank may have claims running into thousands of crore rupees, but what it receives could be just a fraction of what it is owed.

What government says

The government’s opinion is that the primary objective of the Code is “resolution, not recovery”. The logic is that if a company has been under financial stress for years and its assets have depleted significantly due to non-performance, the IBC process may yield low or no realisation, or even result in liquidation.

“It may not be appropriate to see realisation in relation to claims of the creditors. The assets available on the ground may make better sense, because the market offers a value in relation to what a company brings on the table, and not what it owes to creditors...the amount of claim often includes NPA, which may be completely written off, and interest on such NPA. It may include loans as well as the guarantee against such loans,” said the Ministry to the standing committee on finance in December 2025, which did a holistic review of the effec-

tiveness of IBC.

The ministry also said that the amount realised often does not include the value that may be realised from equity holdings post-resolution. Beyond realisation against claims, it is considered that the IBC has also helped create credit discipline, which has contributed in reducing the gross non-performing assets of banks.

What banks say

However, the banks have been voicing strong opinions and serious concerns over haircuts on a case to case basis. They have been suggesting that the problem lies in the valuation of stressed companies and that all assets should be included and properly valued as per established standards, indicating that some assets may not be accounted for and there is an opacity around the process.

In the IBC process, at least two valuers are appointed to give a fair value and liquidation value, based on records and physical examination of the assets of the entity under challenge. “One of the suggestions to reduce excessive haircuts is asset valuation systems to ensure the reflection of enterprise value instead of liquidation value,” said the Chairman, SBI, to the standing committee. **FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM**

Temasek backs SIA’s Air India investment

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 29

TEMASEK, THE Singapore government-owned investment company that is the majority shareholder in Singapore Airlines (SIA), said Saturday that it backs SIA’s investment in Air India, and views it from a long-term view of securing growth beyond the city-state.

Temasek’s statement, which came amid concerns being raised in Singapore over the loss-making Air India seeking fresh capital infusion from its shareholders Tata Sons and Singapore Airlines; the latter holds 25.1% stake in the Indian airline.

“As a shareholder of SIA, we view their business decision from a long-term perspective and are supportive of it. We recognise that the large-scale transformation of Air India involves complex, multi-year operational and integration challenges. Efforts of this scale take time and are not expected to be linear, particularly in the aviation sector, where outcomes are shaped by industry developments, including aircraft innovation and fleet renewal cycles, and external factors such as airspace disruptions, geopolitical developments, and fuel price volatility,” Temasek said in its statement.

Air India, which is implementing an ambitious and cash-guzzling transformation programme, is also struggling

due to external headwinds like the Pakistani airspace closure, West Asia conflict-related disruptions, and sky high fuel prices. The airline, which was taken over by the Tata group from the government in January 2022, recently sought about \$1.5 billion from its shareholders, it is learnt.

In a social media post on Wednesday, Kenneth Tjong, an opposition MP in Singapore’s parliament, raised concerns over Singapore Airlines investing further in Air India, and the consequent impact it could have on Temasek. Singapore-based newspaper The Business Times published an opinion piece on Singapore Airlines’ exposure to Air India, saying that SIA faced some “bleak choices” as it lay “trapped in Air India’s money pit”. The publicly issued statement by Temasek on Saturday was in response to the article.

According to Temasek, SIA has articulated its objective to invest in a second hub to secure long-term growth beyond Singapore, and as the world’s third-largest aviation market, India is well-positioned to serve as this second hub. It added that SIA has long participated in the India market, including an operating presence through Vistara since 2013 and its investment in Air India “allows it to deepen its participation in India’s aviation growth”.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

After one year, GST Council to meet on Sept 12

New Delhi: After a long gap of over a year, the Goods and Services Tax (GST) Council has decided to hold its next meeting on September 12 in Delhi, an office memorandum stated.

The Council, which will meet for the first time after the GST 2.0 rate rationalisation in September last year, is likely to take up issues of blocked input tax credit for several goods and services that are facing a higher tax rate for inputs as against the final output, especially after being moved to a lower tax slab under the indirect tax regime. The Council is also expected to discuss a uniform and simplified registration framework by states and Centre for businesses looking to register under the GST regime. **ENS**

Budget FY28 exercise to start from Oct 12

New Delhi: The Finance Ministry will begin the exercise to prepare the Union Budget for 2027-28 from October 12 amid heightened global uncertainties and rising food and fuel prices.

The Budget for the next financial year is expected to focus on the reform continuation exercise to further accelerate economic growth, along with measures to create jobs and boost domestic demand. **PTI**

Sitharaman urges US companies to make in India for the world



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in a business roundtable meeting, in Chicago, US. **PTI**

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, August 29

FINANCE MINISTER Nirmala Sitharaman on Saturday exhorted US businesses and investors to co-develop, co-produce, and build in India, leveraging its engineering talent, manufacturing scale, and technology ecosystem to create global products, technologies and infrastructure.

During the US leg of her two-nation visit, Sitharaman addressed a high-level roundtable with leading investors and business leaders in Chicago. “The finance minister invited global partners to co-develop, co-produce and build for global markets, and to not merely consider India as a market to serve, but as a platform

from which to build for the world — whether as a manufacturing base, technology and innovation centre, consumer market or destination for long-term infrastructure investment, leveraging India’s engineering talent, manufacturing scale and technology ecosystem,” the finance ministry said in a post on X.

The roundtable focused on India’s broad-based growth, reform momentum and expanding opportunities for long-term investment, with “manufacture in India — for India and for the world” emerging as a key theme. Opportunities were highlighted across manufacturing, AI and digital technologies, financial services, infrastructure, food processing, defence and advanced technologies. **FE**

Delhi CNG price rises Rs 3.89/kg amid renewed West Asia crisis

New Delhi: Indraprastha Gas Ltd (IGL) on Saturday raised the price of compressed natural gas (CNG) in Delhi by Rs 3.89 per kg, citing a sharp rise in international liquefied natural gas (LNG) prices following a renewed West Asia crisis and disruptions to gas cargo movements through the Strait of Hormuz. The hike, effective from 6 am on August 29, takes the CNG price in Delhi to Rs 86.98 per kg, from Rs 83.09 per kg earlier.

The increase takes the cumulative increase in Delhi CNG prices this year to nearly Rs 10 per kg. Delhi CNG was priced at Rs 77.09 per kg at the beginning of the year. It was raised by Rs 6 per kg in four installments in second half of May, taking the price to Rs 83.09 per kg before Saturday’s hike.

Prices have also been increased in adjoining cities like Noida and Ghaziabad. CNG now costs Rs 95.59 per kg in Noida, Rs 95.59 in Ghaziabad and Rs 92.01 per kg in Gurgaon. Rates differ from state to state depending on local taxes like VAT. **PTI**

US curbs on China cotton drive Indian yarn prices

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, August 29

INDIAN APPAREL exporters have approached the Commerce and Industry Ministry and the Textile Ministry seeking regulation on cotton yarn exports to arrest a sharp surge in prices in the backdrop of US restrictions on the use of cotton originating from the Uyghur region in China, where Washington alleges Beijing uses forced labour. The price pressure also comes as China is the largest producer of cotton and has a 29% share of world cotton production. India is the second-largest producer of cotton.

The Apparel Export Promotion Council (AEPCC) said that cotton yarn prices have increased by around 60%, from approximately Rs 250 per kg in early 2026 to around Rs 400 per kg currently, raising increasing pressure on the apparel manufacturing value chain. The council, in a letter to the ministries, sought measures “to regulate the export of cotton yarn, specifically 20s count (a medium-thickness thread) and above”, and to stabilise prices so that cotton yarn remains available to apparel manufacturing and export-

ing units at competitive rates.

The export promotion council also flagged that limited stock availability with ginners and reduced arrivals have “compelled mills to rely more heavily on auctions conducted by Cotton Corporation of India (CCI)”. Much of the cotton has already moved out of farmers’ hands and is currently held by traders, leading to hoarding and speculative practices in the market, AEPCC told the government.

AEPCC said that the increase in exports of Indian cotton and cotton yarn to apparel-producing countries is coming from top apparel and textile manufacturers such as Bangladesh and Vietnam.

“Forced labour restrictions against Uyghur cotton have been in place for quite some time, but countries of late have become more cautious due to US regulations and increasing emphasis on supply chain traceability. This is resulting in higher demand for cotton yarn from India, which has already been in short supply,” Mithileshwar Thakur, Secretary General of AEPCC told *The Indian Express*.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• ‘CLOSING AUCTION SESSION IS STILL EVOLVING, SO IT WOULD BE DIFFICULT TO COMPARE IT WITH THE PREVIOUS VWAP SYSTEM’

‘CAS is a move in the right direction, but the timing may not be right’

THE NEWLY introduced Closing Auction Session (CAS) mechanism is a step in the right direction but was probably implemented too hastily by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), according to **Tejas Shah**, director and head of trading at Equirus Group. The mechanism, which was implemented at the start of this month and has been in the news since, is probably a move in the right direction, but the Indian market is “probably not a mature enough market for it,” Shah told **Akash Mandal** in an interview. Excerpts:

How does the CAS system work, and how does it differ from the previously used VWAP system?

SEBI’s idea was to adopt a mechanism used in many developed markets, like the US and the UK, whereas in India, we used to calculate the average price over the last 30 minutes to derive closing prices.

Now, especially after the Jane Street incident, SEBI realised that at times it is easy to tilt the VWAP system in your favour because if you trade a big quantity during the closing moments of the session, the previous 30 minutes would not matter that much in the VWAP system. Many FIIs and global players also pitched that CAS would be a better mechanism to determine closing prices.

So now, until 3:15 pm, there is normal trading. All pending

limit and market orders are then carried forward to the CAS, while stop-loss orders are removed from the system. Exchanges calculate reference prices from 3:15 pm to 3:30 pm. From 3:20 pm to 3:25 pm, you can place either market or limit orders. From 3:25 pm, you can only place limit orders, and the session ends at a random time between 3:27 pm and 3:30 pm.

Market orders help execute orders faster at the prevailing market price, while limit orders focus more on price than certainty of execution. Derivatives continue to trade until 3:40 pm.

How is CAS better than the previous system?

It is still evolving, so it



would be very difficult to compare the two. But the participation level and price discovery become more democratic than when someone could tilt the price at the end. Rather than

having your order match with the closing price and being dependent on it, you can now participate and place orders at a higher or lower price, based on your requirements. So, you have that flexibility.

What is the reason for the thin volumes currently seen during the CAS?

It is something new that people have still not adjusted to. Also, whenever there is a change in a financial market, we see people first thinking it over and playing it out with caution rather than jumping into it.

What is happening is that the price-matching mechanism that operates for 5-7 minutes during the CAS is happening

behind the scenes. So, you are not aware of the price at which your order is going to match.

Volumes are thin because people are still working out the probabilities around that blind spot. If I put an order for a particular quantity of a stock at a price 2% higher, it does not give me certainty about whether the entire order will be executed or whether I will find a match at the price I want. There is a higher chance that you would get under-executions, where only part of your order is executed.

Volumes are often driven by bigger players. All these players, such as arbitrage firms and prop (proprietary trading) firms, are sitting out currently because the new system is not allowing

them enough time or visibility to hedge in the F&O market, and they do not run unhedged positions. So, the participants that are more active in generating volumes are currently sitting on the sidelines because of their own limitations.

How do you view the CAS system?

See, probably it is a move in the right direction, but timing-wise, we are probably still not a mature enough market for it. The other thing is that we have much higher retail participation in our market compared with other major markets. Other global markets are more institution-driven, where participants have access to all the

necessary information on when and how to participate.

For us, awareness is still pretty nascent at the retail level. So, while SEBI had probably given us enough of a window, the new system could have been run in simulation or in parallel for longer before implementation to give market participants enough time to get used to it.

See, for example, most retail investors trade in small ticket sizes. So, if an institutional player places a big order, they are probably not going to get matched. Plus, retail traders will always choose to play in the derivatives segment compared with CAS because of the higher leverage.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

ZELENSKY VOWS PUNISHMENT TO THOSE RESPONSIBLE FOR ‘NEGLIGENCE’

Russian strike on arms depot near Kyiv triggers blast, kills 37

Toll is highest from a Russian attack in Kyiv area this year

Reuters
Kyiv, August 29

AT LEAST 37 people were killed after a Russian drone attack on a Kyiv-area ammunition depot sparked a detonation, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Saturday, vowing to punish suspected negligence in the second such incident in two months.

The deadliest Russian strike in the Kyiv area this year came as Moscow's air attacks on the Ukrainian capital and surrounding region dragged into a third straight day, killing residents, damaging homes and derailing daily life.

Dozens were also injured and hundreds evacuated from the area of the strike late on Friday on the village of Myla, Zelenskyy said, where nearby infrastructure including residential buildings and a facility for the elderly and people with disabilities suffered "significant damage".

The attack sparked wide-



A firefighter at a site of a Russian drone attack in Kyiv region, Friday. AP

spread fires, officials said. Among those killed was the head of a neighbouring village who rushed to help.

"A terrible situation and terrible negligence on the part of those who stored explosives right next to people," Zelenskyy said in a video address.

The site of Friday's blast was a military facility that held artillery shells, mines and drones, among other ammunition, he added. It followed a similar incident in the Kyiv-area town of Vyshneve last month, when 10 people were killed and hundreds

of houses damaged after a strike triggered secondary explosions. "Another such crime – after what happened in Vyshneve – is absolutely unacceptable," Zelenskyy said. "I expect the details to be presented to the public promptly."

He added that criminal cases had already been opened on charges of official negligence. Ukrainian officials rarely disclose damage to military targets from Russian attacks.

In a statement on Saturday, Ukraine's Defence Ministry said all those responsible for

Moscow claims it captured 3 areas in Donetsk, Sumy

Moscow: The Russian defence ministry said on Saturday Russian troops had captured the village of Khrapivshchyna in Ukraine's Sumy region, and the villages of Novoandriivka and Rubizhne in the Donetsk region.

The ministry said via its Telegram channel that it had struck a logistics centre in the Kyiv region where components for Ukrainian ballistic missiles were stored. *Reuters* could not verify the report. **REUTERS**

weapons storage should complete a full audit of their locations. Nine other regions had been targeted in overnight strikes by Russia, Zelenskyy added, saying Kyiv was under "virtually non-stop attack" from jet-powered drones.

Russia has escalated its air war on Ukraine with increasing numbers of elusive ballistic missiles and new high-speed drones, which Kyiv lacks the air defences to shoot down.

US is taking partial control of Venezuela's oil reserves: Trump

Reuters
August 29

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump on Friday announced an unprecedented U.S. push to take control of a fifth of Venezuela's vast oil reserves, betting that American companies can revive the OPEC nation's battered energy industry while delivering a new source of crude to help bring down US fuel prices.

Trump provided few details about the agreement, saying only that US had secured majority control of over 65 billion barrels of Venezuela's proven oil reserves through a partnership with private business.

"At my direction, Secretary of State Marco Rubio, and Secretary of War Pete Hegseth, working closely with Highly Respected Interim President of Venezuela, Delcy Rodriguez, and, through a partnership with private business, have secured majority US control of more than 65 BILLION BARRELS of proven Oil Reserves in Venezuela, at no cost to the American Taxpayer," Trump wrote on Truth Social.

The South American nation's leader welcomed the agreement, saying it would boost the economy and government revenue.

‘Don’t know what to do next’: Nepal flood survivors confront uncertain futures



Residents check a list of rescued people published by the Nepali army following devastating flash floods, in Trishuli Bazar, Nepal, on Friday. NYT

Anupreeta Das & Sajal Pradhan
Devighat (Nepal), August 29

IN JUST two simple sentences, in separate conversations, they gave voice to the many Nepalis who have seen the lives they had built wiped away in seconds.

"Everything is gone," said Anju Shakya, a shopkeeper. Anushka Tamang, a janitor, said, "I don't know what to do next."

The cascade of mud that Wednesday carried away or buried loved ones, homes, businesses and schools left people asking: What can I eat, where can I sleep and what can I salvage? And what happens then?

Tamang, 29, improvised a path to the home she had fled in Devighat, Nepal. She crossed a fallen tree trunk and a tin roof plank, avoiding quicksand.

Inside, she found the silver suitcase filled with saris, stuck in the doorway and covered in

mud, but intact. She found her daughter's clothes hanging from the ceiling. She and her brother dragged belongings to a school where she worked as a janitor. She planned to stay there.

About 675 people are confirmed killed in the flash flood, and nearly 2400 are reported missing. The tourism-dependent economy faces billions in losses. The government and nonprofit groups are building shelters and delivering meals.

"Delivering food and water and providing shelter are the top priorities," said Hiralal Tamrakar, program director of Good Neighbors Nepal, working with local authorities in Bidur, Nuwakot district. Survivors need food, clothes, shelter, blankets and basics. "Later on, the government will make the provision, the plan to settle them," Tamrakar said.

Until two days ago, Shakya, 50, ran a jewelry store in Trishuli Bazaar in Bidur. She had worked

hard to build a life for the family. She had lived for over two decades in a three-story home with her son, daughter-in-law and grandson. The family had amassed about 3.5 kg of gold, worth roughly \$500,000, to pay for her grandson's education.

That life vanished when mud burst through the shop walls on its way to her home.

Her family tried to shut the doors and windows, but within minutes they fled. They climbed a hillside and stayed there for two days before army personnel arrived. The house and cars are gone. The shop is gone. The gold is gone. Sitting on a cot as army doctors checked her vitals, Shakya said she did not know how to face the future.

"My eyes keep welling up thinking about the wealth we've lost," she said. "You can't build a gold shop from scratch," Shakya added. "God has taken what he has given us." **NYT**

War weighs on Iran economy as US intensifies sanctions

Reuters
Dubai, Cairo, August 29

IRANIAN LEADERS are acknowledging the economic toll of war with the US, with the supreme leader urging the government to address the hardship and the president saying foreign trade has shrunk by a third due to the American sanctions and blockade.

Yet Tehran signalled no retreat on Saturday, vowing to withstand US pressure, pursue diplomacy and maintain what it said was control over the Strait of Hormuz.

The government said in a statement on state media that

addressing economic pressures caused by sanctions and war was a central focus, including curbing inflation, managing markets, creating jobs, directing investment towards domestic production and gradually reducing dependence on the dollar.

Six months after the US and Israel launched the war, negotiations are at an impasse and President Donald Trump's administration has stepped up efforts to punish Iran financially with what it has billed as an "economic D-Day".

Washington has warned countries to cut business ties with Iran or face secondary sanctions, though Treasury Depart-



Pro-government protesters at a rally in Tehran on Saturday. AP

ment stopped short of imposing penalties against major Iranian trade partners such as China and India, which could have repercussions for the US and global economies.

The Treasury imposed sanc-

tions on Egypt's Banque Misr for doing business with Tehran, proposing a rule that would cut off the bank's branches in the United Arab Emirates from dollar transactions. Egypt's central bank said it and the foreign ministry were in contact with US officials concerning the matter, adding the measure was limited to Banque Misr UAE's US dollar transactions with correspondent banks only.

Banque Misr said later in a statement it was reviewing the US Treasury notice, adding that its branch in the UAE continued to provide banking services to its customers in line with applicable rules and procedures.

The US also issued sanctions targeting an entity based in

Hong Kong and a person linked to Iran's Bank Mellī, according to a notice on the Treasury website.

The sanctions drive compounds the toll of the war on Iran's economy, where annual inflation hit 66% last month.

Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, who has not been seen publicly since he was injured in the initial February 28 attack, called on the government to tackle the economic hardship.

"There is need to seriously address the chain of economic and livelihood challenges, such as inflation, unemployment, management of prices and the market for goods and services," according to a written statement attributed to Khamenei.

Israeli settlers stage new attack on homes in West Bank's Qusra

Reuters
Qusra, August 29

DOZENS OF masked Israeli settler militants attacked homes surrounding the occupied West Bank village of Qusra on Saturday, the first major attack since a siege by settlers in the area earlier this month drew an international outcry.

The settlers surrounded a Palestinian home, throwing stones while seven Palestinians were trapped inside, according to witnesses who spoke to *Reuters*.

Saddam Oday, one of those trapped, said the Israeli military fired tear gas into the home and detained the residents inside while letting him go. He said the Israeli military had not detained any of the settlers and had allowed them to leave.

The owner of the house, Luay Bayruti, said when the military arrived they hand-

cuffed, blindfolded and beat those inside.

The Israeli military said in a statement that troops and border police forces had arrived on the scene to remove "rioters" and protect the residents inside the house. The military did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

In his first public statement on Qusra, Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu said he condemned the violence in Qusra and blamed a "handful of rioters".

"I strongly condemn the criminal acts of violence committed in the villages of Qusra and Jalud," said Netanyahu, referring to a separate incident in a neighbouring village.

The US had previously pressured Netanyahu to publicly condemn militant settlers who had besieged Palestinians in their homes, US and Israeli officials told *Reuters* two weeks ago.



California Wildfire Spreads

Firefighters monitor the Plaskett Fire in the Big Sur area of California. The fire broke out in steep terrain, prompting evacuations and warnings for some isolated properties. Crews used aircraft and ground teams to contain the flames and prevent them from spreading through nearby canyons. AP

Pak PM suspends 8 officials after probe into hospital fire that killed 14 infants

Associated Press
Islamabad, August 29

PAKISTAN PRIME Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Saturday ordered the suspension of eight officials and directed that criminal proceedings be initiated against those found responsible for a fire that killed 14 newborns at an Islamabad hospital, his office said.

Sharif issued the orders after an investigative committee headed by retired senior civil servant Shahid Khan presented its interim report on Wednesday's fire at the Pakistan Institute of Medical Sciences, or PIMS, his office said in a statement.

The inquiry found the nursery had no fire alarm or sprinkler system and the hospital lacked detailed procedures and training for responding to fires and other emergencies, the statement said. He ordered departmental and criminal proceedings against those identified by the committee.

The eight included hospital's executive director, two joint executive directors, head of the neonatal department, two other doctors, the hospital's assistant director for security and the head of the Capital Development Authority's emergency services.

• BRIEFLY

ECUADOR

Former president Lenin Moreno sentenced to 5 years for corruption



Lenin Moreno Garces at 73rd session of the UN General Assembly. FILE

FORMER ECUADORIAN President Lenin Moreno was sentenced Friday to 5 years in prison after a court found him guilty of accepting bribes from a Chinese company in exchange for helping it secure a contract to build a hydroelectric plant. Moreno is 73 years old and has a physical disability that prevents him from walking. He will serve the sentence under house arrest. Moreno was convicted as a direct participant in the bribery scheme during his tenure as vice president under Rafael Correa. **REUTERS**

ZIMBABWE

27 killed after truck-minibus collide head-on

A COLLISION between a minibus taxi carrying church members and a truck killed 27 people Friday in Zimbabwe, a police spokesperson said. Paul Nyathi, the police spokesperson, said Saturday that the truck was trying to overtake another vehicle when it crashed with the minibus taxi near Chivhu town, 132 kilometers south of the capital, Harare. **AP**

PAKISTAN

3 cops hurt after gunmen attack police vehicle

THREE SECURITY personnel were injured on Saturday after unidentified gunmen opened fire at a police vehicle in northwest Pakistan, police said. The banned terror outfit Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan claimed responsibility for the targeted attack in the Tank district of the restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province. **PTI**

• THE HUMANOID ROBOTS LACK THE INTELLIGENCE NEEDED FOR GENERAL-PURPOSE WORK, LIMITING THEIR PRACTICAL USES, SAY EXPERTS

China can build kung fu-fighting robots; but it can't get them to do factory work

Laurie Chen, Eduardo Baptista & Ju-min Park
Liuzhou, August 29

INSIDE A training center in southern China, more than 100 humanoid robots stand in neat rows. A dozen human trainers wearing headsets guide some of them through simple tasks – sorting crates, packaging noodles, making coffee.

The humanoids are slow and awkward. A novice trainer might get them to produce one usable movement in 300 attempts; an experienced trainer, one in 50.

Robot maker UBTEch won an \$18 million tender from the Guangxi regional government last October to supply the train-

ing facility with humanoids and related hardware. The mission: to produce training data for so-called embodied AI – robots able to perceive, decide and act in the physical world. The trainers use headsets to see from the robots' perspective and handheld controllers fitted with sensors to translate their own movements into the robots' actions.

Teaching humanoids to handle labor-intensive work could one day meet an acute need. China's population is aging and shrinking, eroding a critical demographic advantage for its industrial base: a vast pool of workers. And China's military researchers have explored the potential uses of robotics and ar-

tificial intelligence in future weapons systems.

The Liuzhou center, which *Reuters* visited in April, aims to sell robot-training data to factories. But three staffers acknowledged the subsidy-dependent project currently has no clear path to profitability, citing high operating costs and low prices for its data in the nascent market.

UBTech and the Guangxi and Liuzhou governments didn't comment for this story.

The facility captures a central tension in China's humanoid push: Government funding and manufacturing investment are racing ahead of the robots' ability to operate outside of chor-



Humanoid robots at a Beijing innovation centre in March. REUTERS

eographed demonstrations – like the kung fu routines, dances and boxing matches that have made the machines internet sensations.

Though China's robot makers produce world-beating hardware, the humanoids lack the intelligence needed for general-purpose work, limiting their

practical uses, a half-dozen industry executives and researchers told *Reuters*. Critically, they struggle with situations requiring intuition or deviation from programmed routines.

"The robots' IQ is too low," said Tang Wenbin, co-founder and CEO of AI robotics venture Yuanli Lingji, at a March industry panel. "A lot of what we see is dancing disguised as working."

The humanoid-robot industry shipped about 20,000 units globally last year, with Chinese manufacturers accounting for 95%, according to BofA Global Research. Gan Xiaobin, an official at China's Ministry of Industry and Information Technology, said in July the country

expects to build more than 100,000 humanoids this year. BofA forecasts 1.2 million annual shipments globally by 2030.

The implications of China's supply-chain dominance extend beyond commercial competition. In July, the Trump administration banned imports of new Chinese humanoids, citing the need to protect the US AI industry from threats of disruption and cyberattacks.

Beijing's effort to build intelligent robots follows the industrial-policy blueprint it deployed for electric vehicles and solar panels: Subsidize a strategic sector, build capacity early, and stoke fierce competition to drive down costs. Such

investment serves China's ambition to win control of critical industrial technology and displace Western competitors.

But cars and solar were mature industries when China accelerated production.

Humanoids, by contrast, remain an early-stage technology with limited domestic or foreign demand and unresolved problems in dexterity, reliability, intelligence and cost, analysts and industry executives say. Government entities are at once major financiers and customers of the same robots – artificially boosting demand.

That all makes China's gamble on humanoids a riskier prospect. **REUTERS**

BRIDGE

Communications plays a very important part in planning bridge strategy. Like a general planning his assault on the enemies needs free movement from one flank to another, declarer also needs to move from his hand to dummy and back at opportune times. This he achieves by correct handling of his entries.Dealer: South Vulnerable: East/West

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ 10 9		♠ A 5	
♥ K J 9 5 3		♥ A	
♦ Q J		♦ K 10 7 5 4 3	
♣ Q J 4 2		♣ A K 10 3	
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
1♦	pass	1♥	pass
2♣	pass	3♣	pass
6♣	pass	pass	pass

West leads the spade king. Plan the play. South must discard his losing spade on dummy's king of hearts before knocking out the ace of diamonds. However, if he draws three rounds of trumps during this process, a four-one break in diamonds will leave declarer short an entry. For example, if the play began spade ace, club ace-king, heart ace, club jack, heart king (spade pitch), diamond, the defenders could win the ace of diamonds and force out the last trump from the closed hand by leading a spade or a heart - if diamonds broke four-one, declarer could not run the suit.

THE WEST HAND: ♠ K Q 8 2 ♥ 7 6 ♦ 9 8 6 2 ♣ 9 8 5
THE EAST HAND: ♠ J 7 6 4 3 ♥ Q 10 8 4 2 ♦ A ♣ 7 6

Instead, the play should go as follows: Spade ace, heart ace, a club to dummy's jack, the king of hearts to discard the five of spades; now declarer should lead one more round of trumps, then start diamonds. As the cards lie, East wins with the ace and leads a major; South trumps, leads a diamond to the remaining high diamond in dummy (protecting against a defender's holding a singleton diamond with only two trumps, losing nothing if diamonds break three-two), and gets back to the closed hand with the last high club to run the rest of the diamond suit and make the slam. If, during this process, the defenders are able to get a diamond ruff, declarer could not have made the contract by drawing trumps (because of the bad diamond break). Your problem for the week: Dealer: South Vulnerable: Both

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ K 5 4 2		♠ A J 8	
♥ K 10 7 5		♥ A J 9 6 4 2	
♦ 6 5 2		♦ K 7	
♣ 10 4		♣ K Q	
SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
1♥	dbl	2♥	pass
4♥	pass	pass	pass

West leads the club ace, then the club five; East plays the seven and nine. Plan the play.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

The best way to ____ one's word is not to ____ it. - Napoleon (4,...,4)

DGHEE

ANNEI

AGINGP

GIINKV

ANSWER: The best way to keep one's word is not to give it. - Napoleon

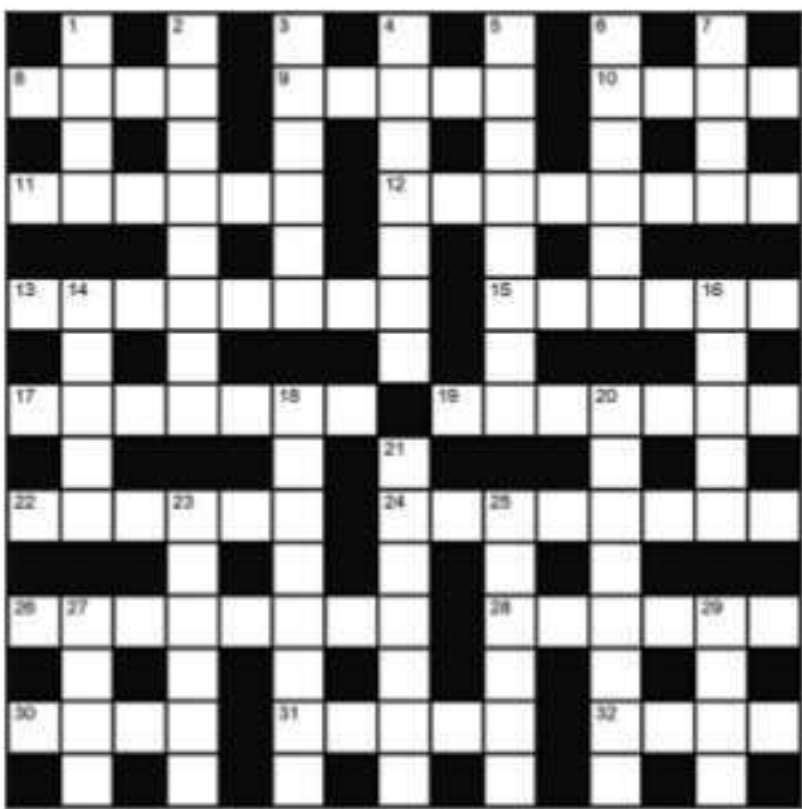
SOLUTIONS: Hedge, Inane, Gaping/Paying, Viking

• SUNDAY CROSSWORD

QUICK CLUES

- ACROSS**
8. Leap (4)
9. Abundant (5)
10. Auto maker Ferrari (4)
11. Get back (6)
12. Headlong plunge (8)
13. Secret, for the benefit of a select few (8)
15. Young bird of prey (6)
17. Give rise to (7)
19. Native of Flanders (7)
22. Untamed (6)
24. Huge (8)
26. Ghost (8)
28. Octavian's foe (6)
30. Grows older (4)
31. Pineapple fiber (5)
32. Angler's hope (4)

- DOWN**
1. Coarse fibre (4)
2. Began to grow ? (8)
3. One of the three Magi (6)
4. Green vegetable (7)
5. Film report (8)
6. Old sailor (3-3)
7. Northern arm of the Black Sea (4)
14. Arab state (5)
16. Listlessness (5)
18. Climbing plant (8)
20. Canadian province (8)
21. To stir up (7)
23. Military command (6)
25. ____ are sour : statement made by a



- disappointed man, perhaps ? (6)
27. Like omelettes (4)
29. With charges paid (4)
CRYPTIC CLUES
ACROSS
8. This lady went inside to cover a dish (4)
9. He'd gone on to remove the bushes (5)
10. Wild ox in favour, usually (4)
11. Fellows shortly to join villain (6)
12. Number holding fashionable statuette (8)
13. Is there a sign of a carry-on with water ? (8)
15. Cordial ambassador having his affectations (6)
17. High in graceful elegance but low in cunning (7)
19. Choose to dispense with long-handled tool (7)
22. Five hundred over paper money, for a change, indicates inaction (6)
24. High Churchman wanting God's favour (3,5)
26. Flatter and overwhelm (8)
28. Settle comfortably in finest leathers (6)
30. One offer in the same place (4)
31. Do cattle salute at the river-bend? (5)

SOLUTIONS TO 2596 QUICK CLUES ACROSS: 1 Dollops, 5 Swarmed, 10 Reno, 11 Oleaginous, 12 Ajay jadeja, 13 Ryes, 14 Gyroscope, 17 Fully, 19 Edits, 20 Embedding, 23 Oche, 25 Fraudulent, 28 Beforehand, 29 Tara, 30 Invents, 31 Spreads **DOWN:** 2 Overjoyed, 3 Loony, 4 Prosaic, 6 Wigwam, 7 Runaround, 8 Elude, 9 Pete, 15 On the move, 16 Pam, 18 Leningrad, 21 Ended up, 22 Effect, 24 Clean, 26 A sad, 27 Lathe **CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS:** 1 Offside, 5 Ash-tray, 10 Info, 11 Uneducated, 12 Bystanders, 13 Seth, 14 Grimalkin, 17 Boats, 19 Jeans, 20 Viability, 23 They, 25 Indentures, 28 Escalators, 29 Ados, 30 Gym shoe, 31 Swimmer **DOWN:** 2 Fancy-free, 3 Shoot, 4 Diurnal, 6 Squash, 7 Toad-stool, 8 Avert, 9 Dele, 15 Money-bags, 16 Illl, 18 Title role, 21 Bandsaw, 22 Figaro, 24 Husky, 26 Do ok, 27 Unarm

2597

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY AUGUST 30: This year your creativity, zest and desire for life are at a pinnacle! Enjoy socialising. Nurture the happiness and beauty that you have within. Loosen up a bit.

MONDAY AUGUST 31: This is a year of work and construction. Create foundations in your life, both externally and internally. Take charge of your health. Stay grounded and levelheaded.

TUESDAY SEPTEMBER 1: This is a slower paced year for you. Rejuvenate your energy. Focus on business and personal relationships with people who are kind, helpful and have your back.

WEDNESDAY SEPTEMBER 2: Kick back and relax this year. Let your guard down and loosen up a bit. Have fun but don't lose sight of your goals.

THURSDAY SEPTEMBER 3: It's time to build foundations in your life, both external and internal. Take charge of your health. Physical exercise will be important. Stay levelheaded.

FRIDAY SEPTEMBER 4: This year holds exciting changes and increased personal freedom for you. Let go of whatever holds you back. Seek out new opportunities. Travel and expand your horizons.

SATURDAY SEPTEMBER 5: This is a year of service, perhaps service to family. Take care of yourself so that you can be a support to others when they turn to you for guidance.

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Stay light on your feet today, because this is a fast-changing day. New faces and places might intrigue you. As the day wears on, you can enjoy socialising with others. This Week: Be happy in your work.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): This is a restless day. Those of you at work will enjoy the support of helpful co-workers. You will be forthright in your communications. This Week: You're enthusiastic and playful. Work as enjoyable.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): A friend might surprise you today. You might meet a real character. Later in the day, your involvement with a group will bring you joy. It's a great day for socialising and romance. This Week: Home and family, plus playful outings.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): You're high-viz today. Meanwhile, relations with bosses, parents, authority figures and the police might hold a surprise for you. As this day wears on, you might see ways to boost your income or purchase something special. This Week: A high-energy week! Redecorate and entertain.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Surprising opportunities to travel might fall in your lap today. Enjoy talking to others, especially people from different backgrounds. Seek out opportunities that expand your world. This Week: You'll charm everyone.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Discussions about how to share something will go well today. Something or someone might surprise you. You'll have a warm feeling in your tummy about everything. This Week: Playful competitions.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Today, someone close to you might surprise you. You might meet someone new and unusual, perhaps someone in the general public. Your involvement with a group of people will be rewarding. This Week: Shop for wardrobe items.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Your work routine will be interrupted today. It could be good or not so good. Take care to avoid accidents and equipment breakdowns. Later in the day, authority figures will favour you. This Week: Sociable times and secret love affairs.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): This is a great day to socialise. Enjoy vacation times, sports events and romantic outings. Because it's easy for you to feel friendly towards others today, the world will feel friendly to you. This Week: You're admired and popular.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): You want to relax at home and enjoy time in familiar surroundings. Your home routine might be interrupted by something today. Small appliances might break down. This Week: You impress authority figures. Patience with partners.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Pay attention to everything you say and do as this is a mildly accident-prone day. You will enjoy meeting new faces and encountering unusual people. You'll enjoy good times with partners, spouses and close friends. This Week: Work hard. Travel if possible.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Keep an eye on your money and your possessions today. Sports events and social outings will appeal. Later in the day you might discover some moneymaking ideas. This Week: Socialise.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Seikh Sajjan @ Shajan @ Manirul, S/o: Seikh Israfil, R/o: Jhuggi No-N38/B367, CD Park, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No.: 97/24, U/s: 25/54/59 ARMS ACT, P.S. Jahangir Puri, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Seikh Sajjan @ Shajan @ Manirul** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Seikh Sajjan @ Shajan @ Manirul** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Seikh Sajjan @ Shajan @ Manirul of P.S. Jahangir Puri, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.09.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
JMFC-07, North West, Room No. 06,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DPI/12202/NW/2026

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
ASSAM HEALTH INFRASTRUCTURE DEVELOPMENT AND MANAGEMENT SOCIETY (AHIDMS)

4th Floor, Nayanantara Supermarket, Sixmile, Guwahati-781022
No. 759997/2

REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL
NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING

Hiring of Consultancy Services for Strengthening Nursing Education, Research, Skills, and Center of Excellence in Assam.

The Project Director, Assam Health Infrastructure Development and Management Society (AHIDMS), invites proposals from eligible and reputed consulting firms/organizations with proven experience in providing consultancy services for strengthening Nursing Education, Research and Skills Development, and operationalization of a Centre of Excellence in Nursing in Assam, through the Quality- and Cost-Based Selection (QCBS) method.

The details may be seen in the Request for Bid document uploaded in the Assam E-procurement portal (<https://assamtenders.gov.in>) & <https://ahidms.assam.gov.in>

The applicant must be registered with the E- Tendering system (ETS) of the Govt. of Assam. (Website: <https://assamtenders.gov.in>). The Project Director, Assam Health Infrastructure Development & Management Society reserves the right to accept or reject all bids without showing any reasons whatsoever.

Sd/-
Project Director
Assam Health Infrastructure Development & Management Society

DIPR/CE/IXP/1399/30-AUG-26

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Shiv @Shivam** S/o Bhim, R/o H. No. 160, Naharpur, Sec-7, Rohini, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 317/23 Dated 02.09.2023 U/s 279/338 IPC, PS South Rohini, Delhi and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Shiv @ Shivam** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Shiv @Shivam** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Shiv @Shivam in FIR No. 317/23 Dated 02.09.2023 U/s 279/338 IPC, PS South Rohini, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.10.2026**.

By order
Sh. Gaurav Kataria
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
2nd Floor, Room No. 208
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DPI/12157/RD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

SEE SECTION 84 BHARTIYA NAGARIK SURKSHA SANHITA

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Aakash @ Nepali** S/o Laxman Singh R/o 11/77, Sec-18, Rohini, Delhi P/A Kharsa No.1174, Gali No.-3, Village - Kushak-2, near Kams Convert School, Swaroop Nagar, Delhi, have committed (or is suspected to has committed) the offence under FIR No. 470/2021 U/s 392/394/411 IPC., has been registered at PS: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Aakash @ Nepali** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Aakash @ Nepali** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Aakash @ Nepali** of under has been under. FIR No. 470/2021 U/s 392/394/411 IPC., registered at PS: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.10.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
JMFC-07, Room No. 06
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/12133/ON/2026
(Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Avantika Signatory of M/s Rudra Buildwell Constructions Pvt. Ltd. Address at: Flat No. 118A, Ground Floor, Pocket 6, MIG Flat, Mayur Vihar, Phase-III, Delhi-110096** Also at A 66, Sector 63 Road, Sector 63, Noida, UP-201301 Also at CS-01, 4th Floor, Ansal Plaza, Vaishali, Ghaziabad-201010 has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in CT Case No. 2805/2021 U/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Model Town, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Avantika** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Avantika** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Avantika of CT Case No. 2805/2021 U/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Model Town, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.10.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Aakash Sharma
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
North, Court No. 213, 2nd Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DPI/12191/NW/2026 (Court Matter)

SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

No-G27/138/NFR-COMM/E-Auction/SEY/2026 Date:27.08.2026

PRESS NOTIFICATION

E-AUCTION FOR RENOVATION, OPERATION AND MAINTENANCE (ROMT) OF THE RAILWAY BUILDING AT SEONI RAILWAY STATION (SEY) FOR DEVELOPMENT OF A BUDGET HOTEL, DORMITORY AND OPERATION OF AN OPEN EVENT SPACE

South East Central Railway, Nagpur Division invites online bids through e-Auction from reputed developers, hotel operators, hospitality firms, infrastructure companies, consortiums and interested investors for Renovation, Operation and Maintenance (ROMT) of the Railway Building at Seoni Railway Station (SEY) for development and operation of the following facilities:

• Budget Hotel • Dormitory Accommodation • Ground Floor Restaurant • Basement Parking • Open Event Space for marriage functions, social events, exhibitions, cultural programmes and similar activities.

Location: Seoni Railway Station (SEY), Nagpur Division, South East Central Railway, approximately 2.2 km from Seoni city and conveniently located for tourists visiting Pench and Kanha National Parks.

Contract Period: 10 years, extendable as per extant Railway policy and subject to satisfactory performance.

The premises shall be offered on "As Is Where Is" basis. Ownership of the land and building shall remain with the Railway Administration.

Mode of Auction: Online e-Auction through IREPS

Date of E-Auction: 07.09.2026, Time: 12:15 Hrs.

Interested bidders are required to register themselves on the IREPS portal under the "E-Auction Leasing" module and participate in the e-Auction after fulfilling the prescribed eligibility criteria and other terms and conditions. Detailed eligibility criteria, terms and conditions and other particulars are available in the e-Auction document on the IREPS portal.

Divisional Commercial Manager
for Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/SECR/Nagpur

PAM/42/106

f South East Central Railway @seccr

BIHAR SCHOOL EXAMINATION BOARD

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER

(Through e-procurement mode only over <https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in>)

Tender Notice No.: PR 196/2026

Bihar School Examination Board, Patna invites e-tenders under two bid systems from the reputed, experienced Firms /Companies/ Agencies/ Societies having adequate infrastructure and Experience of "Supply and Printing of Answer Books for Class 9th to 12th Students."

TENDER SCHEDULE

Date and Time for Activity	Date/Time: Duration
Online Sale/ Download Date of Tender Documents	From 31/08/2026 (16:00 Hrs.) to 21/09/2026 (16:00 Hrs.) (https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
Pre-Bid Meeting	07/09/2026 at 12:30 Hrs. (Bihar School Examination Board, Sinha Library Road, Patna-800017)
Last Date/ Time for Submission/ uploading of Online Bid	21/09/2026 up to 16:00 Hrs. (https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
Last Date and Time for submission of EMD in Hard Copy/ Original (Only in case of BG)	22/09/2026 at 13:00 Hrs.
Date & Time for Opening of Technical Bid	22/09/2026 at 15:00 Hrs (https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in)
Date & Time for Opening of Financial Bid	Date to be announced later by competent authority.
Cost of the Tender Document	₹ 5,900/- (Five Thousand Nine Hundred Rupees) (Non-Refundable)
Tender Processing Fee	₹ 5,900/- (Five Thousand Nine Hundred Rupees) (Non-Refundable)
Earnest Money	₹ 1,00,000/- (One Lakh Rupees) (Refundable)
• Contact Details: Nodal Officer, Mobile No. : +91 62999 23095, E-Mail ID: eproc-bseb-bih@gov.in eproc.bseb@gmail.com • Note: Bihar School Examination Board reserves the right to accept/ cancel/ reschedule tenders without assigning any reasons. Prospective bidders are advised to regularly visit https://eproc2.bihar.gov.in . Corrigendum/ Amendments etc., if any, will be notified on this portal only and no separate advertisement will be made.	

Secretary

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Rohit Gujrati, S/o: Lala, R/o: H.No. 136, Gali No. 6 Chanchal Park Rannahola, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 56/26, U/s: 304(2) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023, PS: Dwarka North, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Rohit Gujrati**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Rohit Gujrati**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Rohit Gujrati**, of FIR No. 56/26, U/s: 304(2) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023, PS: Dwarka North, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **12.10.2026**.

By Order
Rahul Katara
Judicial Magistrate First Class-06
South-West District Court No. 514
Dwarka Court, New Delhi

DP/11903/DWD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Mohd. Sharif, S/o Saukat Ali, R/o H.No. 55A, Sarai Kale Khan, New Delhi, Sunlight Colony, South-East** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 48/2025, U/s 33 D. Excise Act 2009, P.S. Hazrat Nizamuddin, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Mohd. Sharif** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Mohd. Sharif** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Mohd. Sharif** accused of FIR No. 48/2025, U/s 33 D. Excise Act 2009, P.S. Hazrat Nizamuddin, New Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.09.2026**.

By Order - Sh. Manuj Kaushal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03, South-East
DP/12211/SE/2026 Room No. 512, Saket Courts, New Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Priyanka W/o Dushyant Singh R/o P-27, Krishan Vihar, Budh Vihar, Rohini, Delhi** Also At: H. No. 47, Nandpuri, Kanker Khara, Meerut, Uttar Pradesh has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 517/2021 U/s 370(4)/34 IPC & 75/81 JJ Act, PS Paschim Vihar West, Delhi and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Priyanka** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Priyanka** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Priyanka** of case FIR No. 517/2021 U/s 370(4)/34 IPC & 75/81 JJ Act, PS Paschim Vihar West, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **30.09.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sunil Kumar
Ld. Additional Sessions Judge-07
Pocso West, Room No. 216
Tis Hazari Court, New Delhi

DP/12087/OD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Laxmi Narayan S/o Sh. Rajender R/o H. No. 2734 , Gali No. 6, Jain Nagar, Karala Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 500/2019 U/s 457/380/411 IPC PS Kanjhawala, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Laxmi Narayan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Laxmi Narayan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Laxmi Narayan** accused of case FIR No. 500/2019 U/s 457/380/411 IPC PS Kanjhawala, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.09.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Apoorv Bhardwaj
JMFC-02, Room No. 113
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/12188/RD/2026
(Court Matter)

India will miss Jemimah at Asia Cup, says Muzumdar



Jemimah Rodrigues is sidelined with a hamstring injury. PTI

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 29

INDIA WILL embark on their bid to reclaim the Women's Asia Cup title on Sunday with a nearly full-strength squad, save for their player for 'clutch' moments, Jemimah Rodrigues. The top-order batter will not be featuring in this competition and next month's Asian Games, owing to a hamstring injury she sustained during The Hundred Women's. Rodrigues is currently undergoing rehabilitation at the Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru, and Pratika Rawal — who is yet to play a T20I or a Women's Premier League fixture — has been named as her replacement.

Ahead of India's campaign opener against Thailand, head coach Anol Muzumdar acknowledged that Rodrigues' absence will be felt by the Indian team. "Speaking about Jemimah, I have always maintained that she is a clutch player for us. She will definitely be missed. But having said that, her recovery is very important for us. She will be missed. There are some other players who have come into the team, and I am sure they will do well. But having said that, Jemimah will be missed," he told reporters.

While India will walk into this tournament as outright favourites — having won seven of the nine editions, current form has been a cause of concern for the 50-over world champions. Harmanpreet Kaur's girls have lost nine of their last 16 T20Is, including a group stage exit at the ICC Women's T20 World Cup in June.

Muzumdar, though, is not concerned about form — or the lack of it. "We don't pay too much attention to form. You are talking about 16 T20Is in the last 6 months. But at the same time, we know what scope of improvement this team has got. This is a young side. We are trying to play aggressive cricket. And from here on, we will try and set the tone for the next six months."

Among the most anticipated games of the tournament is the clash between India and Pakistan, which will be played on September 5.

On being asked whether his players will shake hands with their Pakistani counterparts, Muzumdar replied: "Look, we try to play the best cricket on the ground. And off-the-field stuff, we don't focus on. We will speak about this (shaking hands) when we play that game (against Pakistan). But at the moment, we are focusing on the Thailand game."

WOMEN'S ASIA CUP: India vs Thailand, 8 pm onwards on Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV

BAPTISM BY FIRE

Dinusha's journey: Father drove a tuk-tuk, son bats like a dream

SL batter stamped his class with three centuries against India, but to get to the top he had to battle adversity

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, August 29

ON THURSDAY, Susantha Gamage did not arrive at the Sinhalese Sports Club Ground on his tuk-tuk. He no longer needs to drive one. His son, Sonal Dinusha, now earns enough to take care of the family's needs.

But for seven hours, the father might have remembered the years he did — ferrying his boy from ground to ground on his tuk-tuk, aware, always, of the disparity between the child's dreams and his own means. For seven hours, India threw everything at his son during the second Test. For seven hours, Shubman Gill and Gautam Gambhir used every trick up their sleeve, every weapon in their arsenal to dislodge the Sri Lanka No.6. For seven hours, India searched, probed for a single Sri Lankan wicket.

In the end, they stood stunned, realising it was but an exercise in futility.

264 deliveries. 133 runs. Nearly 500 minutes of resilience, spread across two days. The 25-year-old southpaw, only 5 Tests old, had done what Sri Lanka had not managed since 2015 — denied India a Test victory on Lankan soil.

When it was finally over, when the visitors had accepted their fate and retreated into the customary pleasantries, and when Dinusha stood absorbing the Colombo crowd's applause, his father, eyes wet, turned to the man beside him.

Sonal Dulshan Elwalage — a former Sri Lankan domestic cricketer, now known simply as Dinusha's childhood coach.

"I was watching the game with his family. When it ended, his father told me 'I entrusted you to take care of my son. This would not have happened without you'," Elwalage tells *The Indian Express* from Colombo.

Though, it was not only one particular individual. Behind Dinusha's rise, says his coach, is a community that allowed him to dream.

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 29

SURYAKUMAR YADAV, India's T20 World Cup-winning captain, was dropped just two months after he guided the team to the title. The decision surprised many at the time but the BCCI reportedly felt it was the right time to move on and appointed Shreyas Iyer as the new captain.

In an interaction with Aa-



Sonal Dinusha (top) scored 103 and 133 not out in the second Test against India; batter with his parents and sister. AP/SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

"Sonal's father was a tuk tuk driver. His family did not have much money for Sonal to pursue an expensive sport like cricket. Within his means, his father gave him everything he could to support his career. He would drive Sonal to training sessions on his tuk tuk. He would tell him not to worry about a thing but his game," the coach recalls.

Difficult period

And yet, there were times, inevitably, when money became something to worry about for a batsman who now has three centuries in two Tests against India.

"There were difficult periods in Sonal's career when money was a real problem. There were even times when he did not have proper accommodation. But Sonal never allowed those difficulties to become excuses. He put together

whatever money he earned from playing cricket to solve his problems himself."

At times, the cricket money was enough to keep his hopes alive. On other occasions, it wasn't. That was when the coaches stepped up.

"His coaches took care of the financial part. Kalum Gango-dawila, a coach with the Colombo Cricket Club, made sure he always had the cricket gear he needed to play. We all knew that Sonal would make it big one day, and we did all we could to ensure money doesn't stand between him and his dreams."

Elwalage is only eight years senior to Dinusha, but says they share a 'father-son' bond, because through his protégé, he is living out his own unfinished dream. "Sonal and I both studied at De La Salle College in Colombo. I was his senior in the college team. While playing, I also started coaching the



“There were difficult periods in Sonal's career when money was a real problem. But he never allowed those difficulties to become excuses.”

SONAL DULSHAN ELWALAGE,
DINUSHA'S CHILDHOOD COACH.

Under-13 team on the side. Sonal was one of the first kids I worked with. He was only 12 at the time."

Perseverance

Even then, two things set him apart — his penchant for spending long hours on the ground, and his love for the longest format of the game.

"When we used to practice, Sonal would spend three to four hours in the nets daily. You simply couldn't get him out of the ground. Ever since he was a kid, he wanted to bat as long as possible, and he had this unique passion for Test cricket. There were days where he would enter the nets in the morning, and leave only at night. Patience became his big-

gest strength, as we saw in the Colombo Test."

When he brought up his century on Thursday — his third of the series — his family and coach could barely contain themselves. Dinusha, though, was subdued in his celebration. "That is how he always has been. One of his greatest strengths is his humility. Even today, when he is a national team player, he prefers a simple lifestyle over the worldly things that he surely can afford now."

Across the two Tests, Dinusha batted for nearly 19 hours. He faced a total of 722 deliveries — 224 more than his nearest competitor. Gary Kirsten, Sri Lanka's coach, would call it 'one of the great saves of Sri Lankan Test cricket.' Gill, drained and in disbelief after fielding for 243.4 overs straight, would acknowledge "I don't think there was even half-a-chance."

Sri Lanka had escaped defeat. At the heart of it stood a boy who had learned, long before he ever wore the national cap, exactly how escapes are made. "Cricket, for Sonal, was the only escape route from his family's financial problems. He knew that if he wanted to change his circumstances, he had to make something of himself through the sport. Perhaps, that is where his determination and his mental strength comes from. When he plays, he does not give up easily because he knows what he has had to overcome to get there," Elwalage said.

Rasheed, the 21-year-old gearing up to become next Test mainstay



Shaik Rasheed scored 627 runs in eight Ranji games last season. SLIC

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 29

AT THE BCCI Centre of Excellence, Shaik Rasheed has just taken a blow to the ribs. It's enough to floor him, force a short break, an ice pack, a moment to sit. When he gets back up and returns to the nets, he asks the throwdown specialist to send the same ball that troubled him. For the next 30-odd minutes he works through it, his back-foot cover drives the pick of the lot by the end.

It's the influence of Joe Root in him, a batsman whose videos he watches constantly, idolises enough to have the same "66" on the back of his T-shirt. "I watch a lot of Root's videos," Rasheed tells *The Indian Express*. "I really like his back-foot punch cover drive because it is my favourite shot. When I see his batting, I learn a lot. I can connect with him. When I watch him play, I feel I'm playing. I want to learn from him how he constructs his innings in different conditions."

On Sunday, when South Zone take on North Zone in the Duleep Trophy semi-final at CoE in Bengaluru, Rasheed begins the new season with renewed hope that he remains among the top-order batsmen selectors are watching closely. Devdutt Padikkal has sealed the No. 3 spot for now, but the 21-year-old is among the pool being prepared for the Test team. His childhood coach, NS Ganesh, has had one message in Rasheed's ear for seven years now: "After Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma, you should be the one who takes their spot in the long run."

Rasheed still has a long way to go. But the signs are encouraging. Having come through the India Under-19 team that won the 2022 World Cup, last Ranji season marked a coming of age for the Andhra batsman. He scored 627 runs in eight games at an average of 89.57, including three centuries and two fifties, which earned him a spot on India A's recent tour of Sri Lanka. He managed 63, 20 and 45 against Sri Lanka A, but he knows those numbers aren't enough on their own.

"I need to grab the opportunities. In India it is not easy to get one, and when I get a chance, I should be responsible, because there is so much competition. I want to get the Test cap. But at the same time, I shouldn't get desperate. It is a process. From Under-19, I came to Ranji and now India A. So to get to the next step, I should

evolve as a batsman," he says.

Part of that evolution has meant learning to bat against the Kookaburra ball. During the A series in Sri Lanka, Rasheed admits struggling to pick the Kookaburra deliveries, and leaned on coach Hrishikesh Kanitkar for help. "I'm grateful for that A team tour, because when I went I didn't know how to bat against the Kookaburra ball. I was struggling to pick which side the shine was on. So Rishi Sir helped me learn how to pick the shine," he says.

Shadow practice

Rasheed credits his recent form to a habit of shadow practice before games, picked up during the IPL and continued ever since. "Before a game, I shadow practice a lot. For example, if I'm going to face Mitchell Starc in my next game, I would close my eyes, imagine he is bowling at me, and play the shots. Be it defence or playing shots, I would do everything." He kept it up through the domestic season too, when he scored three centuries in four matches. "When it comes to domestic cricketers, I ensure that I get the videos from the analysts and ensure I follow the same routine. Visualisation plays a big role for me in the build-up to a game," he says.

While his peers made headlines in the IPL, Rasheed, despite being with Chennai Super Kings for three seasons, played only six matches. This season he watched from home before heading to the CoE for the red-ball season. Asked if it feels like a missed opportunity, he disagrees. "The IPL was a big learning curve for me. From Mike Hussey I learned a lot, particularly from his experience of batting in different situations. It was he who taught me to take control of the game when a door opens, and how to build once you lay a platform. As a top-order batsman, these are valuable lessons for me. After a long wait, when I played the IPL, I was playing for myself rather than the team. When I get an opportunity, I would be a different batsman," he says.

That's the version of Rasheed nobody has seen enough of yet, the one his coach keeps insisting is coming. For now, there's the throwdown specialist, the ball that hurt him, and the demand to have it bowled again.

DULEEP TROPHY SEMIFINALS: Central Zone vs East Zone, South Zone vs North Zone, 9:30 am onwards, JioHotstar and Star Sports Network

US OPEN

Jovic banking on Djokovic's mentorship, malleable mind to soar higher

Bhuvan Gupta
New Delhi, August 29

SOMETIMES, IT'S about shooting your shot. Iva Jovic's mother, Jelena, did it when she applied for an American green card through the lottery, and got it. Iva's coach, Kathy Rinaldi, did it too, when she walked up to Novak Djokovic at Wimbledon 2025.

"We were practising on the indoor courts at Wimbledon and he (Novak) just walked into a court close to us. His son was playing, and Kathy was like, 'Let's go up to him right now!' I was like, 'Kathy!' Iva was quoted as saying by *tennis.com*.

Introductory greetings were exchanged. A more detailed conversation followed at the Australian Open in January 2026. The 24-time major winner told Iva not to be hasty with her

shots, and to hit more of them closer to the sidelines. She heeded the advice, and beat eighth seed Jasmine Paolini, her first win over a top-10 opponent.

A student-mentor relationship has since developed between the 18-year-old and the 39-year-old, both competing in the US Open main draw starting Sunday. Iva, like Novak, has Serbian roots. Her mother, Jelena, is from Croatia, but her father, Bojan, is Serbian, and Serbian is a staple language at home.

"For my parents, it was really important to them that I spoke Serbian, so that I could speak with my grandparents, my aunts and uncles," Iva said last year, in a Cincinnati Open interview. "I'm super grateful that I have that, because now at these international events, it's another group of people that I can com-



United States' Iva Jovic is ranked 14th in women's singles. REUTERS

municate with," she added. Novak, perhaps, is foremost on that list. That her idol turned out to be "even kinder and even more attentive outside the cameras than what he's por-

trayed" has likely strengthened the bond. The California-born teenager's main aim is to absorb Djokovic's growth mindset on tour. She hopes to hold onto the same "open-minded men-

the person they have chosen. I played a lot of cricket with Shreyas and I know he is a good player, a good human being, good captain also," he added.

Surya's form with the bat was a big concern. He has endured a prolonged poor run over the last two years, with his fortunes plummeting in the 2026 IPL season as well. While he finished with a half-century against the Rajasthan Royals, Surya only managed 270 runs

in 13 innings, averaging 20.76 this season.

"I was not like 'why did they make him (Shreyas) the captain?' But yes, I was a little disappointed. Because you have not lost a single series in two years. You have won the World Cup and the Asia Cup. Then you want the same thing to go forward. Because when everything is going well, then why? What is the reason for the change?" Surya said.

week is incredible. Not being stubborn in your ways, making changes, making improvements, is very important."

Change and growth have been constants since her Grand Slam main draw debut in New York in 2024. Just 16 and ranked No. 389 at the time, Iva made an impact right away. The wildcard entrant upset Magda Linette in the first round, becoming the youngest American to win a US Open women's singles main draw match since 2000.

A breakthrough WTA 500 title in Guadalajara, a final at the Hobart International, and an Australian Open quarter-final run followed. Iva is now the top-ranked under-19 player on the circuit, at 14th overall.

Novak feels Iva "definitely has all the tools to be a future champion and a future number

one." Her compatriot Coco Gauff believes Iva will continue "to do damage" on tour, while the more experienced Jessica Pegula calls her a "mini me." Hitting the ball early, packing power into her returns, and opening up the court with her backhand are the traits Pegula likes most.

Even when world No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka beat Iva 6-3, 6-0 in the Melbourne Park quarter-finals, she had words of praise for her. "In the second set I felt like I have to step in and put even more pressure on her, because I can see that she's young, she's hungry, and I could tell during the match that no matter what's the score, she's still going to be there trying and trying to figure her way," Sabalenka said.

The youngster's road hasn't been without bumps. Early hard-court successes were fol-

lowed by below-par showings on the same surface through North America, second-round exits in Toronto and Cincinnati, heading into Flushing Meadows. But Iva can take heart from a relatively kind draw, opening against Poland's world No. 47 Magdalena Frech.

There's the possibility of a delightful third-round meeting with good friend Alexandra Eala. The American-Filipino pair faced off at the Stars of the Open exhibition event, and invited their fathers onto the court for a warm, reel-worthy moment. That warmth might fade in four-odd days, if the two rising stars meet again. For Alexandra, there's a huge fanbase to please. For Iva, there's a third straight head-to-head win to claim.

US OPEN MAIN DRAW: 8:30 pm onwards on JioHotstar and Star Sports Network

‘Competitive spirit gives ego... You don’t take a loss lightly’

GCT champion talks about his learnings, finding confidence again after Candidates

Mayank Chaudhary & Amit Kamath
New Delhi/Mumbai, August 29

PRAGGNANANDHAA is riding a wave. He missed out on his biggest target of the year — the Candidates, where he finished seventh out of eight players — but quickly realigned his goals, and conquered Norway Chess and now the Grand Chess Tour’s season-ending finale. In winning both those titles, there was some history to be made as well, since no Indian had ever won those two events before Pragg got there.

A day after his Grand Chess Tour Final triumph, Praggnanandhaa sat down with *The Indian Express* for a free-flowing interview on all things chess. He spoke about enjoying his chess, finding his confidence again after the Candidates, why he would even be okay with being a reserve player in India’s Olympiad team and a lot more. *Excerpts*

You’ve had a crazy year: Norway Chess, now the Grand Chess Tour Final. Have you changed something in your training or fitness?

No, nothing special. I worked a lot for Candidates and other tournaments and I think it’s showing off now. I’m just enjoying chess right now. In the last two years, I was focusing on Candidates, but now I’m just having fun with the game.

Did not making it to



EXPRESS interview | RPRAGGNANANDHAA GRAND CHESS TOUR WINNER

Candidates free you up mentally?

Yeah, could be. Ideally, you want to do well there (at the Candidates). In a way, the results are coming a bit late, but I’m happy that it’s showing off now. It shows that I can play well in all formats.

How would you rate this GCT title in your career?

It’s high up there. Every tournament is special in its own way. Norway Chess... coming back from last place, Wijk (Wijk aan Zee - Tata Steel Masters in 2025) was special in its own way. I also won some GCT tournaments in between but of course, when you win a final, the whole tour, it’s amazing. I think it’s somewhere on top with Wijk aan Zee 2025 and Norway Chess 2026.

After the Candidates disappointment, did you ever imagine this year

I was seeing was pretty decent. I was playing good quality chess compared to the Candidates or tournaments before that.

Does confidence only come from winning, or can it come from training?

You have to believe that you can be the best. That is also a form of confidence. So for me, as you said, you can get confidence from training as well. I was confident before the Candidates because I felt I was doing well in training. I felt confident going into the tournament and I won the first game. So I thought this could be the tournament. But then a few games later, I was in seventh position or something, trying to fight for the last spot. So all these things are great, but ultimately what you do on the board is what matters.

Hikaru Nakamura said all top players are arrogant and that even Indian players are not an exception to this. Do you agree with that view?

We all want to win. So when we lose, we don’t take it lightly. We all have an ego. But I think most chess players are nice. But when it comes to chess, we all want to beat each other. There is a competitive spirit. That does give you some ego. When you lose, you don’t take it lightly.

Two back-to-back rapid wins against Fabiano Caruana, or two classical wins against Magnus Carlsen in the same event, what would you choose?

Both were important. Both were needed to win the tournament. I’ll have to take both. Without one of them, I wouldn’t have won.

How tough was it to deal with the Candidates performance?

It’s disappointing when you don’t do well. Obviously, at the Candidates, I was really hoping for this cycle. I was looking at the Candidates already from November or December 2024 itself. And of course, it’s disappointing when it ends in such a way. But it happens. It’s just one tournament and anyone can have a bad event. I took some lessons from it and moved on. I don’t think anyone of us were in the fight, Javokhir Sindarov just did too well.

You’ve been playing continuously. How do you recover mentally?

Usually, nowadays I try to avoid playing too much. My schedule towards the end of the year is going to be very light. This is for everyone who played the GCT. If you make it to the finals, you have to play for a month. That’s why we saw a lot of mistakes in the finals and semifinals (at GCT). It happens when everyone is tired.

You said GCT is second only to the World Championship. Did you actually mean it?

No, when I say World Championship, I mean the cycle. The cycle’s ultimate goal is the World Championship match. So when I say World Championship, I mean the whole cycle to get there. But I believe if you take the World Championship cycle out of the equation, the Grand Chess Tour is still an important thing. You have to prove yourself in a series of tournaments and then do it again in the finals. It takes a lot of effort from players. I believe this is up there. There are a few tournaments in chess that are extremely important like Wijk aan Zee, Norway Chess, and the Grand Chess Tour events. I think the World Championship cycle, these are the most important events.

Coach-protégé duo headed towards symbiotic greatness

Mayank Chaudhary & Amit Kamath
New Delhi/Mumbai, August 29



Vaibhav Suri has been coaching Pragg after RB Ramesh, his long time coach decided to focus on his academy Chess Gurukul. GCT

about his GCT title win, he ended up spending most of his time talking about Suri. It was his way of paying the master back. “He completely messed up his sleep schedule because of me. He couldn’t come here because of some visa issues, but he stayed connected with me despite the massive time difference. His sleep cycle must have been completely ruined. Huge credit to him. He was basically up throughout the night,” Pragg had said.

Specifically, Pragg praised Suri’s work ethic. “He worked probably more than me in this tournament. He is a dedicated person. He worked a lot. It’s difficult to put it in hours or words. He basically always has a plan for my next game before I even finish the game. So it’s much easier for me to come back and decide for the next games,” Pragg told *The Indian Express*.

Never exhausted

“Even when I’m playing Rapid and Blitz games, he’s always there checking if there is some improvement needed or if we need to shift to a different opening or something. It’s nice to have someone like that who is always there to help. Huge thanks to him. As I said, doing it remotely with this time difference is difficult,” he added.

If asked to do so, Suri would happily sacrifice his sleep cycle for Pragg again. For the motivation he has, it’s a small price to pay. “I get very excited by the work I do. And honestly, I was willing to do whatever it takes to help Pragg. It’s completely okay for me. The fact that both Pragg and I are fairly well aligned on things makes it very easy,” he said.

“The stakes were so high. Between Pragg and I, we both understand and are willing to do genuinely whatever it takes to put our best. Make sure that there is no effort lacking from our end,” affirmed the coach.

While Praggnanandhaa put his GCT win second only to the World Championship, given the gruelling nature of the tour and the quality of the field, Suri has no favourites. For him, every tournament, every win, every move matters. “St. Louis Rapid and Blitz, Sinquefeld Cup, Tata Steel Masters, Norway Chess... everything was very important,” he said.

Now that the title is won, one would expect the sleep cycle to be fixed.

Not quite. It has to wait. Suri is already deep into preparation for India’s men’s Chess Olympiad title defence, working alongside Sankalp Gupta and N Srinath.

Argentina stun Dutch at home, win hockey World Cup title



Argentina defeated the host Netherlands in a penalty shootout. REUTERS

Press Trust of India
Amstelveen, August 29

ARGENTINA SNAPPED co-host the Netherlands’ dream run of four consecutive women’s FIH World Cup titles by winning the crown, defeating the Dutch side 3-1 in penalty shoot-out after both the teams were locked 1-1 at end of the regulation time here on Saturday. Argentina, thus, avenged their last World Cup and Tokyo Olympics final defeat to win their third title.

The first goal was scored in the 30th minute by Netherlands Yibbi Jansen, considered the world’s number one drag-flicker. Argentina received eight penalty corners in the match, and captain Maria Granatto converted the eighth penalty corner to equalise on a rebound in the 54th minute, forcing the match into a penalty shootout.

In the shootout Marjin Veen scored for the Netherlands while Pien Sanders and Felice Albers missed. For Argentina Victoria Granatto, Brisa Bruggesser and Sofia Cairo scored while Zoe Diaz’s goal was disallowed on referral.

India finish eighth

Captain Harmanpreet Singh’s last-gasp penalty-corner strike took the match into a shoot-out but India finished eighth at the FIH World Cup after losing 3-4 to co-hosts Belgium. Harmanpreet forced a shoot-out after the two sides were locked 3-3 in regulation time.

● HUGE BLOW FOR INDIA

Neeraj ruled out of Asian Games with an ankle injury

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 29

IN A major setback for Indian athletics, star javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra has been ruled out of the rest of the season, including the Asian Games and the Diamond League Final, after sustaining a ligament tear in his ankle during training.

The two-time Olympic medalist had shown promising signs of form at the Lausanne Diamond League, where he recorded a season-best throw. However, the injury has forced him to cut his season short.

“After a period of hard work, I finally felt I was gaining the momentum I had been looking for with a Season’s Best throw in Lausanne,” Chopra said in a statement. “Unfortunately, shortly after, I sustained a ligament tear in my ankle during training. After discussions with my doctor and team, we’ve decided that I will sit out the rest of this season.”

The Lausanne Diamond League was Chopra’s third competitive outing of the 2026 season, following the Doha Diamond League and the Commonwealth Games. He made his comeback in Doha in June after a lengthy injury layoff, finishing fourth with a throw of 85.69m. He followed that with a silver in Glasgow, where his best throw measured 85.83m.

Mixed season

The 28-year-old had a mixed 2026 season. While his Glasgow performance earned him a podium finish, he was upstaged by Sri Lanka’s Rumesh Pathirage, who won gold with a massive 89.75m throw. The Lausanne Diamond League was supposed to be a stepping stone towards the Asian Games, where Chopra was expected to lead India’s medal charge. Instead, it turned out to be his final competitive outing of the season.

“It’s disappointing, especially because I felt close to finding my rhythm,” he added. “But setbacks are a part of the journey. My focus now is on re-



Neeraj Chopra won gold medal at the 2022 Asian Games. PTI

“After a period of hard work, I finally felt I was gaining the momentum I had been looking for with a Season’s Best throw in Lausanne. Unfortunately, shortly after, I sustained a ligament tear in my ankle during training.”

NEERAJ CHOPRA, POSTED ON X.

covering well and coming back even stronger.”

Chopra’s absence will be a huge blow to India’s medal hopes at the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, which begin next month. He will also miss the Diamond League Final, where he was in contention to qualify after climbing to seventh in the standings.

He recorded his season best of 88.05m at Lausanne and the finish gave some hope to the Indian fans as he looked to find his rhythm again.

One of the most consistent javelin throwers on the circuit, Neeraj came back from a long

injury sustained during the 2025 Tokyo World Championships where he had finished eighth.

In Neeraj’s absence, the onus of javelin will fall on Rohit Yadav who has a personal best and season best of 87.68m. However, despite crossing 87m twice this season, Rohit has failed to replicate the form at Commonwealth Games in Glasgow.

Later in the day, Athletics Federation of India said that the replacement will be announced soon. “Neeraj Chopra has informed AFI that he has sustained an injury and will be unable to participate in the forthcoming Asian Games Aichi-Nagoya 2026,” AFI wrote on X. “AFI will announce the replacement in the men’s javelin throw shortly,” it added further.

Commonwealth Games bronze medalist Yashvir Singh is expected to be the likely replacement after he missed out earlier despite qualifying due to squad restrictions.

In the final of javelin throw at Glasgow, Sri Lankan thrower Rumesh Pathirage had won gold medal with 89.75m, Neeraj took silver with 85.83m and in his last throw, Yashvir produced personal best of 85.41m to win the bronze medal and ensure that two Indians were on the podium.

SHANKAR IAS ACADEMY™
Best Academy for Civil Services Exam Coaching

presents

EXPRESS explained.Live

CAN INDIA AND BANGLADESH Find Common Ground Again ?


Pinak Ranjan Chakravarty
Former Indian High Commissioner to Bangladesh

In conversation with


Shubhajit Roy
Diplomatic Editor, The Indian Express

How much does Sheikh Hasina’s shadow impact ties?

How does PM Tarique Rahman look at the current situation?

How can India and Bangladesh reset and repair ties?

Should India be worried about the security situation in Bangladesh?

Can Delhi and Dhaka work on economic and development projects?

How do China and Pakistan view and influence the current situation in Bangladesh?

02 Sept 2026, 6:00 PM
Join us on Zoom


Scan to Register

The Indian EXPRESS
JOURNALISM OF COURAGE

EYE

AUGUST 30, 2026



Inside Trump’s Second Act

In *Regime Change*, American journalists Maggie Haberman and Jonathan Swan look at what has shaped Trump’s second term

Gaggan Anand back in Delhi with Raga



Nothing brings the mind to its knees as a good crossword. Meet the setters behind the world’s toughest clues, the art of the perfect ‘aha’ moment, and why technology is not yet a formidable rival to the human mind

Where EVERY SQUARE has two answers

Trisha Mukherjee

Riddle me this: I am home to angry words/the key lies in a turn of phrase or between the lines/ those who open the right boxes find rare joy/ who am I?

AROUND THE 1770s, a man called John Spilsbury mounted a world map on a piece of wood. He cut it into arbitrary pieces to be put together by his students as an educational exercise. He called them dissected maps. Today we know it as the jigsaw puzzle, named after the tool used to manufacture it. This, possibly, was the origin of puzzles as we know it.

Since then, puzzles have entertained us in different forms and shapes, from riddles and spelling bees to logic, Wordle, Sudoku and crossword, which remains the most popular among puzzlers, both in analogue and digital versions.

In the 1940s, *The New York Times* (NYT) introduced its crossword — after dismissing it as a “primitive sort of mental development” two decades earlier — as a distraction in the bleak aftermath of the Pearl Harbour bombing, marking the beginning of puzzles as an entertainment phenomenon. Today, NYT’s major revenue generator is its games subsidiary — NYT Games. A Statista report published in February 2026, noted, “In the second quarter of 2024,

tween and underneath the surface. A solver is curious and their never-give-up attitude nearly epitomises human resilience. But, without a good puzzle, there is no good solver.

Will Shortz, editor of *The New York Times* crossword, equates a good puzzle with a work of art: An attractive crossword grid full of interesting, colourful, lively vocabulary, where every square appears in two answers.

“The whole point of a puzzle is to entertain the solver. You want the solver to win, and you want to push the solver to reach that goal,” says Shortz, 73, who is arguably the only person in the world to have a college degree in Enigmatology, the academic study of puzzles, a major he designed himself at Indiana University.

Shortz’s all-time favourite clue appeared in *The New York Times* on November 5, 1996. It was Election Day to call the race between Democrat Bill Clinton and Republican Bob Dole. The clue for the 7-letter ACROSS answer read: ‘Lead Story in tomorrow’s paper!’ The DOWN clues from the answer were created such that it could be the name of either candidate (CLINTON or BOB DOLE) and the grid would still work.

Broadly, there are two types of crosswords: Quick, which is American with straightforward clues; and Cryptic, of British origin and followed in most former colonies of the British empire, including India, Australia and New Zealand. A cryptic clue is never what it seems. There are rules and devices — anagram, charades, container — using which you are required to break the clue in parts, indulge in wordplay before the answer reveals itself.

For both, though, a delicate balance is essential — not so hard that it makes the solver give up, but not too easy that the win doesn’t feel earned.

Australian puzzle setter David Astle has the best analogy — an apple tree.

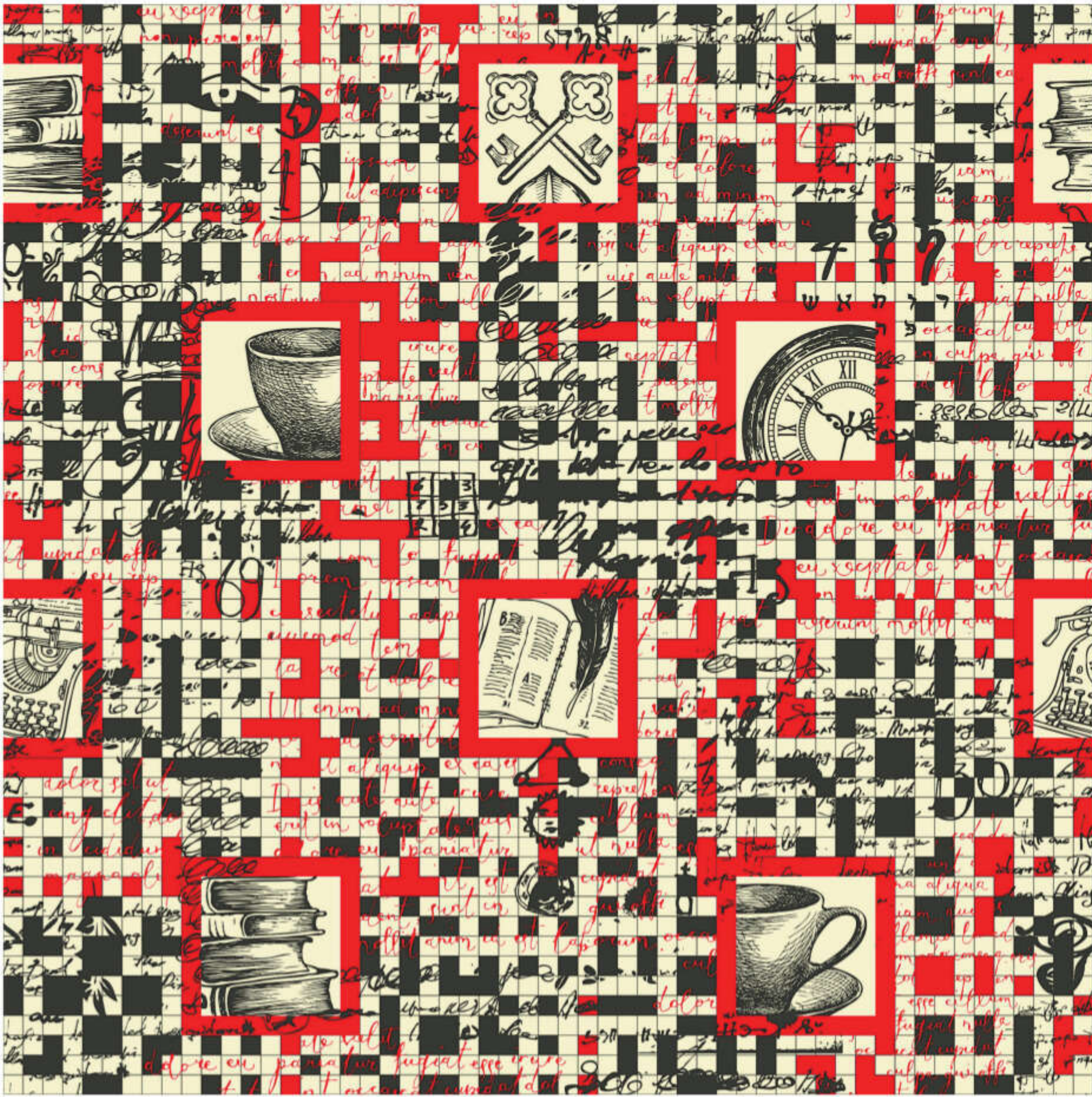
“You don’t want a big bowl of apples sitting for you. You also don’t want a tree that is not going to give you any fruits. There are some low-hanging fruits that give you the courage to keep climbing up the tree. Ultimately, it needs to be this slow surrender of delightful apples,” says Astle, who has had an illustrious career as a TV anchor, radio host and author.

Simultaneously, the 64-year-old has been setting puzzles for publications such as *The Sydney Morning Herald*, *The Age*, *The Canberra Times* among others, although his “gateway drug” into this world was riddles.

Speaking of riddles, do you have the answer yet?

A good puzzle is as much a dopamine hit for the solver as it is for the setter, whose ultimate goal is to create a “satisfying play”, achieved with clever clues, fresh angles, snappy language, smart wordplay, all leading up to juicy answers. This much sought-after satisfaction depends not simply in solving the crossword but also in the fewer hints one requires to reach the goal.

At *The Times* (UK), for instance, the qualification for a setter is not so much the list on their resume. “We look for people



GETTY IMAGES



SCAN THE QR CODE TO SOLVE A CROSSWORD

who can write good, fair, concise clues but also have a very good, plausible surface meaning,” says Mick Hodgkin, Puzzles Editor at *The Times*.

The other non-negotiable quality of a good puzzle is its ability to evoke a triumphant chortle. “I would like to make the solvers laugh at some point,” adds 66-year-old Hodgkin, recalling a funny crossword clue he liked. It was ‘Fly back from China in 747?’ The answer? TANG, referencing the dynasty.

Ben Tausig of the AVCX (American Values Club), an independent puzzles and games outlet, agrees, “Above all else, is the puzzle funny? We want ideas that will put a smile on people’s faces.”

Clues Beyond Borders

Shortz, Astle and Hodgkin began, first solving and then, setting puzzles in a different time. Each of them discovered their passion in their local newspapers as young boys. At the time, it was unlikely for a person in the UK to read an American or Australian newspaper. Besides, the clues were often local references that people outside the community or geography would not necessarily understand. For instance, referring to the Brooklyn-Manhattan transit as BMT.

Today, we live in a different world. Out of the 13.35 million total subscribers of NYT Games as of mid-2026, over three million live outside the US, which means that while the lived knowledge of culture still remains largely elusive, the chances of a non-American accessing a crossword appearing in an American paper have massively increased. This realisation has pushed setters to expand — albeit gradually and often relying on stereotypes — their scope of inspiration to a more inclusive knowledge base, spanning age, culture and even gender.

Clues referencing Indian food items, cities and personalities frequently reappear in NYT and *The Times* (UK) crosswords. A Naan is: Indian flatbread; Sari: Traditional women’s draped garment; Assam: Northeastern Indian state known for tea and silk production. A memorable double-meaning clue for the answer (Mahatma) ‘Gandhi’ in *The Times* (UK) was: Indian spinner who played a leading role in getting England out.

Most of AVCX solvers are American, closely followed by British, based in Australia, New Zealand, Germany and other European countries. Asia, including India, also contributes significantly to their subscriber base, which is why their sports clues often vary between baseball and cricket. “There will be quite a lot of cricket references, which probably don’t bother our Indian solvers but the Americans might go, ‘What’s this?’” Tausig says.

To Each their Own

Like most setters, Tausig, 45, started doing crosswords as a hobby, eventually crossing over to the other side. For him, setting crosswords became a medium of expression when he couldn’t see the voice of his own generation in the puzzles he was solving. “A lot of crosswords felt like they were for people who were old.” That led Tausig to found AVCX in 2006, which either presents traditional topics with a new vocabulary or refer to more recent pop-culture phenomena like Taylor Swift, which “some of the older solvers may not know about.”

What differentiates AVCX from legacy newsroom crosswords — representing a uniform, largely objective, non-political stance of the organisation — is the unique voice of the setter. This means that conventionally the solution to the crosswords would draw heavily from general knowledge rather than opinion. With AVCX, it is the opposite. “Puzzles always have some kind of a point of view. Our politics are pretty liberal,” Tausig says. One of their visibly opinionated clues was published in 2016 after Donald Trump was elected president (first term): “Fascist-leaning reality TV star who won the electoral college in 2016.”

Patti Varol, editor, *Los Angeles Times* Crossword, likes to believe that their puzzles are “completely apolitical” but admits letting her own bias guide what is acceptable and what is not. While she hopes to remain “non-controversial”, she refuses to not represent the LGBTQ community in her puzzles. “My goal and my job is to make sure that anybody can pick up the paper and feel included. That means I’m going to acknowledge the existence of different pronouns, choices and colours and the whole messy spectrum of human life,” she says, adding, “If you’re triggered by the existence of trans people, I can’t help you.”

Gender Matters

When it comes to gender, the world of puzzles is not very different. It has traditionally been a male-dominated field, with few women editors, but when their voice does seep through the puzzles, it makes all the difference.

A woman setter is more sensitive. Varol gives an example: It was women who started clueing Ina (Garten) to reflect the renowned chef as a person — (Be My Guest With _ Garten), and not as the modifier phrase — ‘in a’ (_ manner of speaking, Garten), often used by male setters.

India’s Sowmya Ramkumar, who has set crosswords for several publications, including *The Hindu*, *The Boston Globe* and *Gulf Weekly*, and is the founder of IACross, an independent online platform of cryptic crosswords, likes to indulge in a bit of mis-

chief every now and then. One of her favourite pranks to play as a setter is to use female pronouns in clues for professions that have both male and female personnel — doctors, lawyers, economists. “Most solvers immediately make a male association with these professions, so a female pronoun throws them off, taking them longer to solve,” says the Bahrain-based setter.

In the Time of AI

It is, thus, the individuality of each setter that makes a puzzle one of a kind. As technology — which has helped create a global community of puzzlers — slowly takes over different industries, the inevitable question remains: Can a machine set and solve puzzles?

Yes, it can. Like humans? The unanimous verdict: No. At least, not yet.

The black-and-white grid became auto-

With internet, people across the world can access crosswords appearing in papers in different countries, pushing setters to make their clues more inclusive, across cultures and age groups

mated long ago, but technology, particularly AI, has a lot of ground to cover as a setter of cryptic crosswords. An improved version of Dr Fill, a computer programme, beat humans at solving quick crosswords in 2021 but, as Indian setter Tony Sebastian says, “AI may now construct a full NYT-style crossword. What it still cannot really do is set good cryptic clues.”

John Henderson, whose extraordinarily challenging puzzles have appeared in *The Independent*, *The Times* and *The Guardian*, recalls *The Times* Crossword Championship in London in 2024. “The AI application (Crossword Genius) solved five of the six puzzles to qualify into the finals. The one it could not crack was mine.”

Perhaps, because a good puzzle isn’t just about words. It requires an understanding of human behaviour — what they are likely to assume, what will crack them up and ultimately, what will win them over.

One of Sebastian’s most outrageous feats as a setter was a crossword in *The Hindu* that doubled up as a marriage proposal to his now wife, Rosanna Jacob. While the clues alluded to different aspects of a wedding, the first letters of each clue formed the question: “Rosanna Jacob, will you marry me?”

Riddle answer: Crossword

THE WORD
THIS WEEK



Fractured lives retold

IN SEPTEMBER 1947, as communal fires spread across Delhi, they consumed the library of one Salihah Abid Husain but could not extinguish her words. In the middle of the madness she calls *hunger*, she recorded all she saw much like a journalist, much to the consternation of her husband. *7 from 1947: First-hand Stories* by Husain, collects six visceral *afsanas*, first published in Urdu as *Niras Mein Aas* (1948) and dedicated to Mahatma Gandhi. It now has a new English translation by former Planning Commission member Syeda S Hameed.



WHAT I READ
THIS WEEK

In the old,
the here
and now

Mary Beard's *Talking Classics* is a meditation on the thrill of discovering that the past is familiar yet strange

Kaushik Das Gupta

WHEN MARY Beard was five, a curator at the British Museum took a 4,000-year-old piece of Egyptian bread out of its glass case and held it close enough for her to see. The sight of an ordinary object, made by and for an ordinary person in a world unimaginably distant from her own, evoked in the child what the ancient Greeks referred to as “thauma”. Literally translated, the word means “wonder” or “wonderment”. But, as Beard says, “thauma was a loaded ancient catch phrase.” There was also “an element of the wow factor” in her experience.

That encounter offers a fitting entry point into *Talking Classics: The Shock of the Old*, a slim volume by the world's most distinguished classicist, which I read last week. It's a wonderful meditation on the thrill of discovering that the distant past is neither dead nor settled. It can still surprise us. Beard does not treat antiquity as a mausoleum of great texts, marble statues and heroic men. She is drawn to the ordinary and often overlooked objects and fragments that allow us to glimpse how people actually lived. A piece of bread carries the physical trace of an individual life across four millennia.

Based on lectures delivered at the Universities of Chicago and Edinburgh, the book is a defence of the classics. But Beard has never been given to veneration. She has little interest in arguing that the ancient Greeks and Romans possessed timeless wisdom. Nor does she present the classical world as the uncontested foundation of Western civilisation. She is more interested in what happens when we look closely at the past and discover that it is simultaneously familiar and strange.

That tension explains the subtitle: *The Shock of the Old*. “Thauma requires brain work as well as wide eyes,” Beard writes. “Wondering what the past is, how to describe it, treading the tightrope between the idea that inhabitants of the past were just like us and the idea that they were incomprehensibly alien pushes to the very frontiers of understanding.” The “shock of the old” comes from discovering that the past is never quite what we thought it was.

That is an especially precious proposition at a time when the classics are routinely summoned into arguments about cultural identity. Beard is alert to the uses — and abuses — of antiquity. Greek and Roman culture has been appropriated by fascists, nationalists and defenders of a narrowly defined “Western Civilisation”. But she also refuses the opposite temptation of throwing the classical inheritance away because it has been misused. Nobody has first rights to the past. That is why it can be examined, questioned and contested by everybody. And that's why Beard speaks not just to the West, but to every part of the world where the invocation of civilisational unity today is flattening social complexities.

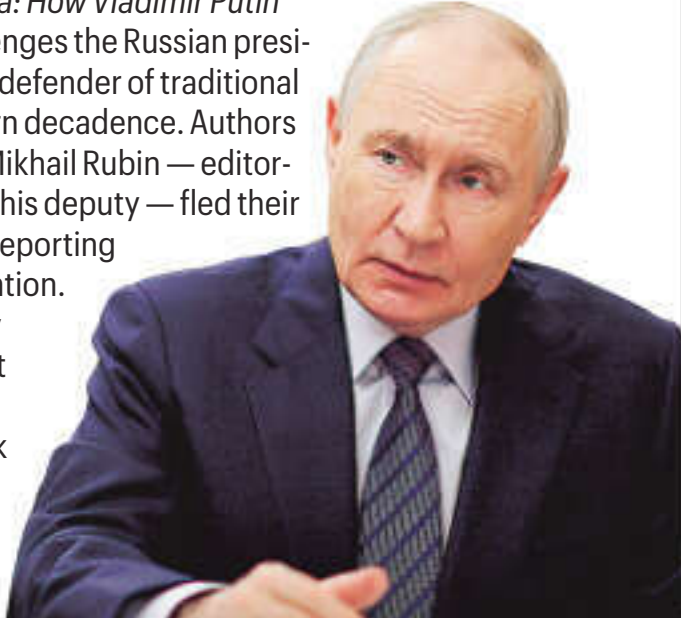
The ancient world, Beard suggests, does not provide ready-made lessons in liberty or democracy. It provides something more interesting: evidence of how easily ideals can coexist with their violation. Beard does not conceal the brutality of classical societies — the slavery, misogyny and extraordinary violence — but neither does she claim that acknowledging these things makes the studies of classics irrelevant.

Beard's feminism and scepticism have subtly reshaped the study of the classical tradition, long presented as an inheritance handed down by eminent men to subsequent generations of eminent men. She has widened the frame, asking who gets remembered, who gets to interpret the past and how supposedly timeless classics have themselves been shaped by changing societies. “Ancient history,” she says, “shines a troubling spotlight onto the here and now too, asking us to face what the judgment of the future on us will be.”

Beard invites us not simply to love the classics, but to let them unsettle us. That sense of curiosity, more than any claim of “timeless values”, may be the best reason to try and understand the past — and continue to look at it afresh.

Putin exposé wins French prize

TWO RUSSIAN investigative journalists, exiled to the US and fearing for their lives, have just won a major French prize for a book that dismantles Vladimir Putin's carefully crafted image. *The Tsar in Propria Persona: How Vladimir Putin Deceived Us All* challenges the Russian president's projection as a defender of traditional values against Western decadence. Authors Roman Badanin and Mikhail Rubin — editor-in-chief of *Proekt* and his deputy — fled their homeland after their reporting drew dangerous attention. The prize, awarded by EBRA, France's largest regional newspaper group, called the work “fascinating and shocking.”



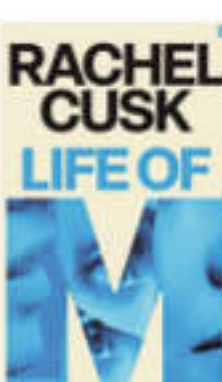
To the rescue of liberal democracy

DEMOCRACY IS in crisis. Elitism, intolerance and rising autocracy have eroded liberalism's promise of shared prosperity and equality. But Nobel laureate Daron Acemoglu is not ready to give up. In *What Happened to Liberal Democracy?* (Hachette India), the MIT economist and co-author of the landmark *Why Nations Fail* charts the decay, and then offers a roadmap for renewal. “The path charted by technology is not destiny; it is a moral and political choice,” writes Nobel laureate Esther Duflo. As democracies teeter worldwide, Acemoglu's urgent message arrives just in time.



Is autofiction exploitative?

THERE IS a new buzzword that is making its way through the literary corners of the internet: autofiction. Rachel Cusk's controversial new novel, *Life of M*, has put the spotlight on this genre that blends autobiography with fiction. The controversy centres on the character ‘M’ whose life and filmography suspiciously resemble the actor Natalie Portman, and unflatteringly. To add fuel to fire, Portman has previously called Cusk one of her favourite writers. The question critics are asking is should the ambiguity of a literary assassination shield the writer from being held liable. Cusk dismisses the work as fiction, but is it not exploitative to write the life story of another in a fresh package? The novel's refusal to clarify, paired with Portman's known admiration, invites a difficult question: Does the slippage between fact and fancy license a particularly insidious form of borrowing, one that trades on real goodwill while disavowing any debt?



Inside Trump's Second Act

Regime Change takes readers behind closed doors to reveal how personal grievance, political vengeance and the pursuit of power have shaped Trump 2.0

Saptarshi Basak

IF THERE was ever any doubt that journalism is the first rough draft of history, a recent book on the first year of US President Donald Trump's second term should dispel it for good. Maggie Haberman and Jonathan Swan's *Regime Change: Inside the Imperial Presidency of Donald Trump* describes, in nailing detail, the authoritarian, corrupt and morally degraded workings of the Trump administration since his re-election. Spanning more than 450 pages, the book is a treasure trove of evidence and information that, decades from now, will be an invaluable record of how American democracy, in the year of its 250th birthday, was tested, and how the institutions of the world's most powerful country were bent to the will of one man.

The book is hardly an easy read; its pages are dense with reporting. But *Regime Change* excels at what it sets out to do: reveal, with almost breathtaking access, what happens behind the closed doors of the Trump administration. Haberman and Swan have got themselves deep inside the President's world — government, advisers, friends and his inner circle. From the opening chapter, which recounts what Elon Musk referred to as “first-class grovelling” text messages sent by Mark Zuckerberg and Jeff Bezos, to the final chapter, which takes readers into the Situation Room on February 11, when Benjamin Netanyahu persuaded Trump to launch an attack on Iran, the book offers a fly-on-the-wall account of power.

What sets *Regime Change* apart from the daily torrent of Trump coverage is that their reporting goes beyond what happened in public: Conversations in the Oval Office, the Situation Room and private meetings are pieced together, often cross-checked against multiple accounts. The result is a granular portrait of how decisions are made. The book is also very much about Trump himself: his obsessions, tantrums, transactional instincts and greed. Much of this inevitably rests on anonymous sourcing.

The book's structure is straightforward, divided into four sections: ‘Whirlwind’, ‘Retribution’, ‘The Enemy Within’ and ‘Plunder’. ‘Whirlwind’ captures Trump's “flood the zone” strategy — the deliberate unleashing of a relentless stream of news, announcements and executive actions, leaving the media and his opponents scrambling to keep up. The authors show how that impulse translated into action: hundreds of executive orders and sweeping decisions on immigration, DOGE, tariffs, Gaza, Ukraine and USAID, among much else. The point was not simply to govern at speed but to move faster than the institutions meant to check the President could

respond. The consequences of that whirlwind are still unfolding.

It is the second section, ‘Retribution’, however, that strikes most directly at the heart of Trump's personality: What does the person occupying the most powerful office in the world do with that power? In Haberman and Swan's telling, he turns personal grievance into institutional policy. That is the essence of the longest of the book's four sections, and naturally so, given Trump's rather overt campaign against those he believed had wronged him. As the two reporters write, “by publicly marking individuals or entities for retribution by decree, and having his targets crumble in anticipation of such attacks, Trump had effectively opened up a new front for the second term, terrorising his foes.” Prosecutors, political opponents, media figures, law firms and others who had crossed Trump in one way or another in the past all found themselves in his sights. Also reported on is Trump's suspicious relationship with the late convicted sex trafficker Jeffrey Epstein, the Justice Department's handling of the Epstein files, and the deepening divisions within the MAGA coalition.



POWER GAMES
US President Donald Trump outside the White House



REGIME CHANGE:
INSIDE THE
IMPERIAL
PRESIDENCY OF
DONALD TRUMP
MAGGIE HABERMAN,
JONATHAN SWAN
Simon and Schuster UK
496 pages
₹999

‘The Enemy Within’ is the most politically consequential section. The authors make it clear that Trump does not conceive of foreign powers such as China, Russia or Iran as his primary rivals, but Americans inside the United States — particularly the Left and institutions associated with it — as his enemies. After the murder of Charlie Kirk, Trump reportedly told reporters that “we just have to beat the hell” out of “radical Left lunatics.” For Trump, political opposition became an internal security problem.

The final section, aptly titled ‘Plunder’, is all about the monetisation of Trump's presidency — because, as the authors make clear, “throughout his life, Donald Trump had monetised everything he could.” Although the section opens with the world of crypto, it moves through land deals in the West Asia, the FIFA Peace Prize and oil in Venezuela. It ends, however, with some of the book's most important reporting: the account of Netanyahu in the Situation Room two weeks before Operation Epic Fury, when Vice-President JD Vance, CIA Director John Ratcliffe and Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Dan Caine all expressed scepticism about going to war

with Iran. The course of events has proven them right.

India doesn't get many mentions in the book, and when it does, there is a tone of sneering condescension, particularly over money and tariffs — a tone that sits alongside the continuing difficulties in reaching a trade deal... And during a discussion of the possibility of deploying international peacekeepers in Ukraine, Trump says, “The Indians won't do that, they won't pay for something like that,” adding, “The Indians don't ever pay for anything.” India, in fact, has a long and respected record of contributing troops to United Nations peacekeeping missions. But for a president who has confused Albania with Armenia, expecting him to keep track of peacekeeping, perhaps, is asking too much.

Overall, *Regime Change* is an essential read for anyone seeking to understand the first year of Trump 2.0 — and, perhaps more importantly, a book worth keeping on the shelf for the next two-and-a-half years. For all that has happened, and for all that Haberman and Swan document in extraordinary detail, remember that we are not even halfway through Trump's presidency.

The House That Democracy Built

Sobhana Nair's *Housing the Republic* is an evocative history of India's old Parliament House — and of the democratic culture that flourished within its circular walls

John Brittas

HOUSING THE Republic by Sobhana Nair is no ordinary architectural history, but a love letter to a building that once held the soul of India's democracy — the old Parliament House, now rechristened Samvidhan Sadan — and to the turbulent, intimate, imperfect institution that grew within its circular walls.

Jairam Ramesh's foreword sets a startling tone. He invokes Joseph Goebbels's 1928 declaration about entering the Reichstag “to use the arsenal of democracy in order to assault it with its own weapon.” It's a comparison that underscores the political transformation of India's parliamentary space into a field wide open for the Executive's play.

The book unfolds as both an elegy and an inquiry, tracing how a colonial Council House became the heart of a Republic and how its physical form shaped, and was

shaped by, the politics conducted inside it. She has done justice to the Capital city too. Lord Hardinge, the largely forgotten architect of New Delhi's conception, emerges as a pivotal figure. His arrival in India was almost comic: He missed his train in London and reached Bombay 16 days later as the 13th Viceroy. Yet, he refused to let the new Capital resemble an ordinary British cantonment.

The design of the Parliament building was a drama of clashing temperaments. Edwin Lutyens was imaginative, idealistic, sometimes impractical; Herbert Baker was pragmatic. The final building was a compromise — Baker's three-part arrangement set within Lutyens' circular form. The circular corridor, according to the author, is among the building's most democratic spaces — a place for photographs, tea, gossip, and the informal politics that no chamber could contain. The new Parliament, which often feels like a



WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

VIEW FROM
THE TOP
The new
Parliament
building

grand mall, doesn't have such a space.

The historic Central Hall functioned as the backstage where party colours faded and common problems of public expectation briefly united rivals. When the new Parliament opened without an equivalent space, the complaint was not mere nostalgia; it was the loss of a physical condition that had sustained cross-party politics. Imperfect acoustics and cramped seating produced a living, argumentative body rather than a managed spectacle. In the new building, members are divided and they withdraw to numerous echo chambers.

Nair meticulously narrates the evolution of the Parliament House from a building that once upon a time housed multiple arms of democracy, including the Supreme Court, Election Commission and even the Princes' Chamber. All these organisations later found their own abodes. Three complexes were

added — Library building, Parliament House Annexe and Annexe extension — in due course but never found mention when lack of space was discussed.

Nair has written about her interface with incidents, including the Parliament House attack that eventually made the building inaccessible for the common man. The CISF now controls entry points that once fell more clearly under the Speaker's authority. The complex has grown “like an amoeba,” swallowing surrounding roads.

The new building occupies a triangular site, set at a respectful distance from the old circle. Visual continuity is retained — green for Lok Sabha, red for Rajya Sabha, peacock motifs, *jaali* light — but the human scale has changed; members sit further apart.

Architecture, Nair reminds us, is never neutral. It can stabilise a new order by giving it a physical form around which to gel, as Charles Goodsell argued. Yet, as Ambedkar warned, a good Constitution can be made to work badly by those who operate it, and hero-worship in politics remains a road to degradation. The building itself cannot protect democracy; only the people who inhabit its chambers and the public who claim it as their own, can do that.

The old building's imperfections helped create a parliamentary culture of friction and improvisation. The new one is larger, better equipped, more orderly. Whether that order deepens democratic life remains an open question. As the two buildings sit close enough to feel like a conversation frozen in stone with only a thin sliver of sky slipping between them, India's democratic experiment continues.

Brittas is a Rajya Sabha MP from CPI(M)

Anuparna Roy, who returns to the Venice Film Festival with her second film, on mining the personal, casting friends and the struggle of those on the margins

Alaka Sahani

GROWING UP, writer-director Anuparna Roy was fascinated by Ameena, an elderly domestic help at her grand-uncle's home in Purulia, West Bengal. Once her daily chores were done, Ameena would smoke *bidis* and while away her time trying to catch fish in the pond. As a child, Roy often wondered why Ameena spent so little time with her husband Kareem. Years later, she realised that Kareem was gay and that their marriage was his way of feeling accepted by society.

Roy's sophomore feature, *Lovers in the Blue Night*, explores the desires of those caught in such situations. She reimagines Ameena and Kareem's story in present-day Mumbai, portraying them as migrants. With this film, Roy returns to the Venice International Film Festival (September 2-12), competing again in the Orizzonti Competition, a year after she became the first Indian filmmaker to win the Best Director Award in the segment for her debut feature, *Songs of Forgotten Trees*.

Talking about how her childhood memories became the foundation of her latest work, the 28-year-old shares, "I don't forget people, places and stories. If anyone shares their story, that stays with me." These memories eventually lead to something exciting: a personal cinematic narrative. This, however, keeps changing shape until she is done with the editing. Her drafts undergo multiple revisions. Scenes are chopped during editing. "Film-making is unpredictable. You cannot even rely on your own narrative completely. Before I start the shoot, I have a certain idea. It changes later on. What I write and how it finally turns out is different. That surprises me all the time," she says.

Before Roy discovered world cinema in her early 20s, she was deeply influenced by her maternal grandmother, who often told her stories of the river. The very first film that moved her was Ritwik Ghatak's *Meghe Dhaka Tara* (1960). "Ghatak literally shook me with his realism," she confesses. Subsequently, a number of movies, including *The Color of Pomegranates* (1969), *The Revenant* (2015), *Roma* (2018), *The Zone of Interest* (2023) and *Haider* (2014) left their mark on her. Though she was profoundly impacted by movies, she has not studied filmmaking. What helped her pick up the technical aspects of the craft was working



‘I don’t forget people, places and stories’

with her filmmaker friends. Both her features are deeply personal and bear her signature touch as she takes an incisive look at people who live on the margins and search for intimate connections.

However, finding funding for such films is not easy. "After I narrated my first feature, a producer told me nobody was going to sit through my film. A friend reassured me saying that there are elements in the film that are personal and no one else has experienced what I have. That gave me the confidence to save money and start working on *Songs of Forgotten Tree*," says Roy, who worked for two IT companies without her employers' knowledge to raise money for the film. After she got caught, her father chipped in. *Songs of Forgotten Tree* follows Thooya, a migrant and aspiring actress, who secretly works as a part-time sex worker in Mumbai. When she sublets her flat to Sweetha, a call-centre employee and a migrant, they form an unexpected connection.

Once *Songs of Forgotten Trees* was selected for the Venice Film Festival, Khan and Kumar Media, founded by Sharib Khan and Vikas Kumar, came on board as co-producers and funded its post-production. "After winning the Orizzonti award at Venice, I had money and producers. Khan and Kumar signed me for my next film,"

A TELLETALE
A still from *Lovers in the Blue Night*; (right) director Anuparna Roy



says Roy. Set in Mumbai, *Lovers in the Blue Night* follows four migrants — a closeted husband, his lonely wife who works in a bar, a small-time thief and a pimp — whose lives intersect through unexpected love, survival and forbidden desire.

What lends Roy's work a touch of authenticity is her approach to casting. "It is personal. I don't believe in casting someone who I don't know. I want to work with my friends. It is like giving chances to the bestest people so that your work gets easier and you are at peace," she elaborates. There are times she changes the scene or dialogue on set, and having friends as her actors helps. The film's ensemble cast fea-

“It can be seen as a narcissistic approach. I can be truthful about what I have experienced and felt. If I’m writing with somebody or if I’m writing someone else’s story, I might not be able to do justice to it”

tures Neelima Sharma, Pritam Pilania, Bhushan Shimpi, Jatin Sarin, Kajal Keshav and Vinod Suryavanshi.

For Roy, the constant struggle is to write and create something that has not yet been delivered. Going forward, she plans to make a few more personal films. "It can be seen as a narcissistic approach. But I can be truthful about what I have experienced and felt. If I'm writing with somebody or if I'm writing someone else's story, I might not be able to do justice to it," she says. The two stories that she plans to tell next are about a couple in a long but dysfunctional marriage and a coming-of-age drama that talks about sexual awakening.

Guns, Roses, and Feathers

Karan Johar's stylist Eka Lakhani on designing the campy costumes of *Traitors* Season 2 and collaborating with the filmmaker through his style evolution over the years

Devansh Sharma

THE DEVIL really exists in the details, essentially when it comes to Karan Johar's wardrobe in *The Traitors*. If Season 1 of Amazon Prime Video's reality show saw the filmmaker embrace the excess, Season 2 is all camp on steroids. "Karan can wear a lot of capes. He can easily switch from being a director to an actor to a talk show host to an award show host to a reality show host. I haven't seen anyone be so at ease with who they are when they are doing such different things," says stylist Eka Lakhani, in an exclusive interview.

The Language through the Wardrobe

Of all the many roles Johar takes on with ease, *Traitors* is perhaps the furthest removed from his real-life persona. Somewhere, it feeds into his perceived image as Bollywood's dictatorial ruler, a persona he briefly embraced in Aryan Khan's *The Baatals of Bollywood* on Netflix last year. "*Traitors* already carries a little bit of that crime thriller aspect to it within the reality show spectrum. Karan wanted his wardrobe to be very different from what he wears on *Koffee with Karan* or any other reality show he has done. We wanted *Traitors* to have the language of Karan not being himself, but becoming the character he is on *Traitors*. You'll see it happen not only with his wardrobe, but also with his personality. You don't see him chirpy and goofing around like he usually does," says Lakhani.

It's probably the camp aesthetic of *Traitors* that helps Karan get an entry point into that personality. "We wanted to keep the opening episode somewhere in the 'love and war' space. Which is why you see him with a black robe with roses on it. That's when we introduced his cat, Boo. I don't know if you noticed it, but when Boo is introduced, he has a collar with a rose on it. In that episode,

we see his second change where all his roses are gone, and he's just kept one big rose with him," says Lakhani.

Another look that captured the audience's attention is the black overcoat with a cape designed like crow feathers. Lakhani claims that it's being called the "Moiré Rose outfit", referring to the iconic crow-inspired costume worn by the late Catherine O'Hara in the popular comedy show *Schitt's Creek*. "We wanted to add that extra layer of mystery to the oath ceremony, just that feeling of hiding in the shadows," says Lakhani. Another look had blood-red splattering all across his white robe. "When there was a murder in the episode, we thought let it be all about blood. We didn't want it to be aesthetically spread blood but just blood splattered all over," she adds.

Not too many filmmakers in India can pull off these looks. The shock value of that wardrobe is so high that the polarising response is almost embroidered into the look. "We're okay with getting comments that they don't get the look. It's a high-impact look designed to make some noise," says Lakhani.

The Lakhani-Johar Connection

Ironically, Lakhani's collaboration with Johar began with his least glamorous film — *Lust Stories* (2018) on Netflix. The short film, starring Kiara Advani and Vicky Kaushal, was too small for Karan's go-to costume designer Manish Malhotra. Which is when he roped in Lakhani, best known for her work in stylised yet rooted cinema such as Santosh Sivan's *Urumi* (2011) and *Ceylon* (2013), Mani Ratnam's *Kadal* (2013) and *Kaatru Veliyidai* (2017) in Tamil; *24* (2016) in Tamil as well; *Gulaab Gang* (2014); *NH10* (2015); and *Ok Jaanu* (2017) in Hindi.

"My association with Mani sir is what defines me. He gave me my first break," she says, "Whether I'm on a Mani Ratnam set, Karan Johar set or a Rajkumar Hirani set,



COAT OF MANY COLOURS
(Above) Costume stylist Eka Lakhani; Karan Johar in *Traitors* Season 2

I'm giving them what they want and the world they want to create. In the end, it's a director's medium. Their worlds are different, but they just want to show beauty in a certain way. I'm just adapting to their aesthetic." Lakhani was behind the muted yet gorgeous cotton saris for Kiara in *Lust Stories*. She married her background in design with Johar's cinematic aesthetic to give those saris a quintessential small-town flavour, without falling prey to the "raw and grunge" textures of realistic cinema.

Lust Stories was followed by Johar's segment in another Netflix anthology, *Ghost Stories* (2020), where Lakhani designed costumes for Mrunal Thakur and Avinash Tiwary. She landed her first feature with Johar three years later with *Rocky Aur Rani Kii Prem Kahaani* (2023). She considers the Rocky Randhawa-West Delhi wardrobe for Ranveer Singh in the family comedy as her favourite work for the actor, whom she continues to style till date. "It was actually Karan who pushed me towards styling. I had styled actors for promotions briefly. Karan gave birth to my parallel career of being a stylist,"

says Lakhani. Soon, she began styling Johar for all his public appearances. He has maintained that while the bling and the love for diamonds in both his and Singh's wardrobe stems from their Sindhi genes, he has gone through a style evolution of his own, switching to monochromes and all black.

Johar also agrees that despite his fashion sense, he couldn't have shaped his styling journey without her expertise. "Eka's skills as a stylist and curation of fashion is truly admirable. She has an old-world charm about how she approaches a garment," says Johar. "She has an immense ability to capture the right costume at the right moment. From her designing the costumes in my films to her styling me for the Met Gala, we have had an emotional and exceptional journey. I can't imagine being on a film set or at a big event without having Eka by my side," he adds.

For someone who shaped Shah Rukh Khan's wardrobe in the late 1990s, at the peak of his superstardom, it's safe to say that in Eka Lakhani, Karan Johar found what he didn't know he was looking for.

Layers of Becoming

Actor Nimisha Sajayan on gaining 14 kg for Babita Singh Reporting and why she wants to keep surprising herself with every role



AS REAL AS IT GETS
Nimisha Sajayan in *Babita Singh Reporting*; Nimisha (below)

Alaka Sahani

BEFORE ACTOR Nimisha Sajayan delved into the emotional journey of the titular protagonist in the film *Babita Singh Reporting*, she went through a physical transformation. She had to gain 14 kilos. It was one of the most challenging aspects of essaying the role of the people-pleasing assistant to sub-inspector (ASI) Babita Singh, aka Baby. The transformation changed everything — from her walk and body language to her food habits and the way she dressed. For the actor, it was a rewarding experience since it brought her "closer to the character".

Babita Singh Reporting joins a section of films and shows that are set in India's small towns and examines the lives of women, their ambitions and search for identity. It follows Babita who returns to her hometown of Rewa for a family function, after being suspended from duty. When her childhood friend Banshi, played by Barun Sobti, is found dead, she investigates his death despite resistance from those around her. This eventually nudges her to assert her identity and make her own choices. The film that released on Prime Video on August 28 is directed by Ambiecka Pandit, written by Amita Vyas and executive produced by Sudip Sharma.

"Baby is someone who always wants people around her to be happy. She often puts their needs before her own. Her realisation that it's okay to live the life she wants is very subtle. When Baby is going through this transformation, it's not very loud or heroic, but internal. We don't suddenly see her becoming a different person. That's the beauty of Baby, and that's going to resonate with most women," says Nimisha.

The 29-year-old actor, who made her acting debut with Dileesh Pothan-directed *Thondimuthalum Driksakshiyum* (2017), has been part of a number of

acclaimed films and shows, including *The Great Indian Kitchen* (2021), *Poacher* (2023) and *Dabba Cartel* (2025), in which she has played fascinating women characters who don't conform to prevalent mainstream moulds.

By her own admission, Nimisha "fell in love with Baby" when she first read the script. Calling herself "a greedy actor", she says, "I just wanted to experience Baby's journey. That's the reason I was ready to do anything for this role — from getting rid of my unibrow to gaining weight."

The journey of Babita Singh, believes Pandit, will make the viewers empathise with people "who struggle to find their voice and do not take up space because they don't feel welcome to."

Even though several actors, including Bhumi Pednekar for *Dum Laga Ke Haisha* (2015) and Aamir Khan for *Dangal* (2016), have gained weight to make the portrayal of a certain character authentic, this is not an easy choice. Yet, Nimisha took up the challenge. "It took me two months to gain around 14 kg. We started with 1,200 calories a day and eventually it went up to 8,000. It was a nightmare but I enjoyed the process. During the weight loss period, I felt as if a part of Baby was leaving me, mentally and physically," says the *Eeda* (2018) actor.

Commenting on such commitment to realistic storytelling, Sharma says, "This film would not be the same film without Nimisha agreeing to put on the weight. The same way a *Paatal Lok* would not be the same without Jaideep Ahlawat agreeing to put on that weight for the character of Hathiram. The process of transformation helps the actors under the skin of the character." Sharma is the creator of widely-praised shows *Paatal Lok* (2020) and *Kohrra* (2023).

While workshops helped Nimisha in shaping her character, on the sets she pushed herself to do physically-challenging scenes. In one scene, she jumps over a fence when dogs are chasing her. "For that scene, we had a stunt person on the set. We got the shot in a way that the stunt person's face was not visible. But I asked Ambiecka if I could give it a shot. She said we would do only one take. If we did not get it right, then we won't try anymore. However, we managed to get the shot," recalls Nimisha.

Some key scenes of *Babita Singh Reporting* feature Nimisha and Sobti, delivers a brief but compelling performance. Sharing how he roped in Sobti for the role, Sharma says, "When Barun was dubbing for *Kohrra* and we were taking a smoke break, I told him about *Babita Singh Reporting*. He agreed to do the film on the condition he was not going to be paid for it."

Talking about the kind of films that Nimisha has chosen to be part of, she says, "If a film is trying to convey something that reflects what's happening in the society, I would like to be part of that. However, I should agree to what kind of a message the film is trying to convey."

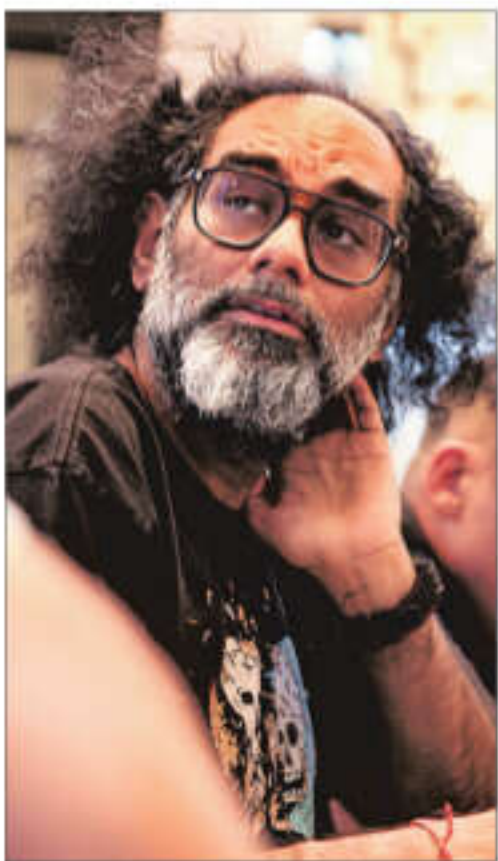
Does she have a dream role? "I have never played a negative character. I would love to play something like The Joker in *The Dark Knight*."



ON THE SETS, NIMISHA PUSHED HERSELF TO DO PHYSICALLY-CHALLENGING SCENES, INCLUDING WHERE SHE JUMPS OVER A FENCE WHEN DOGS CHASE HER

WHERE THE FOOD SINGS

With 22 courses, Gaggan Anand's long-awaited restaurant Raga in New Delhi has the most expensive tasting menu



COURTESY: RAGA

and warm. As at Gaggan Bangkok, the cutlery, crockery and serveware is sourced from Japan, down to a custom bento-style bowl-and-plate set carrying Indian floral motifs. Raga opened to the public on August 26, for dinner only, with 22 courses on offer. The menu is set to change thrice a year. At Rs 11,111 plus taxes, it is, by some distance, the most expensive tasting menu in India.

FULL PLATE (Clockwise from top left) Gaggan Anand; Rydo Anton; Charcoal mirchi; Lick it up; Golden egg

The Experience

The meal opens light: a slice of orange dusted with seasoning, then a gulaab khatta — a spin on kala khatta — with cherry sorbet and a disc of mangosteen pulp meant to be scooped like ice cream. Then there's Gaggan's famed yoghurt explosion, followed by a dish the servers won't let you see coming: a creamy walnut filled with brown chutney, meant to be eaten in one bite while you

guess what it is. We won't give away the answer, but the lingering mustard note that follows was one of the meal's high points. The first several courses arrive in quick succession, almost bombarding you with texture and colour, before the pace deliberately slows. There's pani puri disguised as egg, and an aloo bonda sandwich that is a small masterclass in sleight of hand — everything a bonda should be, except the toasted "bread" on top isn't bread, but onion meringue.

The charcoal course, a long-running signature, changes its filling every time it's served; this iteration uses local chillies, grilled and stuffed with cheese, warm enough that the kitchen warns you before you bite in.

The fish course — usually bhetki (Asian sea bass), lifted with mustard — arrives in a fish-shaped bowl. The vegetarian version, paneer layered with butternut squash in a Bengali mustard marinade, was the one

The 'brain' course on the tasting menu, the one Gaggan tells diners is made from rats, is actually cauliflower, styled to look uncannily like the real thing

course that didn't quite land; it needed something sharper to cut through the creaminess and sweetness. As for the "brain" course, the one Gaggan has, at various points, told diners is made from rats, is actually cauliflower, styled to look uncannily like the real thing.

The meal winds down with passion fruit-and-mango granita and a chamorro sauce, meant to evoke fruit carts, before dessert opens with another signature, "Lick It Up" with a Biscoff stem, coconut-pandan base and a charred pomegranate layer at the top.

Ask Gaggan why he chose Delhi, and he answers, "Because this is where I left cooking. It was here that I quit cooking in a hotel, and I started hating cooking. And now, 25 years later, here I am to prove myself."

While the tables are currently sold out for the coming days. We've heard some of the city's top companies are keen to book the entire space.



HEENA KHANDLWAL



CURATED BY SHINY VARGHESE

From feature walls to muted decor

A four-decade-old home gets a makeover

Sushmitha Ramesh

IN TIRUCHIRAPPALLI, on the banks of the Cauvery, is a 40-year-old home with wooden jaalis that was built by the client's parents that needed a renovation. When Chennai-based The Auburn Studio stepped in, they were told it would be "an exercise not in erasure but in continuity".

Living Room

The formal living room extends into the backyard. In the renovation, a sculptural feature wall clad in cement brings in subtle movement through soft waves and curves. The curved false ceiling arches are meant to conceal existing beams while adding fluidity to the space.



BEFORE



AFTER

Atrium

A central corridor connects two guest bedrooms on the eastern side to a dramatic double-height atrium that anchors the home spatially and visually. Stone, wood, and cement form the backbone of the renovation.

Dining Room

The dining space here strengthens the home's indoor-outdoor relationship. It was dressed in muted upholstery in keeping with the gentle, modernised way of living.

Bedroom

The master suite with a TV lounge, a sit-out garden, his-and-hers walk-in closets, and a skylit bathroom, is given a face lift with a restrained palette of colours and coordinates.

Architect Sushmitha Ramesh leads The Auburn Studio in Chennai



Neil Patil

Founder, COO & CTO, Veena World
neil@veenaworld.com

Nobody designs a hotel room to make a cultural statement. There is no committee that sits down and says, "Let us ensure this room reflects our national values." And yet, without fail, it does, every single time.

Through all my travels, I have come to believe that the fifteen minutes you spend alone in a hotel room after check-in - before you have unpacked, before you have connected to the Wi-Fi, before you have figured out how the shower works - tell you more about a country than any guidebook ever will. The bed, the bathroom, the minibar, the kettle, the slippers, the light switches, the things they assumed you would need and the things they assumed you wouldn't: it's all there, a country compressed into 25 square metres. Let me walk you through a few.

The Room That Thinks

Japanese hotel rooms are small, often startlingly small. You walk in, put your suitcase on the bed, and realise the suitcase is now touching both walls. The wardrobe is a shelf. The desk is a shelf with slightly different intentions. The window opens just enough to confirm that, yes, you are still in Japan.

And then you start noticing things. The toilet has a heated seat. It has a bidet with adjustable pressure and temperature. It has a button that plays the sound of running water so nobody in the next stall hears you. There are slippers by the door, placed at a precise 45-degree angle, toes pointing towards you so you can step into them without bending down, and separate slippers for the bathroom, because of course there are. The remote control for the TV has a button that shows you how to fold your yukata, the light cotton robe that Japanese hotels leave for every guest to wear around the room and down to breakfast. The shampoo, conditioner, and body wash are in identical bottles, but each has a different texture of raised dots on the cap so you can tell them apart in the shower with your eyes closed.

The room is small, but nothing has been left to chance. Every centimetre has been thought about by someone who cared. Japan's hotel rooms don't say "welcome." They say "we anticipated you."

The Room That Gives You More Than You Need

An American hotel room is three times the size of a Japanese one and about a third as considered. You walk in and there's space, a lot of space: a king-size bed that could sleep a family of four, a desk you will never use, an armchair you will use once, to throw your jacket on, a closet with eighteen hangers and an ironing board you will discover when you are looking for the safe, and two sinks in the bathroom.

Then there are the pillows. There are always too many - four, six, sometimes eight, arranged in layers like geological strata, and half of them end up on the floor within ten minutes. The ice bucket is prominently placed, because Americans have a relationship with ice that the rest of the world has never fully understood. There is a coffee maker with pods that produce something technically classified as coffee, and a TV with 200 channels and nothing to watch.

The American hotel room isn't about precision. It's about abundance. The room says: we may not have thought about the details, but we gave you a lot of everything, and if that's not enough, there's a vending machine down the hall.

The Room That Judges You Quietly

Scandinavian hotel rooms are a masterclass in elegant restraint. Everything is white, cream, or the colour of unbleached linen. The furniture is wood, pale and smooth, with no unnecessary ornamentation. The bed is low. The lighting is warm but dim, as if the room is gently discouraging you from staying awake past 9 PM. There is a single, beautifully designed lamp that looks like it belongs in a museum and provides roughly the same amount of light as a candle.

The minibar is where the cultural message becomes explicit. A small bottle of water costs what a full meal costs in Lisbon. A beer is priced like a bottle of wine. A bag of nuts is itemised like a luxury good. The minibar doesn't say "help yourself." It says "we trust you to exercise self-control."

The bathroom will have one excellent shampoo, one excellent conditioner, and one excellent soap, all



in refillable ceramic dispensers, because individual plastic bottles would be environmentally irresponsible. The towels are thick but not excessive: two per person, not twelve.

The Scandinavian hotel room is beautiful, calm, and ever so slightly disapproving. It wants you to be a better person during your stay. You find yourself making the bed before you leave, even though housekeeping will do it. The room has that effect.

The Room That Will Feed You No Matter What

Indian hotel rooms, across every price point, share one non-negotiable feature: a kettle. It might be a five-star suite in Udaipur or a business hotel in Pune, but there will be a kettle, sachets of instant coffee and tea, two cups, a small container of sugar, and powdered milk or, if the hotel is feeling generous, tiny sealed cups of liquid creamer. This is the baseline, the minimum commitment an Indian hotel makes to its guest: hot water will be available to you at all times.

Next to the kettle, there will be a laminated room service menu, and it will always, without exception, include dal, rice, a paneer dish, and a chicken dish. It doesn't matter if the hotel restaurant is Italian or if the lobby has a sushi counter - the room service menu knows

who you are. You have been travelling all day, it's 11 PM, and what you actually want is dal chawal. The menu anticipated this before you did.

The bathroom will have too many products: shampoo, conditioner, body wash, body lotion, shower cap, shaving kit, dental kit, sewing kit, shoe shine sponge, and a small bottle of mouthwash you may never open. Indian hotels don't do restraint. They do abundance with care. The assumption is that you might have forgotten something, and the hotel's job is to make sure that never becomes a problem.

The Indian hotel room says, clearly and warmly: we will take care of you. Sit down, have some chai - dinner is on page three.

The Room That Wants to Impress You

Gulf hotel rooms, particularly in Dubai and Abu Dhabi, operate on a different philosophy entirely. The room doesn't want to make you comfortable. It wants to make you feel important. The lobby will have a chandelier the size of a car. The hallway carpet will be thick enough to lose a shoe in. The room itself will be large, gold-accented, and aggressively air-conditioned. The bathroom will have marble - not marble-effect tiles, actual marble. The toiletries will be branded, possibly by a fashion house

you recognise.

There will be a welcome note, possibly handwritten, possibly accompanied by a plate of dates and Arabic coffee. The turndown service will leave chocolates and a folded towel shaped like a swan. The minibar will include items that seem to have been selected for visual impact rather than practical consumption: a gold-wrapped chocolate bar, a bottle of water with a label in calligraphy, a jar of macadamia nuts presented like jewellery.

The Gulf hotel room says: you are our guest, and guests are royalty. It's not subtle, but it's sincere, and after a few days, you start standing a little straighter.

Europe's Contradictions

European hotel rooms vary so wildly that generalisation is dangerous, but for our Sunday read, I am willing to risk a few.

Italian hotel rooms are romantic and slightly broken. The shutters don't close fully. The Wi-Fi works in the lobby but not in the room. The bathroom is gorgeous, but the shower head has two settings: scalding and off. None of this matters, because the view from the window is a terracotta roofline and a church bell, and you forgive everything.

British hotel rooms are apologetically small. There will be a kettle (the British and Indians agree on this point), biscuits, and a note explaining that the radiator is decorative rather than functional. The room says: we know this isn't ideal, but we are terribly sorry about it, and here's a custard cream.

Greek hotel rooms are white, simple, and have a balcony with a sea view that makes the room irrelevant. You check in, step onto the balcony, and don't go back inside until it's time to sleep.

What the Room Is Really Saying

The hotel room is the first honest conversation you have with a country. Not the airport, which is designed for efficiency. Not the taxi, which is designed for transit. The hotel room is where a country shows you what it thinks hospitality means.

Japan thinks hospitality means anticipating every need before you have it. America thinks it means giving you so much you couldn't possibly want more. Scandinavia thinks it means giving you exactly what you need and nothing extra. India thinks it means making sure you are fed. The Middle East thinks it means making you feel like the most important person in the building. None

ADVERTORIAL

of them are wrong - they are just different answers to the same question: what does a guest need?

So the next time you check into a hotel room anywhere in the world, just stand there for a minute. Look at what's been placed where, what's been included and what hasn't - the pillows, the kettle, the slippers, the minibar. The room is already talking to you. All you have to do is listen.

Know the Unknown

This week, since we're on hotel rooms, here's one that ties the two together.

Emirates flies an Airbus A380 with two fully functioning shower suites at 40,000 feet. Not a wet wipe - a real shower, with heated floors, Bvlgari toiletries, a vanity mirror, and five minutes of hot running water while cruising at 500 mph over the Indian Ocean. Each first class passenger gets one shower and up to thirty minutes in the suite. The showers sit at the front of the upper deck, in space too curved for seats - so Emirates turned dead space into a bathroom.

Here's what fascinates me. Airlines obsess over weight, shaving grams off everything to save fuel - yet Emirates loads hundreds of extra kilos of water onto every A380 flight just so fourteen passengers can shower midair. Economically, it makes no sense. As branding, it's genius: millions who'll never fly first class still associate Emirates with that shower. Remember what I said about Gulf hotel rooms - they're not about comfort, they're about making you feel important. This shower is that philosophy at altitude. See you next week...

Email: travel@veenaworld.com
Toll-Free: 1800 313 5555
veenaworld.com

